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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 19th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:33 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I hold in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 18th November, 2025 for correction.

Page 1...14—

Yes, First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on page 13, item 17, the name “Hon Nana Osei-Adjei” is to be replaced with “Hon Samuel Awuku”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table Office, take note.

Page 14...23—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on page 22, the item numbered 3, the name “Hon Samuel Awuku” is to be replaced with “Hon Nana Osei-Adjei”.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Table Office, take note.

Page 24? Yes, Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, sorry to take you back to page 22. Just for the records, I would want—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: From today, I will not have a reverse gear, but I will reverse to page 22 for you.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

The name should be Mahama Tiah Abdul Kabiru for the records, that is the item numbered 19.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table Office, take note.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 26...44—

Yes, Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings?

Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Here on page 42, the item numbered 7, under the list on the Committee on Defence and Interior, the name “Agyemang” should be without the letter

“g” at the end. That is the spelling of my name.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table Office, take note.

Page 43...73.

Hon Members, the *Vote and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 18th November, 2025 as presented and corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Friday, 7th November, 2025, is under correction. Hon Members, any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Friday, 7th November, 2025.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 6. Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

Mr Speaker, yes, the item numbered 6—It starts with the Minister of the Interior, who is not actually present yet. But we have two Ministers here, these are the Ministers for Lands and Natural Resources and Roads and Highways.

So, I would plead with you that we start with the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and then continue to fill the gaps.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So which Question do we start with?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: We have Question 458, which is the item numbered 7. We are looking at page 4, Question 458.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that the only Question?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes, that is for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Minister has already taken the designated seat. I will therefore call Question number 458, standing in the name of Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh, Member of Parliament for Nsawam/Adoagyiri.

12:43 p.m.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if you may indulge me, before we begin, I admit we had some engagement at Conclave.

Mr Speaker, because today we have lined up nine contributors to make statements on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented, and we have four sectors programmed for today, we are starting off by doing away with the Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Foreign Affairs. I am aware these two Ministers had written to Parliament and applied for today to be programmed for them to come and answer these Questions. So, if it is the case that we are beginning from the Minister for Lands

and Natural Resources which I do not have any objection to, what happens if the Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Foreign Affairs come? How are we going to navigate because the debate must also go on, and we also have the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yesterday, I indicated that in view of the fact that we have to take a lot of people to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, do we go with Questions? So once the Ministers are programmed, we can take their Questions, but I will plead with the House if we can limit supplementary questions to one. This is because to have about 10 Members from each Side speaking on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. We need not less than four to five hours.

Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, rightly so. We have quite a number of Questions today, and the debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy as well. So, as you have directed, we should restrict the supplementary questions to one so that we can get to all the programmed Questions as we have the Ministers here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the Questions are more than 20.

Yes? So, Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh, you have the floor.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I can start. However, if it becomes the case that we only deal with the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and the Ministry of Roads and Highways, then we can reprogram the rest, because you and I know typically when the debate is done, we are now going to have the estimates, the report will take a while. Then Table Office can reprogram the outstanding Questions to be taken when the House is less busy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Agreed. We would try as much as possible to take the Ministry of the Interior, Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and the Ministry of Roads and Highways. Yes, so you have the floor.

Hon Members, we should as well limit the comments to a supplementary question.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Cocoa Farms and Crops as a Preserve of the Forestry Commission

Mr Frank Annoh- Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, I am guided. I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources whether cocoa farms or crops have been selected as a preserve of only the Forestry Commission in the REDD+ programme, and the justifications for this.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) (MP): Mr Speaker, the idea of REDD+ (Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation) programme emerged from global efforts to address climate change under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). During the early 2000s, scientists highlighted that deforestation and forest degradation accounted for about 10 to 15 per cent of global greenhouse gas emissions. This made forest a critical area for climate change mitigation.

Mr Speaker, under the REDD+ programme, cocoa farms are not reserved for the Forestry Commission alone. The REDD+ programme, particularly the Ghana Cocoa Forest REDD+ Programme (GCFRP), is a collaborative effort that empowers farmers, private sector actors, and communities to participate in sustainable cocoa production and forest conservation. The Forestry Commission's role is therefore, regulatory and facilitative.

Mr Speaker, cocoa was selected as a key commodity in the REDD+ programme due to its significant impact on forest degradation and deforestation thus leading to emissions.

The Ghana Cocoa Forest REDD+ Programme (GCFRP), therefore, aims to:

Promote climate-smart cocoa production;

Integrate shade trees into cocoa systems;

Enhance farmer livelihoods while reducing emissions; and

Secure Ghana's forest reserves and biodiversity hotspots.

Mr Speaker, this will help reduce the rate of deforestation as a result of cocoa farming.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Annoh- Dompkeh: Mr Speaker, going by your earlier directives, may I ask the Minister, if there are exclusive programmes for private sector participation. I do not have time to elucidate, but what specific action lines has he undertaken or intend to undertake in facilitating the participation of private hands in the entire REDD+ programme? This will be my only question.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, as stated in my Answer, the REDD+ programme focuses not only on the cocoa sector, it also includes private sector actors. For example, in Ghana, we have Tounton, Rainforest Alliance, Mondelez, and others. We also have civil society organisations, farmer cooperatives and associations, and traditional authorities and local communities all focused on this programme. The Forestry Commission is actively engaged with them, supporting them, and facilitating these efforts with them. I thank you.

Mr Annoh- Dompkeh: Based on earlier directives, there are more issues, but I intend for the records to engage the Minister to get these matters sorted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am most grateful.

Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, fortified under Order 88(3), I seek your permission, and I have the authority of my Colleague, Mr William Ofori-Atta, to ask the Minister—since we are dealing with the issues of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is not his turn yet.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am sorry.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Question number 546 standing in the name of Mr Akwasi Konadu, MP for Manhyia North.

Measures being Implemented to Safeguard the Forest Plantation within the Tano-Offin Shelterbelt Forest Reserve

Mr Akwasi Konadu (NPP — Manhyia North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources what specific measures are being implemented by the Ministry in partnership with the Forestry Commission to safeguard the forest plantations established under the government's flagship Green Ghana

Project within the Tano-Offin shelterbelt forest reserve (Nkawie) where parts of the reserve are reportedly at risk due to the activities of illegal miners.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I wish to clarify that there is no forest reserve called Tano Offin Shelterbelt Forest Reserve. There are however the Tano Offin Forest Reserve and Offin Shelterbelt Forest Reserve.

Mr Speaker, the Green Ghana Initiative was introduced by the previous government with portions of the programme implemented within the Tano Offin Forest Reserve. The Ministry has since instituted comprehensive measures to ensure that all trees planted under this initiative receive the necessary care and maintenance. We have put in place elaborate programmes including regular monitoring by the Ministry and the Forestry Commission.

The Tano Offin Forest Reserve is also benefiting from tree maintenance activities being undertaken under the Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative introduced by this new Government. These efforts are aimed at nurturing the seedlings and promoting their optimal growth across the country.

Mr Speaker, it is also important to note that this forest reserve was part of the nine red zoned no go areas that have since been liberated and are out of the woods, falling into the yellow zoned category. This is because of the collaborative efforts between National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations

Secretariat (NAIMOS) and the Forestry Commission Forest guards.

12:53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Konadu: Yes, Mr Speaker. The Minister made me aware that it was one of the red zoned areas that has been liberated. So, I would want to ask if we have now permanently stationed men in there, such that there will be no opportunity for other individuals to go back in there to have their way in this forest reserve, so that it will not go back to whatever it was in the previous times?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, this is one of the areas that have had consistent incursions by illegal miners, and because of that, NAIMOS has identified that area as one of the areas that they are working to station people in that vicinity, working with the forest guards to ensure that it is protected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will now move to the Question numbered 460, standing in the name of Hon Duke Williams Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori Atta.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, the name is a combination of all names. Mr Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta — *[Laughter]*.

Mr Speaker, I have sought permission *supra*, so it is subject to you —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I do not know that it is a combination of all names. I know that it is the name of an Hon Member.

Please, you have the floor.

Establishment of 12,000 hectares of forest plantations and 500 hectares of reclaimed mined-out sites under the Afforestation and Reafforestation Programme (ARR)

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib on behalf of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources how the Forestry Commission plans to ensure the successful establishment of 12,000 hectares of forest plantations and 500 hectares of reclaimed mined-out sites under the 2025 robust Afforestation and Reforestation (ARR) Programme.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the ARR interventions this year are being undertaken under the Government's flagship Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative. The initiative was launched by the President on 21st March, 2025 with a target of 30 million tree seedlings this year under various tree planting components. The components of the Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative are:

Modified Taungya System (MTS)

Under the Modified Taungya System, a total of 5,895.3 hectares has been developed as at the end of August 2025. Planting is ongoing across the country,

and it is envisaged that the Modified Taungya System target of 10,000 hectares will be attained by the end of the Tree Planting Season.

Direct Planting by the Youth Forest Champions

As at the end of August 2025, 714 hectares of forest plantations has been established out of a target of 2,000 hectares.

Distribution of Tree Seedlings for Amenity Planting

A total of 2 million seedlings was targeted to be distributed. As at end of August 2025, 1,483,713 seedlings had been distributed.

Enrichment Planting

This component involves incorporation of high-value timber species within moderately degraded forest reserves. Under this component, a total of 1,310 hectares of enrichment planting has been undertaken nationwide against a target of 2,000 hectares.

Mr Speaker, with the reclamation and rehabilitation of mined-out areas, two large-scale mining companies in the Western North Region have rehabilitated a total of 18 hectares of mined-out areas. The Ministry is also in discussions with the Chamber of Mines and other private companies to undertake reclamation of degraded landscapes in forest reserves and agricultural landscapes off reserves.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Shaib: Yes, there will be just one supplementary.

Mr Speaker, I just want to find out from the respected Minister whether there is an extensive plan to reclaim more lands that have been mined up?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, indeed, the Ministry, working closely with the Forestry Commission and the Minerals Commission, intends to undertake a lot of land reclamation, which is why in the Answer, we talked about the fact that because of limitations of funds, we have reached out to the private sector. We are also working with the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, local authorities, especially Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs), to ensure, for example, that in the various districts, every district knows who has mined and failed to reclaim, and that they should collaborate with us to basically reclaim all these areas in all those districts. So, reaching out to the local government authorities, the private sector, and with the Government's own focus, we believe that we will do a lot of reclamation this coming year.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 519, standing in the name of Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw, Member of Parliament (MP) for Juaben.

Signed License for the Purchase and Export of Gold

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw (NPP — Juaben): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources whether the Ministry has signed licence for the purchase and export of gold since he assumed office.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, since assuming office as the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, I have issued two (2) licenses authorising the export, sale, or disposal of gold in connection with large-scale operations.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Owusu-Akyaw: Mr Speaker, based on the directives, I will engage the Minister further, so I will leave it here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 545, standing in the name of Mr Issah Salifu Taylor, MP for Takwa/ Nsuaem

Support of Small-Scale Miners in Tarkwa/Nsuaem to Transition to Sustainable and Legally Compliant Mining Practices

Mr Issah Salifu Taylor (NDC — Tarkwa/Nsuaem): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask Minister for Lands and Natural Resources how the Ministry is going to support small-scale miners in Tarkwa Nsuaem to transition to sustainable and

legally compliant mining practices to promote environmental protection and community development.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, Tarkwa/ Nsuaem has a number of licenced small-scale miners who are operating concessions in an environmentally friendly and sustainable manner. These operators have been engaged, educated, and trained in sustainable mining practices and are under constant supervision by the Minerals Commission to ensure they continue to operate in an environmentally sustainable manner through the use of sustainable mining practices and mercury-free processing technologies, such as the gold Kacha and Sika Bukyia, to safeguard the environment for use by the current and future generations. However, amid all these, there are some irresponsible illegal mining activities occurring in various areas such as Dompim, Simpa, Nsuaem, Bonsa, Bedukrom, Esuoso, and Asuogya, all within the Tarkwa-Nsuaem and its environs. To help mitigate the situation and to ensure sustainable and legally compliant mining practices, the Ministry, through the Minerals Commission, has put in place some interventions detailed below:

- i. Streamlining the licensing and permitting regime to shorten the time required for obtaining a small-scale mining license, thereby enhancing legal compliance. We are adopting the bottom-up approach through strengthening and supporting district mining committees and small-scale mining associations to play an effective role

in the licensing and management of small-scale mining operations at the local level.

- ii. Demarcation of more block-out areas for small-scale mining to ensure the availability of minable areas for small-scale operations, thereby curbing the tendency of encroachment on large-scale concessions and mining in unapproved areas.
- iii. Geological investigation of blocked-out areas for small-scale mining to delineate viable deposits to guide the operators and avoid the trial-and-error approach, which results in the destruction of the environment.

Mr Speaker, in line with this, the Minerals Commission, in collaboration with the Ghana Geological Survey Authority, is selecting additional areas for geological investigation to be blocked out for small-scale mining operations.

The Government, under the World Bank-supported Ghana Land Shape Restoration and Small-Scale Mining Project, is also undertaking a similar exercise.

- iv. The establishment of Cooperative Mining Schemes under the Responsible Cooperative Mining and Skills Development Programme (rCOMSDEP) — not only to transition illegal mining operations into a well-

coordinated and truly community-based mining ventures but also to provide alternative employment opportunities for community members, thereby boosting the local economy.

- v. Decentralisation of the Minerals Commission through the building and expansion of office facilities to accommodate more mine inspectors to facilitate licensing and provision of technical assistance to small-scale miners. A new office for the Tarkwa area is currently in an advanced stage of construction.

1:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, even as we roll out these interventions, our commitment to enforcement remains unwavering. In addition to the effort by the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS), we have deployed 1000 Blue Water Guards in specific areas to monitor and curb illegal mining activities on our river bodies. Furthermore, we continue to provide ongoing training and sensitisation for miners on best practices in responsible mining. The Tarkwa-Nsuaem area is no exception.

Mr Speaker, we believe the initiatives outlined above will facilitate the shift toward sustainable and legally compliant mining practices, fostering environmental stewardship and advancing community development

within the Tarkwa-Nsuaem area. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any further questions?

Mr Taylor: Mr Speaker, I would like to thank the Minister for his elaborative response.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, thank you very much for attending upon the House and responding to Questions scheduled for you. That is all for you for today. You are hereby discharged.

Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, the suggestion is to continue with the Question numbered 513 for the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is so, but Hon Members, permit me to acknowledge the presence of some revered guests in our midst.

The Chairperson of the All-Party Parliamentary Group for Ghana (APPG) of the United Kingdom Parliament has paid a visit to the Parliament of Ghana.

Hon Members, I have the pleasure to introduce to you a three-member delegation led by Hon Bell Ribeiro-Addy, the Chairperson of the All-Party Parliamentary Group for Ghana (APPG) of the United Kingdom Parliament. They are in Parliament to engage with the Members of the Ghana-United Kingdom Parliamentary Friendship Association.

Their engagement aims to explore opportunities for collaboration on shared priorities between Ghana and the United Kingdom, particularly in the areas of trade, and to further strengthen the longstanding cooperation that has characterised our inter-parliamentary relations.

Hon Members, our visitors are Hon Bell Ribeiro Addy MP, Clapham and Brixton Hills, and Chairperson, All-Parliamentary Party Group for Ghana. Hon Diane Abbott, MP, Hackney North and Stoke Newington. We have Ms Doris Gyasi, Member, All-Parliamentary Party Group for Ghana. The delegation is being accompanied by an official from the British High Commission, Mr Duke Mensah Opoku.

On behalf of the House, I welcome the delegation to Parliament and I wish them a very fruitful engagement and stay in Accra.

[Delegation from the All-Party Parliamentary Group for Ghana (APPG) were acknowledged]

We also have some students in our midst. One is Faith Presbyterian Basic School, led by Sandra Opoku, a teacher, and they are from La Nkwantanang. They are 65 in number.

[Students of Faith Presbyterian Basic School were acknowledged]

We also have Generations' Royal Academy, led by ACR/MR Ion Kudze (Rtd), proprietor. They are from Gomoa East Constituency and are 50 in number.

[Pupils of Generations' Royal Academy were acknowledged]

Then we have Presbyterian Boys' Senior High School, Legon, led by Mr Emmanuel Samuel K. Larbi, club patron, Civic Club, and departmental senior housemaster. They are from Madina and are 65 in number.

[Students of Presbyterian Boys' Senior High School were acknowledged]

Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana and may they have a fruitful stay.

We shall continue with the Question numbered 513, slated for the Minister for Roads and Highways who has taken the designated seat. In the meantime, let me hear the Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I have no objection to the application made by the Deputy Majority Leader for the Minister for Roads and Highways to take the appropriate seat. The Minister has nine Questions. I am aware that at Conclave, we all expressed concern about time allocation. So, after the Minister for Roads and Highways, Mr Speaker, I humbly want to suggest that we can go to the item numbered 8, and start with the contribution to the Budget. At least, we would have done quite a number of Questions. Depending on how it goes, we can decide if we can do that of the Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Foreign Affairs.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, actually, some of the Questions for the

Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Foreign Affairs are Urgent Questions. So, I would suggest that at least you take those Questions, since they are urgent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us not belabour this. Let us just go straight and start with the Minister for Roads and Highways who is seated. The first Question for the Minister is the Question numbered 513, standing in the name of Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi, Member of Parliament for Asante Akim Central. Well in the absence of—Yes?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3) and seek your —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please go ahead.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Consideration of Construction of Praaso, Nyabo, Obenimase and Kyekyebiase Roads

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib on behalf of Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Ministry would consider the construction of the Praaso, Nyabo, Obenimase, and Kyekyebiase Roads.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Governs Agbodza): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

(i) Praaso Road

Background

The Praaso road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Konongo-Dwease-Dickson Feeder Road, which is 25.6km long. It is an inter-district road that connects Asante Akim Central Municipality to Asante Akim South Municipality. It is a bituminous surfaced road in poor condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2027 budget upon the availability of funds.

(ii) Nyabo Road

Background

Nyabo is one of the principal towns on the Konongo-Agogo road in the Asante Akim Central Municipality. Roads within the Nyabo township have not been improved over the years. The links are earth roads in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2027 Budget upon the availability of funds.

(iii) Obenimase road

Background

The Obenimase Road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Obenimase Junction-Obenimase which is 4km long. It is an access road on the Konongo-Agogo Road in the Asante Akim Central Municipality. The road is bituminous surface in poor condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2027 Budget upon the availability of funds.

(iv) Kyekyebiase Road

Background

The Kyekyebiase road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Kyekyebiase-Kwakoko. It is a 2km access road on the Konongo-Agogo Road in the Asante Akim Municipality of the Ashanti Region. It is a gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2027 Budget upon the availability of funds.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

1:13 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, there is no supplementary question. I want to take the opportunity to thank the Minister for coming.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. We then move to the next Question, 514, standing in the name of Mr George Kwame Aboagye, the Hon Member for Asene/Manso/ Akroso Constituency.

Yes, Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei?

Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am coming under Order 88 (3) —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Resumption of Construction Works on the Agona Swedru–Akim Oda Road

Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei on behalf of Mr George Kwame Aboagye (NPP —Asene/Manso/Akroso): I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways why the road construction from Agona Swedru to Akim Oda has come to a halt for several months, and when the contractors will resume work.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

Agona Swedru to Akim Oda (IR2) is a 79.5km road. It starts from Winneba Roundabout to Agona Swedru to Eshiem in the Central Region and Eshiem through Akroso to Oda in the Eastern Region. The road is made up of three sections, that is, Winneba Roundabout – Swedru (15.0km), Swedru-Eshiem (22.5km) and Eshiem-Oda (42.0km).

Current Programme

There is no programme on the first section i.e. Winneba Roundabout – Swedru (15.0km). The second section, that is, Swedru-Eshiem (22.5km), has been awarded under the contract titled “Rehabilitation of Agona Swedru – Eshiem Road (22.5Km)”.

The rehabilitation of Agona Swedru-Eshiem (22.5km) commenced on 1st April, 2024 for completion by 1st October, 2024. The progress of works is

estimated at 19.5 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete all outstanding works.

The third section, that is, Eshiem - Akroso - Oda (km 0.0 - 42.0), has been awarded under the project titled 'Rehabilitation of Eshiem - Akroso - Oda (km 0.0 - 42.0)'. The rehabilitation of Eshiem - Akroso - Oda (km 0.0 - 42.0) commenced on 7th March, 2020, and is to be completed by 5th September, 2023. The progress of works is estimated at 47.9 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site due to a delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to the site to complete all outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Osei: Yes, Mr Speaker. I want to ask the Minister what measures his office has put in place to ensure the contractor gets to the site to continue the work immediately?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, from the records, it shows clearly that some of the contractors do not have the capacity to do the work. Because one of the projects was even supposed to have been completed in 2023. He did 47 per cent and stopped. Even the Question of why the project stalled for several months is problematic because the project did not stall for months. In reality, the project stalled for years.

So, what can we do to get the contractors back to the site? We will continue to work and pay them. But those ones that we realise that if you are a contractor and you do only 19 per cent of the work, and out of the inability for the state to pay you for 19 per cent of a small size of work like this—It questions your capability of being selected to do the work in the first place.

So, Mr Speaker, as I said, the Government is working hard to make sure that all outstanding bills owed to contractors are paid for them to go back to site and complete outstanding works.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we then move to the Question numbered 376, standing in the name of Mr Yao Gomado, Member of Parliament for Akan Constituency.

Yes?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Respectfully, may I mount a prayer under Order 88(3) to seek your permission to ask the Question on behalf of the Member?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Mr Afriyie: Thank you.

Construction of the Asato–Apesokubi Road to Improve Access to the Oti Regional Hospital

Mr Frank Afriyie on behalf of Engr Yao Gomado (NDC — Akan): Mr

Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the measures being taken to construct the road between Asato and Apesokubi, which is the shortest route for the people of the Akan Constituency to access the Oti Regional Hospital.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

Background

The Asato - Apesokubi Feeder Road is 6.50km long. It is an inter-district road connecting Asato in Kadjebi Municipality to Apesokubi in the Biakoye District of the Oti Region. It is an unengineered earth road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration under the 2027 Budget upon the availability of funds.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, that will be all, just to thank the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 455, standing in the name of Mr Sanja Nanja, Member of

Parliament for Atebubu/Amantin Constituency.

Hon Member, you have the floor. Yes, Hon Member?

Hon Members, in the absence of Mr Sanja Nanja, we move to Question numbered 298, standing in the name of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta.

Yes, Hon Member?

Installation of a Traffic Light at the Osino Intersection on the Accra–Kumasi Highway

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib *on behalf of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South):* Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when a traffic light will be installed at the Osino intersection on the busy Accra-Kumasi Highway.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, with regard to question numbered 455, I will crave an indulgence to direct the Question and the answers published as having been answered, so that it is not repeated, since I am here to answer that Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I did not give those directives because there may be similar Questions.

Mr Agbodza: All right. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

The Osino intersection is located along the Accra–Kumasi Highway (N6). The intersection lies within the Fanteakwa South District of the Eastern Region and serves as a key junction point for traffic heading towards communities such as Anyinam, Begoro, and Koforidua.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies and road safety audit will be carried out at the intersection to determine the appropriate traffic management measures for consideration, subject to the availability of funds.

Mr Speaker, the Question is about when the traffic light will be installed. I will work with the relevant agencies to get this reviewed and the necessary action will be taken.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, there is no supplementary question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 374, standing in the name of Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe, Member of Parliament for Suhum.

1:23 p.m.

Plans to Construct Footbridges on the Accra-Kumasi Highway

Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (NPP — Suhum): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways whether the Ministry has any plans to construct footbridges on the Accra-Kumasi highway.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Question I have is to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways whether the Ministry has any plans to construct footbridges on the Accra-Kumasi Highway, which is quite a distance. It did not specify, but I can see my Colleague is narrowing it down to a section, which is alright with me, but the original Question covers quite a distance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, go ahead and answer the original Question.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Accra-Kumasi Highway is one of the most important national road corridors. It is a 250-kilometre road which forms part of the National Route 6 (N 6) and connects Accra to Kumasi.

Current Programme

There are currently no programmed activities with respect of footbridges, as the Colleague asked.

Future Programme

However, the Ghana Highway Authority will carry out the necessary safety audit on the sections mentioned, and determine the appropriate action to be taken to mitigate the challenges espoused by my Colleague.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I now move on to a supplementary question, based on the Question on the *Order Paper*.

Mr Bekoe: Mr Speaker, I did not type it. I think that I forwarded a Question based on Suhum to be specific. So, if he is not aware of the specific communities that I was talking about, then I cannot proceed. I think we have to postpone it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, there should be no argument. It is either you ask a supplementary question, based on the *Order Paper*. Hon Member, kindly resume your seat.

Yes, Deputy Minority Whip? Very well.

Let us move to Question numbered 379 standing in the name of Hon Maxwell Kwame Lukutor.

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I rise again on the strength of Order 88(3), seeking your permission to ask the Question on behalf of Mr Lukutor.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Current State of the Tefle Town Road Project

Mr Frank Afriyie on behalf of Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of the Tefle Town Road Project awarded sometime in 2020.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, Tefle is one of the principal towns in the South Tongu Municipality of the Volta Region. It is located along the Sogakope - Accra highway. It is a gravel road in fair surface condition.

Current Programme

The Tefle Town Roads was awarded under the contract titled “Bitumen Surfacing of Tefle Town Roads (3.9km)”. The works commenced on 8th June, 2020 for completion by 7th June, 2021. The project has been terminated after several warning letters were issued. The physical progress of work at the time of termination was 20 per cent.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies have been carried out on the entire 3.9km of the road links for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Afriyie: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We move to Question numbered 385, standing in the name of Hon Member for Fanteakwa North Constituency, Mr Kwame Appiah Kodua.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Commencement of Miaso-Asirebuso to Owusukrom Road

Mr Kwame Appiah Kodua (NPP — Fanteakwa North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Miaso-Asirebuso to Owusukrom road will commence after the contractor left the site.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, once again, the Question is to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Miaso-Asirebuso to Owusukrom Road will commence after the contractor left site.

Current Programme

Mr Speaker, the Miaso-Asirebuso to Owusukrom feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Miaso-Asirebuso-Owusukrom feeder Road (14.60km)”.

The contract was awarded on 30th September, 2020 for completion by 11th January, 2022. The overall progress of works is estimated at 49 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Kodua: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Since governance is continuous, I seek to ask the Minister what practical steps is he making to ensure that some releases of funds will be made to the contractor so that he can go back to site.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed, governance is a perpetual endeavour. Government of Ghana continues forever. I agree. But the emphasis I made was the contractor stopped working in 2022 because the contractor was not paid. My Colleague wants to find out what efforts Government is making to get the contractor paid to come back to site.

I think the Colleague asked a similar question the last time, and I reminded him that just about three weeks ago, the Government of President Mahama paid contractors in excess of GH¢5 billion. Out of the GH¢40 billion indebtedness that has been left. That means that Government actually continues.

So, we shall continue to work and pay the rest of the contractors that are owed their money so that they can complete their work.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question numbered 475 which is standing in the name of Hon Member for Ejisu, Mr Kwabena Boateng.

Current State of the Besease – Jamasi Road in the Ejisu Constituency

Mr Kwabena Boateng (NPP — Ejisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of the Besease – Jamasi road in the Ejisu Constituency, particularly when work will resume to complete the road.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, Jamasi is located in the Ejisu Municipality near the Besease community. The Besease-Jamasi road is a 900m road off the main Kumasi-Accra Highway serving the two communities.

Current Programme

The road has been earmarked for rehabilitation by the Department of Urban Roads (DUR) under the contract “Rehabilitation of Jamasi, Addientem & Donase, Adako Gyakyekwamo roads &

Bronikrom Area roads within Ejisu Municipality (19.27km)”. The contract commenced on 19th December 2024 for completion by 18th December, 2026.

The Besease-Jamasi road has some existing drainage structures and the current programme is to undertake earthworks, paving and surfacing works. The contractor has worked up to base layer level and currently preparing to undertake primer sealing works. Overall physical progress on the project to date is 45 per cent. The Contractor is on site and works are ongoing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Boateng: Mr Speaker, that would be all. But by way of information and to alert the Minister that presently, there is no contractor on site. May I get an indication of when work will resume to reduce the plight of the people?

1:33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, any indication as to when work will resume?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my answer is clear that the contractor has carried out 45 per cent of the works. This includes the base layer, and is currently preparing to undertake primer seal. So they might not be doing anything on site, but maybe they are hauling aggregates and treating them for the primer seal. So, the fact that he does not see them actively with equipment rolling up and down the

road does not mean that they are not on site.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Roads and Highways, we thank you very much for attending upon the House to respond to Questions. Accordingly, you are hereby discharged.

I will, therefore, call on the Minister for Foreign Affairs to take the designated seat.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, when the Budget Statement and Economic Policy is presented, we follow up with comments on the Budget.

Mr Speaker, may you listen to me? Your microphone is on.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I am informed that there should even be an *Order Paper Addendum* to enable the Minister for Foreign Affairs to respond to the Questions. So, we will go back to the comments on the Budget.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am old enough in this House to know how the cycle works. When the Budget Statement and Economic Policy is presented, the focus is always on the comments on the Budget. Ordinarily, we do not even combine Question Time with the commentary. We sought to differ because the Questions have compounded over the days.

Now, we had agreed that we would do two sectors. We have done the Ministry

of Lands and Natural Resources. We have also done the Ministry of Roads and Highways. Mr Speaker, I had cautioned our respected Deputy Majority Leader that when these Ministers are done, we will refer to the item numbered 8. We must start the commentary. The public is watching. That is what they are keenly interested in. Now—[Interruption]—would they listen? They are not listening.

Mr Speaker, with respect to the Minister for Foreign Affairs, I do not have any issues with him, but I am aware that the Minister for Foreign Affairs brought his Response just about 30 minutes ago. When we were at Conclave, we demanded the response of the Minister for Foreign Affairs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Chief Whip, that is what we are coming to do

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, can I finish? Listen to me. Mr Speaker, I beg you in the name of God. Just listen to me, I beg you. You are my friend.

Mr Speaker, I do not have anything against the Minister for Foreign Affairs. He is my Friend. In our other world, he was my Ranking Member when I was Chair. We worked together. He just brought his Answers 30 minutes ago, and the Table Office received the Response.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is the reason for which we are deferring.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, Parliament cannot wait for the Ministers; the Ministers must come and wait in Parliament. We have done two sectors.

Yesterday, we oscillated so well. We took Motions, laid Papers and came back to make comments on the Budget.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs, could you take your seat back?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, he should take his seat back. We do not have anything against him. He should go back.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, respectfully, I thought that because there are two Urgent Questions for the Minister for Foreign Affairs, we could take those two Questions, because they do not require an Answer to be published in the *Order Paper*. But if it is the sense of the House that we defer all Questions for the Minister for Foreign Affairs, then we will go to item numbered 8. The impression should not be created that the Minister for Foreign Affairs is not here to answer the Question. He has been here.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, for the record, I want to make a full declaration. I do not have anything against the Minister for Foreign Affairs. I am simply saying that I made a proposal to the Deputy Leader. The Deputy Leader and I worked so well. Yesterday, we navigated well. I am not saying that we should not take his Questions.

I am saying that an agreement is an agreement; we had agreed that we would do two sectors, and then come back and start the comments on the Budget. After

a while, we go ahead. That was what we did yesterday.

Mr Speaker, let us go to item numbered 8. After a while—The Minister for Foreign Affairs is patient. He should wait. His Answers will be programmed, and then we will take the commentary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, accordingly, I would direct that the Minister for Foreign Affairs be rescheduled to come and answer the Questions on another date.

The item numbered 8—Commentary to continue. I would therefore call on Hon Fred Agbenyo. You have 10 minutes.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, with all due respect, when the Minority makes their position clear on a matter, please, hear us out. We had an agreement. Yesterday, when we started the commentary first, and later went back to Question Time, they raised issues. So, today, we decided that we would take the Questions and clear them out the way, but there are so many Questions.

So, we will deal with the urgent ones, which stand in the name of the Minister for Foreign Affairs and the Minister for the Interior. But I am briefed. So, when they make a proposal, they should let us agree on it. But when they make it as if that is the position of Leadership on the matter, it hurts us. Please.

The Ministers are here; the Minister for Foreign Affairs is here. The Minister for the Interior and with responsibility for national security, is also almost here to come and respond to Questions that stand in the name of Hon Members. When we get those ones out of the way, until midnight, we will be here to make comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

So, Mr Speaker, we are pleading with you. Let us take the two Urgent Questions for the Minister for Foreign Affairs. I am pleading with you. I will hold your feet. Let us take two Questions each for the Minister for Foreign Affairs and the Minister for the Interior, then we can have the whole day. Because of this, we are not even taking Statements, which is also hurting Members whose Statements have been advertised.

So, I am pleading with you. Instead of rescheduling the Minister for Foreign Affairs, let us take him and the Minister for the Interior. Then, we can do Business until the rest of the day.

Mr Speaker, I am pleading with you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, tomorrow, I want to see you at Conclave.

Hon Members, we are going to the item numbered 8—Commentary to continue. Hon Fred Agbenyo, you have 10 minutes. You have the floor.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of Commentary from 18/11/2025]

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Republic of Ghana presented by the Minister for Finance on behalf of H. E. John Dramani Mahama, the President of the Republic of Ghana. The Budget themed, Resetting the Economy for Growth, Jobs, and Transformation, presents opportunities and responsibilities.

1:43 p.m.

The Budget seeks to consolidate the fiscal stability achieved in 2025 and lay the foundation for broad-based growth in 2026. Mr Speaker, allow me to outline the key pillars of this Budget. The Government projected expenditure of GH¢302.5 billion against revenue of GH¢268.1 billion, with Government deficits of GH¢2.2 billion and primary surplus of 1.5 per cent.

The abolition of the COVID-19 levy, the reduction in effective VATs and the upward adjustment of the VAT threshold to GH¢750,000 eased the burden on SMEs and stimulated private sector growth. The US\$10 billion for the Big Push projects, the GH¢302.5 billion Big Push projects for road infrastructure and for the construction of bridges across the

country will open up this country to the movement of goods and services and then develop the country.

Mr Speaker, in the agricultural sector, the Budget has allocated GH¢245 million for food security, GH¢828 million for 1,000 kilometres of agriculture enclave roads, GH¢690 million for farmer service centres, GH¢6.9 billion for oil palm industrialisation demonstrate a strong commitment to sustainable food systems and agro-industrial growth. Mr Speaker, in the educational sector, the Government has allocated GH¢33.3 billion to the Ministry of Education, GH¢9.9 billion to GetFund, GH¢4.2 billion to Free SHS, GH¢2 billion for basic school infrastructure, and these measures will help to kill the double-track system that we have in our secondary school. In the health sector, the Government has allocated GH¢9 billion for national health insurance, GH¢2.3 billion for MahamaCares, GH¢600 million for three regional hospitals, GH¢1.1 billion for Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP), GH¢600 million—

Mr Speaker, in the energy sector, the Government has allocated 15.2 billion to set aside the shortfalls in the energy sector and 4.8 billion for IPP arrears. We, the people of Guan will be happy that with all these projects, we will be able to open up road infrastructure in the area, extend electricity to the rural communities, build more hospitals, Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) compounds and schools and markets in the area.

When one refers to page 146 of the Budget, the Minister for Finance has this to say at paragraph 1195. He said,

“Ghana was indeed at the bottom of the abyss, a nation in distress with its economy bleeding and its people weary yet yearning for a government with the courage and vision to rebuild.”

Indeed, today, we have a Government with vision, and a Government that is ready to rebuild the country. In paragraph 1196, the Minister has this to say,

“But through decisive leadership, bold reforms, and the resilience of the Ghanaian people, we began to turn the tide.”

Mr Speaker, as one moves around the country today, all Ghanaians can attest to the fact that indeed, they voted for a visionary leadership, they voted for a transformational leadership, and everybody can see that indeed, Ghana is progressing steadily. Mr Speaker, in paragraph 1197, the Minister said, GDP growth rose from 5.3 per cent in 2024 to 6.3 per cent. As the Akans will say, ‘*Wo mpe wei na wo pe den*’? Inflation has dropped from 23.8 per cent to a single digit of 8.8 per cent in less than a year: *wo mpe wei na wo pe den*?

Mr Speaker, the cedi cumulatively has appreciated by 38.9 per cent—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is the meaning?

Mr Agbenyo: Mr Speaker, to wit, ‘If you do not like this, what at all again do you want?’

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. You may proceed.

Mr Agbenyo: Mr Speaker, the cedi cumulatively has appreciated by 34.9 per cent within this short period of time that this Government has been in office. It is evidently clear that this is a Government that is determined to serve the people of this country. This is a President who is ready to create employment opportunities for the people of this country. That is why in this Budget, we are proposing that we create employment for about 800,000 teeming Ghanaian youth who are working in our streets and have nothing to do.

Mr Speaker, I am happy to note that this Budget has made a provision to complete 10 of the Agenda 111 projects that were initiated and dotted across the length of this country, and not even one was completed in the eight years that our Colleagues were in power. I am also happy to note that the President has decided that three regional hospitals will be built in the new regions that have been created in this country. The days where people had to move to Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital or Okomfo Anokye Teaching Hospital to access good health care will soon be a thing of the past.

We want to thank the Government and the people of this country for the support they have given to this Government thus far. We want to assure them that we will not let them down and the resources that

have been allocated to the various sectors will be put to good use for the benefit of Mother Ghana.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank you very much for the opportunity. May God bless H. E. John Dramani Mahama and may God bless Mother Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Dr Mohammed Amin Adam. He has 15 minutes.

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam (NPP — Karaga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the great opportunity given to me to comment on the 2026 Budget, which was presented here by my Brother, Dr Ato Forson, on behalf of H. E. President John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I have already described this Budget as growthless and jobless. It does not offer hope to the people of Ghana. It does not offer hope to workers. It does not offer hope to teachers, not even to investors. The confidence level in the economy is very low, and it is not the Minority that is saying it. While the Government is in this House praising itself, investors out there are saying something different. Before the Budget was presented, the Government conducted 45 Treasury Bill auctions. If you want to know one of the measures to gauge confidence in an economy, it is the market – how the market responds, how they patronise investment and debt instruments. I am saying that out of the 45 Treasury auctions conducted since January, 25 of them failed.

1:53 p.m.

If 55 per cent of your treasury auctions failed, what it means is that confidence in the management of the economy collapsed.

Mr Speaker, what is even intriguing is that, two days after presenting the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, one which is supposed to give good news to Ghanaians and investors, the market rejected their debt instruments. Their treasury bills suffered 30 per cent rejection. That is a vote of no confidence in the economy by investors in this country.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to inflation numbers, the Minister boasted that they achieved a single-digit inflation. A single-digit inflation is good for any economy and this was why under the Government of President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, we achieved—*[Interruption]*—A single-digit inflation is good. Under President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, we achieved a single-digit in 2018 and 2019, two years running. This will be one of the longest periods of single-digit inflation in the history of Ghana—*[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, so to achieve a single-digit inflation is really good for every economy. But when you unmask this single-digit inflation we have today, you would see a troubling picture. If you look at the inflation of essential commodities that is, basic commodities Ghanaians associate with, within the inflation basket, the increase in prices are higher

than what we saw in 2024. They are higher than what we saw in 2024.

Mr Speaker, according to data from the website of the Ghana Statistical Service, basic commodities like water, in September 2024, year-on-year, the inflation for water classified was 2.8 per cent. In September this year, it was 3.6 per cent. In August, it was actually higher and it was 3.9 per cent. In September 2024, for goods like milk and eggs the rate of inflation year-on-year was 8.6 per cent. In September 2025, it was 20.1 per cent. In August, it was even higher; it was as high as 37 per cent. In September 2024, the various oils as palm and groundnut oil for cooking and fats had an inflation of 7 per cent. Sadly, in September this year, 2025, it was 44 per cent. In August, it was actually 53 per cent.

Mr Speaker, we can see this trend with fruits and nuts. We can see the same trend with coffee and coffee substitutes. We can see the same trend with drinks. Therefore, behind this single-digit inflation they are boasting about, is a real struggling economy, which is depriving people of decent livelihoods.

Mr Speaker, amidst these economic difficulties, the priorities of this Government have shifted from the people. They are social democrats, but they have forgotten about the people. Their priorities have shifted to buying jets and helicopters. The Minister announced in presenting the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that in 2026, they would purchase two executive jets, four helicopters and a

vessel. If they were to buy two helicopters to even replace those that were involved in the accident, I can understand. But four helicopters, at the time, they are telling Ghanaians to sacrifice more. They gave workers 9 per cent and they are asking them to sacrifice more.

Mr Speaker, the Minister did not give the cost of these jets they want to buy. But conservative estimates show that it will cost us US\$1.2 billion. This is not a government that is concerned about the people. Workers are suffering, teachers are suffering, farmers in my Constituency are suffering—[Uproar]—and then they want to use that money to buy helicopters and presidential jets.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to capital spending, the 2026 Budget cannot produce growth and the jobs promised to the people. Why do I say that? The 2026 Budget proposes 3.6 per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP) for capital spending. This is higher than the 1.5 per cent of GDP which was proposed in 2025.

The Minister actually did 0.5 per cent of GDP. But the 3.6 per cent of GDP for 2026 is lower than the 4.6 per cent of GDP we did in 2024. Generally, capital investment is low in Ghana and it is not just with the NDC. It happened with us, even though our figure was higher. It happened with previous Government. That is not good if we have to build the long-term sustainability of our economy. We need to be serious as a country to invest and to do more capital investment.

Because that is what will generate growth and jobs.

Mr Speaker, having said this, the Minister talked about stability. But I know that economic stability should drive growth. Unfortunately, his estimate for growth for 2026 was put at 4.8 per cent. When the economy has stabilised, they are projecting 4.8 per cent. At the time they said the economy was criminally managed, the economy grew at 5.7 per cent. So, I do not understand this logic. An economy that is badly managed could grow at 5.7 per cent and an economy that is stabilised is projecting to grow at 4.8 per cent. There is no macroeconomic theory that can support this framework.

Therefore, this stability for me does not exist. It is stability on paper. It is cooked stability. Because I see a significant disconnect between that stability and the struggling real economy of this country at this moment.

Mr Speaker, if we have to develop our country and grow jobs, we have to invest in capital investment. Therefore, I want to make a proposal to this Government and I hope they will take it. That to be able to increase capital investment, we may have to introduce what we call the golden rule. The golden rule as pertains to Britain that we will not borrow for consumption but to invest in capital investment, so that we can generate growth to support job creation in the country. This Budget Statement and Economic Policy offers big promises but the numbers behind the promises simply

do not add up. Let us come to numbers with regard to revenue performance.

Mr Speaker, the 2025 revenue performance, up to September 2025, shows that the system is struggling. The Budget reports that by the end of September 2025, revenue and grants amounted to GH¢154.9 billion which is equal to 11.1 per cent of GDP. But the full year target is GH¢226 billion which is equivalent to 16 per cent of GDP. So, to hit this full year target, quarter four alone must deliver GH¢71 billion, nearly 5 per cent of GDP in one quarter.

Mr Speaker, let me break it down for us. Quarter one will have to generate 32 per cent of the entire year's revenue. Quarter four will need to be 40 per cent bigger than the average quarter so far. We must ask what policy, compliance breakthrough, structural shift or even what miracle can support such an extraordinary fourth quarter performance, when they have not performed in the first three quarters of the year. No explanation has been provided. This is not proper forecasting. This is wishful arithmetic.

2:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the revenue measures in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy itself are unrealistic and untested. Government wants Ghanaians to believe that they can raise GH¢1.6 billion from VAT compliance, GH¢1.2 billion from small taxpayers' reforms, GH¢1.68 billion from removing 347 exemptions, GH¢747 million from corporate income tax, and

recover GH¢5.3 billion while reorganising levies and the VAT, what they call the VAT reforms. But these measures depend almost entirely on behaviour change, administrative strength, GRA enforcement capacity, customs discipline, a taxpayer base still recovering from economic stress. But 2025 had these similar measures, and it showed that the measures underperformed. If compliance gains could ensure that we address the revenue shortfall, it would have done it for us.

Mr Speaker, if removing import exemptions could have raised revenue, it would have done it for us this year. Unfortunately, these measures failed and this is why I am confident that the revenue measures in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic policy are unrealistic.

Mr Speaker, when we come to growth forecasts, it breaks the internal logic of this Budget. This is the most revealing contradiction of all that I have seen. The economy, as they said, grew 6.3 per cent in the first half of 2025, above our estimated potential for five consecutive quarters. But under normal forecasting logic, strong first-year growth should lead to strong full-year growth. If you have a strong growth in the first half year, it should lead to stronger full-year growth and strong full-year growth should lead to growth momentum in the following year. But what do we see? According to them, 2025 will end with 4.8 per cent, and the 2026 group projected to be 4.8 per cent. Where is the momentum? The math does not match the message.

Mr Speaker, what it means is that the Minister is telling us that the economy is surging today, but the Budget Statement and Economic policy expects the economy to suddenly lose momentum next year. At the same time, they are telling Ghanaians that this Budget Statement and Economic Policy has introduced transformational policies. Where are those transformational policies? Their growth is anaemic for next year, 4.8 per cent, the same as this year. This is not economic management.

Mr Speaker, the National Democratic Congress (NDC) cannot claim that the economy is recovering strongly—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Dr Adam: Mr Speaker, they are rolling out growth measures. Revenue will surge, and yet growth will fall from 6.3 per cent to 4.8 per cent. There is no macroeconomic logic that supports this. Either the growth number is understated to soften expectations, or there are serious risks the Government is not disclosing.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, let me say that this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is not realistic. It cannot provide growth; it cannot provide jobs. Revenue has not been properly pursued; Compliance has not been achieved. Growth cannot be justified. Social spending has increased—*[Hear! Hear!]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up—Order!

I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Cletus Seidu Dapilah. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah (NDC — Jirapa): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity given to me to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic policy presented to this House by the Minister for Finance, Hon Cassiel Ato Baah Forson.

Mr Speaker, I am surprised the former Minister for Finance is talking this way because the former head of the Economic Management Team, Dr Mahamudu Bawumia has already apologised to Ghanaians for the mess that they caused this country—*[Uproar]*—So, I think if the chairman of the Economic Management Team has apologised to Ghanaians for the eight years' mess, I am surprised at the way he is talking.

Mr Speaker, let me also advert the minds of my Colleagues to the Global InfoAnalytics Polls that has been conducted on this Budget Statement and Economic Policy. This Budget Statement and Economic Policy has 82 per cent rating approval from Ghanaians—*[Hear! Hear!]*. Ghanaians applauded this Budget Statement and Economic Policy and they are so happy with it. Let us stop with the politics and support this fiscal prudence that the current Minister for Finance and his team is embarking on.

Mr Speaker, let me also remind the former Minister for Finance that one of the bad policies that they took was to cap all our statutory funds, thereby starving

the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) of Resources, starving District Assembly Common Fund (DACF) and the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA) of funds.

Mr Speaker, today, under this Government, all these statutory funds have been uncapped, particularly DACF which is performing wonders under Hon Cassiel Ato Baah Forson and President John Dramani Mahama. The Common fund is being sent with 80 per cent going to the District Assemblies.

Mr Speaker, if we want to develop this country, it is for a good reason that the local government concept was created. It was created to send development to the doorsteps of the people. They came in 2017, and one of the bad decisions they took with their 169 was to cap this fund, thereby starving the local assemblies of development.

Mr Speaker, today, 80 per cent of resources or money is sent to the district assemblies for development. Today, when we go to the assemblies, you will see that all the workers and staff of assemblies across this country are smiling because they are working. They are happy that they now have resources to work.

Mr Speaker, let me also say that if we go to NHIA, under their watch, every other day, there were service providers who laid down their tools and said they would not provide services because the previous administration could not pay them.

Mr Speaker, since we came, the whole of 2025, it is a thing of the past. We do not hear any service provider saying that they are going on strike and they would not provide services to our people. It is because the Ministry of Finance is releasing resources to NHIA, and they are also paying the service providers. This is one of the achievements of this Government.

Mr Speaker, let me advert the mind of the former Minister for Finance and my Colleagues on the other Side that from 2023, with GETFund, they could only do GH¢1.8 billion because the fund was capped. In 2024, they did GH¢ 2.3 billion. In 2025, when we came, we did GH¢ 3.2 billion, and in 2026, we are doing GH¢ 9.9 billion because we want to have so much resources that we can solve our educational needs.

Mr Speaker, when we come to the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS), in 2023, they did GH¢ 2.5 billion and in 2024, they did 4.2 billion. Then 2025, when we came, we did GH¢ 6.5 billion, and in 2026, we are doing GH¢ 9.9 billion.

Mr Speaker, for the Common Fund, they did GH¢ 4.5 billion in 2023 and in 2024, GH¢ 4.3 billion. When we came in 2025, we did GH¢ 5.7 billion, and in 2026, we are doing GH¢ 8.9 billion. This is how much resources we are sending to the district assemblies for development.

Mr Speaker, let me say that one thing that our opponents have forgotten is that Ghanaians have not forgotten. During their tenure, we bought a litre of fuel for

about GHC20 in this country—*[Uproar]*—we did. I will give you the year.

Mr Speaker on exchange rates, the former Minister for Finance should have told us the exchange rate—they told us that they arrested the dollar and gave the key to the Inspector General of Police (IGP) to keep, and yet we bought one dollar for GHC17.00 under their watch. How much is dollar today? All of you are happy with the stability of the cedi. It did not come by chance but by prudent management.

2:13 p.m.

So, they need to applaud us; applaud the Minister for Finance, and applaud the President John Mahama for having a good team that manages the economy that we are all enjoying today.

Mr Speaker, when I look into their faces, I see a sign of good living, but even when their own party was in power, most of them were struggling. Today, they are all shining and smiling.

Mr Speaker, on page 132 paragraph 1047, the former regime paid little service to basic education in this country. In the eight years of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) administration, they did not do much in basic education. Basic education virtually collapsed under their watch. Under this Budget, on page 132, paragraph 1049, we are going to invest significantly in basic education. Most of our schools were constructed without kindergartens. So, it is not for nothing that President Mahama and his Minister

for Finance are saying that they would construct some 200 kindergartens across the country.

Mr Speaker, with regard to Junior High Schools (JHS), we would construct about 200 of them. Basically, what I want to say is that even capitation grants, were in arrears for a long time. When you spoke to headmasters and headteachers, they were extremely frustrated. Under the Government of President Mahama and Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, all these basic capitation grants and school feeding resources have now been increased.

Mr Speaker, all I want to say is that this Government, President Mahama's Government, is not a government that they would want to compare their eight years mess with. Sector by sector, we have performed marvelously; we are ahead of them. In education, health, and all the other sectors. All the macro and micro indicators are positive today, and that has brought business investor confidence in this country. People are so happy.

Mr Speaker, when you go to the market—I remember when the Minister for Finance was preparing this Budget, he visited most of the markets. He took their inputs before he prepared this Budget to Parliament. The market women were so happy with what he was doing.

Mr Speaker, today, when you go around this country, you will see sanity. When I say sanity, you will see that the Ghanaian populace is so happy that

President Mahama is managing this country in the right direction; that is the rating out there.

Mr Speaker, our opponents can choose to do politics, but all I want to tell them today is that we have to give credit where it is due.

Mr Speaker, they had the opportunity to present eight Budgets in this House and in all of their Budgets, Ghanaians never gave them any good rating because the economy was hard. Ghanaians were in distress, but today, when we go around, the media can testify to this. They should take their cameras around, and all Ghanaians will tell them that Ghana is moving in the right direction, and it is because of the handlers of the economy. They did not do it but we are doing it, so they should support us in doing it.

Mr Speaker, the last thing I would want to talk about is that—because of bad politics, Mr Speaker, I will urge this House and Parliament of Ghana—it is not for nothing that the National Development Planning Commission (NDPC) found creation in the 1992 Constitution, article 86 and 87. Let us work with the NDPC. Let the NDPC lead the developmental agenda of this country. We should not allow political parties—when I say political parties, I mean we should not allow some political parties or someone—to win election and get up without adding a single dormitory block, or any classroom block, and yet announces a Free Senior High School Programme. We should not allow that. Because of bad politics, we

should not allow—somebody would sleep and wake up and say they are paying teacher trainees' allowance, when indeed, the teachers complete school and they cannot absorb them or recruit them.

Mr Speaker, this is a call to all of us to allow the NDPC to lead the developmental agenda of this country, so that we do not allow any knee-jerk approach like our Colleagues did in eight years; we should not allow that.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by saying that this country is in the right direction; Ghana, is moving in the right direction. The market women are happy, the farmers are happy, the teachers are happy. Workers in this country are so happy; everybody is happy, and even the MPs are happy.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I thank you so much for the opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. You have 15 minutes. The floor is yours.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to comment on the Statement that was delivered to this House by the Minister responsible for Finance.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to the contributions from our Colleagues from

the Other Side, and I tell you in all honesty that I am worried. The Member of Parliament for Jirapa says that the evidence that this Budget is fit for purpose is that Global InfoAnalytics Limited has conducted a poll and says that it is good. Yesterday, I heard my Brother, the Minister for Government Communications, say that under President Mahama, transport fares have been reduced by about 15 per cent, and that it has never happened before; that is not true.

They should check 2022. My good Friend, Mr Isaac Adongo, the Chairperson of the Finance Committee, says that this is the first time we have had a negative rate of debt accumulation; that is not true. They should check 2001. Mr R. Acheampong, yesterday, told us that single digit inflation has been achieved and so all is well. He should check 2018 and 2019.

Mr Speaker, if we do not pay attention to the details, on face value, we will go away thinking that the core issues of the Ghanaian economy have changed. But I say to you, Mr Speaker, in all humility, that if my Colleagues on the Other Side will stop dancing like they were doing in the Chamber, and go into the fiscal tables, they will stop and realise that there is a lot of work that needs to be done.

Mr Speaker, I want to start off by looking at some of the things that are being applauded. If it is about achieving a negative rate of debt accumulation, the first person to have done that was Mr Yaw Osafo-Marfo in 2001.

If it is about single-digit inflation based on sterilisation, where you suck money from the banks and the asset management companies, the one who did that was Dr Kwabena Duffuor, and when he finished, people gave him a name. They said he was unprecedented, three years of single-digit inflation. When Mr Yaw Osafo-Marfo did it, they were calling him “*Oyɛadeɛyie* Osafo-Marfo”.

If it is about cutting down taxes, in 2017, Mr Ken Ofori-Atta cut down over 14 taxes. They should go and see the way they were jubilating in Abossey-Okai.

Mr Speaker, if we, the political class, continue with this exercise of exciting ourselves and dancing over these temporary gains, and we do not deal with the structural issues, all you need is one major shock to the Ghanaian economy and you are back to square one.

Mr Speaker, I want to draw the attention of my Colleagues to the tables, and I beg of them to take time to read them. Mr Speaker, I would please ask my Colleagues to turn to appendix 2 (a), and read with me. In the Mid-Year Budget Review, when we came to this Chamber, we warned our Colleagues on the Government bench that the revenue measures they have put in place, contrary to their thinking that it will raise more revenue so that they can meet their expenditure commitments, will not meet the targets.

Mr Speaker, in the half year when we came here, revenue was underperforming by GHC3 billion. In fact, if we read the Whole of

Government accounts report published by the Controller and Accountant-General, contrary to their claim that we did not leave them buffers, the balance brought forward from 2024 is GH¢11 billion. If we add that to the GH¢3 billion, their revenue shortfall at half year was GH¢14 billion. Mr Speaker, as at now, the revenue shortfall is GH¢8 billion, if we look at the numbers. If we add that GH¢11 billion to it, that is GH¢19 billion.

2:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if *Hansard* and our Colleagues who are here would be truthful to themselves, during the Mid-Year Budget Review, we told them that by the end of the year they will have to cut expenditure by GH¢30 billion because their revenue is not performing. Today, when we look at the tables, they have cut expenditure by GH¢28 billion. *Aka mo two pɛ* then they will reach GH¢30 billion because revenue is not performing. Why is that important? Because, Mr Speaker, all the promises that they make, if they are not able to mobilise the revenue, they cannot fulfil.

If we go into the tables and find the numbers that were promised us, the team from the Ministry of Finance told us that they would remove taxes and they would not bring new taxes, and that after they have implemented this new fiscal strategy, they will get more revenue. Remember, the Minister for Finance told us that he was going to move revenue to Gross Domestic Product (GDP) ratio, from 13 per cent to 18 per cent? I am sure we all remember. Mr Speaker, when we

were leaving power, revenue as a percentage of GDP was 16 per cent. After they implemented their strategy, revenue is now underperforming. It is now at 11 per cent of GDP.

If Hon Colleagues have not taken time to look at the tables, the Government has lost 5 per cent of GDP on revenue. Do they think there is more money? 5 per cent of GDP, that is 5 per cent of GH¢1 trillion, is GH¢50 billion. If they do not understand it, please let me explain some more. *W'abo ka* GH¢50 billion. That is why they have had to cut their expenses. The GH¢28 billion expenses they have cut is not just a number; there are teachers and nurses who are waiting to be recruited, and because this government has played politics with the revenue strategy, they are at home.

There are contractors who are waiting to be paid, and because we have been doing politics with the revenue strategy, they have not been paid. Mr Speaker, there are the flagship programmes that young Ghanaians are waiting for this Government to fund, and because they have been doing politics with it, they cannot fund even their own flagship programmes. So, Mr Speaker, while we are drawing their attention to the fact that their revenue strategy is not performing, they can dance and sing as much as they want in the Chamber. The results out there will show them.

Mr Speaker, in 2025, they promised to spend GH¢51 million on the Women's Development Bank but they did not spend it. Then this year, without providing any report on it, they

announced that they have increased the budget to GH¢400 million, and that it is a credible budget. Does that sound like credibility to us? In 2025, they promised GH¢1.5 billion to the agriculture sector to improve agriculture. They have not done much. In fact, it took one day to the presentation of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy before they launched *Nkokɔ Nketenketɛ*. Zero work was done, then now they come and promise GH¢2 billion cedis for agriculture and say it is a credible Budget. Does that sound credible to them?

They promised GH¢300 million for apprenticeship programme. Where are the apprentices? What work are they doing? Nothing happens, and then they come back and promise another GH¢170 million. Does that sound like credibility? So, if Hon Colleagues in all humility, stop dancing in the Chamber and pay attention to the numbers, they would realise that we all have a big problem that we have to fix. When we say this, then they say, “oh, the cedi has appreciated by 30 per cent. Inflation is down, monetary policy rate is down, and *aban papa aba*”.

Mr Speaker, let me take my time to draw attention once again to a few more things. In the beginning, we told them that this currency that has appreciated by 30 per cent is a matter of fact, but it is because they are pumping dollars into the economy. You would recall, Mr Speaker, that when we said it, the governor of the Central Bank told us on the 30th of April, 2025, “the Bank of Ghana is not injecting dollars to support the cedi’s stability”. This is a matter of

record. We kept insisting that they were pumping. So, when the Bishops’ Conference visited the President at Jubilee House, they enquired of him that, the Minority said that the Government is pumping dollars and that the fundamentals have not changed.

The President told them that, no, it is not true, and that it is effective leadership that was leading to the gains of the cedi. We kept reading the summary of economic and financial data and telling them that they are pumping dollars. It took the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to draw their attention to it and ask them to stop, then the depreciation resumed.

When it resumed by the 10th of September, the President held the press conference, and the media told him that it had started depreciating again. That was when the President admitted that the Bank of Ghana had been intervening, and it is when they stopped that the depreciation has resumed. Mr Speaker, the IMF has instructed the Central Bank, and I can say on authority, that henceforth, every month before they pump, they should announce it, and that is why on the 5th of October, the Bank of Ghana announced that they were going to pump US\$1.15 billion, and on the 3rd of November, they announced that they were going to pump another US\$1 billion.

Mr Speaker, from January till now, the Bank of Ghana has pumped not less than US\$8 billion to shore up the currency. Ghana’s import bill so far is about US\$14 billion, so the normal supply of

dollar in the economy will give us problems. It is this pumping that is holding us up.

Mr Speaker, what we should do is to take advantage of the windfall forex that we are getting from the gold purchase programme, and fix the structural issues, else they can dance as much as they want in the Chamber. If we are hit by one challenge, we will be in trouble.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to inflation, if we do not tackle the supply-side issues, and all that we do is sterilising, the consequence will be that they will claim inflation has come down, but the lived experience of people out there will be that the prices of the average goods and services they are buying is going up. If they say that the monetary policy rate of the Central Bank has come down, so interest rates are solid, I beg of them to check the average lending rate and the stock of credit to private sector. They will find that it has not reflected. So, we have serious issues to deal with. We should not reduce it to name-calling, dancing and singing, else with just one major shock will be back to where we are.

Now, Mr Speaker, let me focus my attention on the real sector. For agriculture, they promised GH¢1.5 billion investment into two major things: Feed Ghana and *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*. They launched *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* one day before they came to read the second of their four Budgets. So how much investment has gone into it? Zero. How much investment has gone into Feed Ghana? Where are the farmers who are

supposedly benefiting from it for it to lead to an improvement in agriculture? So real sector investment growth and jobs is not happening.

Mr Speaker, on industry, they inherited a 24-Hour Economy Programme, but they said it was a bad programme. In fact, they inherited a One District One Factory (1D1F) programme. They said it was a bad programme and that they are replacing it with a 24-Hour Economy Programme. No problem.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, should I ask that “you inherited a 24-Hour Economy Programme” be expunged from the record?

Mr Nkrumah: No, they inherited a 1D1F programme, then they said it was not good for purpose, so they were replacing it with a 24-Hour Economy Programme. Mr Speaker, the National Development Planning Commission (NDPC) of the Republic of Ghana has reported that the 1D1F programme left 150 factories that were functioning; that is 18 factories a year. So, in 2025, when they suspended the 1D1F programme, the opportunity cost is 18 factories that could have created jobs for young people.

They said 24-Hour Economy Programme, so where are the factories? How many jobs? They ended up even by telling us that in 2026 we should not expect a programme and a Budget. Now they say they are going to give us a GH¢110 million for the 24-hour economy. In fact, you have no programme to create industrial jobs.

Mr Speaker, in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they said that they are going to create 800,000 jobs. I saw my brother John Dumelo dancing at the back there that “Ato is forcing” because he has announced 800,000 jobs. They forgot that the next paragraph said that 490,000 of those jobs are for labourers. In paragraph 501, it says,

“The GH¢63 billion road contracts awarded so far under the Big Push, will generate an estimated 490,000 jobs”.

2:33 p.m.

So, the 800,000 jobs that they are announcing, in their own Budget, almost 500,000 of them are going to be manual labour on road projects. I was at the University of Cape Coast two days ago; they have no plans for the students who are about to graduate from the technical universities. Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by reminding our Colleagues that if the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy really intends to create growth and jobs, they need to invest in the job-creating initiatives. They can make all the noise that they want, but if the revenue does not perform, they will not get the money to invest in it. If the revenue does not perform and they do not invest it in the things that will create jobs, the young people will come for them at the end of the day.

They said they do not have fiscal space, but they are doing fiscal discipline. So, I was shocked to hear them say that now they have fiscal space to buy two new executive jets. They do

not have fiscal space to finish paying the contractors on outstanding projects, but they have fiscal space to buy two executive jets.

Mr Speaker, I am going to conclude by reminding our Colleagues that the revenue strategy is not performing; they do not have resources to expend. They are pumping because gold price is at US\$4,000. It may not be there forever. They have two more Budgets to go. I beg of them to spend it doing the real structural issues, not dancing over temporary results, else we will be back here some other time.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Isaac Adongo — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Adongo?

Mr Isaac Adongo: Mr Speaker, my Colleague cited me—[*Uproar*].

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me send this signal. When you are debating, avoid mentioning people’s names. By the rules, once you mention the person’s name, when the person is up, I will give the person the floor. Mr Adongo, you have the floor.

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, my Colleague attributed falsehood to me. When I stood up yesterday, I said the rate of debt accumulation went into negative 33 in many years. From 2021 to 2025 is

14 years. That is in many years. I did not say that it has never gone into negative 33. That is the first one.

Mr Speaker, secondly, this is a House of records. There is no instruction—*[Uproar]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, please, I recognise Mr Adongo. Mr Adongo, kindly conclude?

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, this is a House of records. Ghana is under an official International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme, and there are benchmarks and prior actions. There is nowhere in the IMF programme where there has been an instruction to Ghana not to intermediate in our market, and there is no official—*[Uproar]*—this is a House of records. The IMF has not asked the Government of Ghana and the Ministry of Finance or the Bank of Ghana to make any announcement in managing its foreign currency, therefore, what the Hon Colleague said is not supported by the facts, and this is a House of records—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon, kindly conclude.

Mr Adongo: I therefore request that, Mr Speaker, that should be expunged from the records because the IMF programme is an official programme, and there is no instruction to the Government of Ghana not to manage its foreign currency and nobody should be allowed to put into the official records that Ghana has been asked to report to

the public when it wants to manage its foreign currency.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we can make our submission without mentioning a Member's name. The rules are very clear.

Mr Nkrumah — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, your name has not been mentioned, so I will not give you the floor. I proceed to recognise Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie.

You have the floor.

Order!

Yes, Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, with all due deference to you, we understand that names are not to be mentioned when we are having debates. Yesterday, my respected Colleague, Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah's name was mentioned. He actually stood up trying to catch your attention, which I believe he did, but he was ignored.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then, he did not catch my eye. I will proceed to mention Mrs Faustina Elikplim Akurugu. You have five minutes.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in the order of names that we submitted, the

next Member to comment at this stage will be Mr Gakpey.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: With all due respect, I have the list here. The first on the list is Mr Fred Agbenyo; second on the list is Mr Cletus Dapilah; third on the list is Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie; fourth on the list is Mrs Elikplim Akurugu. That is the list I have before me. From which list are you speaking?

2:43 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is fine. Mrs Akurugu, please speak.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is what I have. I do not have a new list.

Mrs Elikplim Akurugu, you have the floor.

Mrs Faustina Elikplim Akurugu (NDC — Dome Kwabenya): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government delivered by the Hon Minister, Dr Ato Forson. Mr Speaker, the Agriculture sector remains the backbone of the economy and the lifeline for many million Ghanaian households. As the Minister rightly said, the agriculture sector has recorded—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, you have no right to ask the Member to stop talking.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, with all due respect, we are to help you maintain order in the House—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you cannot ask the Member to stop talking. You can draw my attention to something, but you cannot ask the Member to stop talking—

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, if the Member is speaking and they are making noise, I have every right to draw your attention to it. But, Mr Speaker, to tell me that I have no right is also not regular. Please listen to her in silence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Order! Order!

Hon Akurugu, you have the floor.

Mrs Faustina Elikplim Akurugu (NDC — Dome-Kwabenya): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

As the Minister rightly stated, the agricultural sector has seen a 6 per cent growth, doubling that of last year. The progress is commendable and reflects the resilience of our farmers and the growing impact of target interventions.

Mr Speaker, I was surprised to listen to our former Minister for Finance. I do not know what he was saying, but under his watch, the agricultural sector saw an emergency response, while the current Budget, which our Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, recorded, is being managed and structural reforms are being formed.

The former Government acted on emergency relief of 500 million to ease drought and food security, while Dr Ato

Forson is giving us a driving and a long-term structural reform for agro-growth.

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam: —
rose —

Mrs Akurugu: Mr Speaker, [**An Hon Member:** Has your name been mentioned? Master, sit down!] Mr Speaker, under the watch of our former Minister, he focused on short-term fixes, credit assistance, export bans.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Mohammed Amin Adam, I am avoiding interruptions, so if after her submission you want to comment, I will give you the floor just like I did for Hon Adongo.

Mrs Akurugu: Under our current Minister for Finance, we are pursuing comprehensive long-term reforms through broader financing, value chain development, climate-driven industrialisation and major infrastructure investments. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, the 2024 Budget, under the former Minister, was appropriate for purposes of stabilising food security system during national emergency. It was under his watch that we noticed that donkeys were used to export fertilisers meant for farmers and the moneys used to buy lands for themselves. Under the watch of Dr Ato Forson, we see bold, systematic, investment-driven and transformation to the economy. [*Hear! Hear!*] He addresses the root causes of agricultural underperformance, builds sustainable value chains and positions agriculture as a modern economic engine.

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget deserves commendation for shifting agriculture from survival competitiveness and from crisis management to national development.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for this opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mohammed Amin Adam — [*Pause*]

Next on the list is Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I believe that, first, our Side has already delivered on the Budget and actually punched the necessary holes in i [*Pause*]

Mr Speaker, I will be looking at Budget from the inability of the Ministry of Finance and the Government to raise the necessary revenue — [*Pause*]

Mr Speaker, the only way one can fix the economy of this country is the ability of this Government to raise revenue. We know that for the budget amount of GH¢162 billion, only GH¢154 billion was raised which clearly shows that the Government has been very lazy in raising the necessary revenues to spend on the good people of this country.

Mr Speaker, you will also realise that this Government, under the 2025 Budget, came to this House to tell us that they were removing what we call—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you may continue.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Unfortunately, they introduced so many taxes, more than 10 of them. They increased the Growth and Sustainability Levy from 1 to 3 per cent. They also extended the Sunset Clause from 2025 to 2028.

Mr Speaker, electricity tariffs have also been increased to almost 19 per cent in this country, while water prices have also increased by 4 per cent. One would also realise that when it comes to Government fees and charges, they have increased that between 30 to 40 per cent in this country.

Therefore, when the Government says that inflation is reducing, we realise that in the market the story is entirely different. So, while people are trying to praise this Budget, I want to say that what they are doing in 2025 has shown all Ghanaians that nothing is really happening.

Recently, the Minister for Finance himself did some few rounds and came to Takoradi, and he had stated it clearly in the Budget in paragraph 1192. After his rounds, he did his own radio presentations, and I would like to quote one that had come from *Citi FM*. While he was trying to tout himself, this is what the people of Takoradi in particular said, and I quote,

“Some listeners from Takoradi questioned the accuracy of the market price claims made during the Minister’s recent tour of Takoradi”.

So, if the Minister is claiming that inflation is coming down to 8 per cent, single digits, clearly it is not being felt on the grounds. So, that shows that this Budget is not telling the truth.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the prices of goods on the market, sugar used to be GH¢480 per bag. Today, as we speak, sugar prices are GH¢540 at the Takoradi market. When we take a tin of sugar which used to be GH¢6, today, it is GH¢10. Kenkey, which used to be GH¢5 is now GH¢7. So clearly, it shows that the Government of Ghana in the Budget presented by Dr Ato Forson is just not working. Therefore, every Ghanaian should know that the Budget the National Democratic Congress (NDC) keeps presenting to us is not a Budget that solves the problems of this country.

2:53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, is he citing Kempinski Hotel prices or Makola prices?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, continue.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, one other area the Minister for Finance has deliberated on in this House is the issue of “Big Push”. Even before the Minister started spending on the “Big Push”, we were told last year that they spent over GH¢10 billion on projects that we know have not started.

If we look at Appendix 2c on the second column of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, for the first part, they said they have spent GHC6.6 billion, and the second part, it says GHC3.2, but we all know in this country that the “Big Push” has not started. In fact, when they came to Takoradi to launch the “Big Push”, no contractor was introduced. The President was the contractor and at the same time, the person inaugurating the project.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, hold on. Hon Kwame Agbodza, you have the floor.

Mr Governs Kwame Agbodza: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I should let my Colleague flow in the debate. We beg of you, Mr Speaker, if Colleagues make statements—And I am grateful you gave me the opportunity.

My Colleague just said that the Minister for Finance said that we have spent GHC6 billion on “Big Push” and he is aware that the “Big Push” has not started. How can he even make that comment? When he knows in this House that we have listed projects that have started, and I have come here to say that some of the “Big Push” projects are already 30 per cent into the programme. So, if he does not know about these things, he should not say them. “Big Push” projects are on-site.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I think that you were able to manage the first two speakers. Mr Speaker, you can see that when you give opportunities on points of order, under Order 122, they abuse it. So with respect, let the debate flow and do not give chances to all these interjections. If they have something to say, there will be another speaker, they can hand it over to the person to make the corrections so we can move on.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if you watch me carefully, when a Member is commenting on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and our rules are breached, I know. Do not take it that I do not know when the rules are breached.

Dr Adam: Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me.

My name was mentioned by Hon Akurugu, saying that we used the money meant for the fertilisers to go and buy land for ourselves.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you realised that after Hon Akurugu had finished speaking, I gave the floor to Hon Amin Adam.

Dr Adam: No, I did not hear my name.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You stood up, but sat down again.

Dr Adam: No, I did not hear my name.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I did so; the record can bear me out. They can play the voice recording for you.

Dr Adam: Mr Speaker, I think she should provide evidence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I really mentioned your name.

Dr Adam: I did not hear you mention my name, Mr Speaker. And if you may indulge me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if you can keep quiet and listen to each other, I think it would be of great service to all of us. The record will show that I mentioned your name, but you said you did not hear me.

Dr Adam: Mr Speaker, I did not hear you mention my name. So, if you may indulge me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that time has lapsed. It is now the turn of Hon Okyere to make comments on the Floor. So, if you are up, you are interrupting him, and can you tell me the basis? Kindly resume your seat.

Dr Adam: She should provide evidence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Former Minister, kindly resume your seat. The floor is for Hon Okyere.

Dr Adam: That is not fair. Mr Speaker, it is not a fair ruling.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, we all know that “Big Push” is not a funding source; it is just a programme name. And if we are talking about new projects under the “Big Push”, there is nowhere in this Budget Statement that new projects have started under the “Big Push”. And therefore, any expenditure under the “Big Push” is for the former President, Nana Akufo-Addo’s projects. So the NDC cannot claim those projects.

Mr Speaker, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy also made mention of spending over GH¢292 million on sanitary pads. The same NDC, prior to 2025, during the 2024 campaign, made mention that they are going to go into what we call the 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, we have had different versions of the explanations for the 24-Hour Economy. But we all know that the youth of this country are looking for jobs, and that is why they bought into this project. I believe that spending GH¢292 million on just sanitary pads alone is not good enough. In fact, we should take part of that money to set up factories in every constituency in this country. At least, if we are even spending GH¢200,000 to set up a sanitary pad factory, we can provide sanitary pads and employ over 100 people per factory in all the constituencies in this country.

At least, that can be said to be maybe an “Agenda 276” instead of a 24-Hour Economy. So that the youth of this country can be employed, and they can produce the sanitary pads locally and supply the schools that we want to supply. Because with only US\$20,000,

we should be able to set up these factories across the length and breadth of our country.

Mr Speaker, one other area that has been talked about in this House is that any time we give advice, our Brothers on that Side—I have heard the Hon Member for Jirapa and Hon Adongo say that we have messed up the economy and that we handed them an economy that was messed up. But Mr Speaker, everybody in this country knows that before we took over power in 2017, the economy itself had been in a mess. If we look at the data for 2016 and that for 2024, you can see a marked improvement in this data.

Therefore, I believe that Ghanaians should know that those who messed up the economy were not the NPP; we came to fix the problem. We were all here when the NDC supervised the biggest banking loot in this country, costing the nation over GH¢30 billion. At that time, it was about US\$6 billion. It took the courage and the energy of the NPP administration to look for money to solve this problem. It was after that that COVID-19 also came to create additional problems. We were able to solve them to the extent that we took the growth rate under the first John Dramani administration, from 3.4 per cent to 5.7 per cent. So, nobody should be able to say this again in this House, that we messed up the economy. We never messed up the economy.

We were faced with challenges, and we were able to solve them. Under the NDC, there were no challenges in this country. And even with inflation, single

digits, they are only doing just about eight. In 2019, we had a single digit of 7.9 per cent inflation. So definitely, the NDC cannot debate with us and tell us that they are doing better than us.

3:03 p.m.

Everybody knows where they are getting their moneys for the dollar depreciation. Mr Speaker, I do believe that the biggest challenge we have in this country is that the structure of the economy has to be reorganised. Without productivity, we cannot naturally deal with the issue of depreciation of the cedi in this country.

Recently, when the Minister for Finance came to present the Budget, US\$1 was about GH¢10.7. Today, as we speak, we are looking at GH¢11.45 to the dollar. So clearly, the dollar is not stable—*[Interruption]*—You can check the Bank of Ghana rates—*[Interruption]*—We brought it down before we handed it over to you.

Mr Speaker, there is no way the NDC can do anything better than what we did in our term. I want to assure everybody that the choices the NDC are making now are not good choices. We need choices that will continue to support the growth of this country. It is important. When we were in power, they insisted there was no need for us to buy helicopters and jets for the Government and the army. Today, they have come back. They have to be principled. We cannot be running this country without principles. If they believe that we did not need it, why now? Why do we want to

use the taxpayers' money now for those purchases to put the President in executive jets? I believe that it is time to rethink, because the GH¢1.2 billion can be used in fixing the Accra-Kumasi Road where a lot of people have been dying. In fact, we just need a minimum of GH¢3.7 billion to complete the bypasses and get the dual carriage roads from Accra to Kumasi.

I believe that when we are able to spend that money better, deaths on that road will reduce, productivity will increase, and the structure of our economy will change so that we can naturally support our cedi, we can naturally support the growth and development and the creation of jobs in this country, so that more of our young people will be able to better benefit from the Budget that we have developed. With these few words, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I then proceed to give the floor to Mr Alfred Nii Kotey. You have five minutes.

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo): I am privileged to also comment on the Budget that Dr Ato Forson has come to lay before this House. It baffles me when I hear our Colleagues on the other Side churning out figures that we do not know where they are generated from. In fact, we were in this country when they churned out figures to the World Bank and gave Ghana conflicting figures. But because

the truth does not lie, they were caught *in flagrante delicto*. It means they were caught pants down.

It was clear what we all witnessed under the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government. It was obvious the economy was so malnourished that my Bukom brother in Bukom would call it a *kwashiorkor* economy. That is what we inherited. Today, we have a Government that has put better measures in place and we are all seeing the signs of the economy improving.

Let me go on to the specifics. In the area of health—Mr Speaker, if you permit, I would like to refer the House to page 183 of this Budget Statement. I want to lay emphasis on health. Under health alone, allocations made for 2026 is over GH¢22 billion, almost GH¢23 billion. These moneys, hitherto, would not have been gotten because under the NPP, they capped all those sectors and created inconveniences for NHIS and others. Today, we have uncapped it, and I do not want to go into the details because one of my Colleagues has done that already.

Mr Speaker, this money will be channeled into the NHIS Fund so that we will have moneys to pay claims, unlike what they faced that they could not pay. So Ghanaians will be confident when they take their health insurance card and say they are going to the hospital. Under the NPP, healthcare was so bad that even vaccines for children for what we used to call the six killer diseases—now it is more than that. We could not even get vaccines to save our children. Today,

infection prevention and control has been elevated such that all over the country, we see nurses going from one house to the other vaccinating children. We did not see that under NPP.

Mr Speaker, under this Government, we have been able to commence the development of the National Cleft Center at the Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital to save those who are suffering from that. They were in power for eight years. They did not see the need to do that. We have partnered organisations and we are developing that for Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, under emergency response, the National Ambulance Service, in just one year, has trained 500 emergency medical technicians. Under the NPP government, they could not do 500 in one year. Additionally, we were able to train 6,000 youth as first-aid responders under the National Ambulance Service. NPP could not achieve that.

Mr Speaker, on nursing training support, we have been able to make full payment for the nursing trainee allowances, something they made noise over. They made so much noise about it but they could not achieve that. They could not pay. Now, as we speak, 13,500 nurses have been placed on payroll. It is something they could not do as well. We are expanding health training institutions all over the country. We are giving accreditation to several new teaching centres as well. Under the NPP, they could not do it.

Mr Speaker, it will amaze you that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor. You have 15 minutes.

3:13 p.m.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy Debate. Let us be clear, this 2026 Budget must be evaluated and analysed in a context. The context is the basis on which the current NDC government under President Mahama came to office. Mr Speaker, they came to office on two fundamental pillars and commitment to the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, the first, is to implement policies, programmes and interventions, to reduce the cost of living and cost of doing business. The second is to create thousands of jobs for the teeming—to be pointing in the right direction. But it is also important for me to point out that this is principally as a result of the post COVID-19 Economic Recovery Plan by the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo Government—[*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, secondly, on account of the Domestic Gold Purchase Programme which was initiated by the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo Administration, indeed, in April 2024, specifically paragraph 232 of the 2024 Budget, it was projected that by the end of 2025, inflation will ease to 8 per cent. This Government committed to realising

these two commitments of reducing cost of living, cost of doing business and ensuring that they reduce unemployment in our country, principally on one major policy commitment they made to the Ghanaian people, particularly the Ghanaian youth, their 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, let me refer this House to chapter 2 of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) manifesto, specifically paragraph 2.1 on page 22, it reads;

“The 24-Hour Economic Policy, same jobs, three shifts, three people. The 24-Hour Economy is a deliberate policy intervention by the incoming NDC Administration to stimulate economic growth by creating an enabling environment for businesses and public institutions to operate 24/7 in three shifts of eight hours each.”

Mr Speaker, in August 2024, at the launch of the NDC Manifesto for the 2024 election, the then candidate Mr John Dramani Mahama, now President John Dramani Mahama had this to say. He said: “...The 24-Hour Economy is going to be coined in a slogan called 1-3-3 Formula”

This is very important. The President said that, the Ghanaian youth will have this opportunity. One person will start the same job at 8:00 a.m. and end at 4:00 p.m. that would be for eight hours. Then from 4:00 p.m. to 12 midnight, another eight hours, where a second Ghanaian youth will take over from 12 midnight to 8:00 a.m., then another Ghanaian youth will take over eight hours.

Mr Speaker, it means for one job, one person will work for eight hours from 8 a.m. to 4 p.m., another person will take the same job from 4 p.m. to 12 midnight, and the third person will take the job from 12 midnight to 8 a.m., Agenda 1-3-3 Formula. I want to contend and submit here, that the Ministry of Finance today, closes at 5:00 p.m. The Ministry of Finance is running an eight-hour economy. The Ministry of Finance is not running this 1-3-3 shift.

Mr Speaker, the 24-Hour Economy has not been implemented. Instead of that—since our Friends came into Government, all they have been doing is sacking Ghanaian youth who were employed by the previous Administration: this is a reality. You can check it out yourself. Across the length and breadth of our country, in all sectors of our national life and economy, thousands of innocent Ghanaian youth, some of them who are NDC and NPP sympathisers and others non-aligned. The ordinary Ghanaian citizen is being sacked. We are not getting a 24-Hour Economy. We are not getting agenda 1-3-3. We are rather getting the Ghanaian youth sacked. That is the lot of our opponents from this Side.

Mr Speaker, it is important for us to point out that the current state of the Ghanaian economy—the data may look good, the statistics may look good, but the truth is that the Ministry of Finance is not spending. Let us take a look at paragraph 123 of the 2026 Budget. The Budget indicates that for the first three quarters of 2025, the Ministry of Finance

had projected to spend the sum of GH¢207 billion.

The Minister of Finance in reporting to this House, has indicated that they have spent GH¢175.9 billion, a shortfall of 15 per cent. Let us be clear, governments spending anywhere in the world is a catalyst for growth. When Government spends, what they call the trickle-down economic effect, it trickles down to every Ghanaian. So, when you lock the vault, the treasury, and the exchequer and you do not spend, it affects everybody. It affects the nurses, contractors, farmers, each and every person. Let me leave you with one evidence.

This is real. I come from a rural Constituency, Damongo: a farming Constituency. Today, on 10th November, 2025, *Joy News* reported and they said; “Farmers cry out over unsold rice as one million metric tonnes rot in storage.”

Mr Speaker, we have been told today those one million metric tonnes of rice are packed in warehouses at an estimated value of GH¢15 billion; nobody can buy. In my Constituency, Damongo, maize and groundnut farmers are having a bad day. It is principally because Government is not spending, purchasing power is weakening, credit is unavailable, domestic produce cannot be absorbed, money circulation is low and liquidity is not in the system. That is why when you go out there on the streets of Ghana, the statement on the lips of many Ghanaians is that, the Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson’s money is just on paper.

Mr Speaker, he makes allocations as he did when he appeared before this House. He mentions, GH¢1 billion for agriculture, GH¢100 billion for this and that. But when you look at the actuals, releases are in many cases 30 per cent. The Minister for Finance, Dr Ato Forson’s money is only on paper; it is not in the pocket of ordinary citizens. It is not in the pocket of farmers, teachers, nurses and certainly not in the pocket of the unemployed, struggling Ghanaian youth. Our Friends must get it clear.

They can have all the data, the statistics and quieten the economy. They can close down economic activity and they would not have real economic growth in the real sectors. Their books would look good, but in the end, they would realise that on the streets, grassroots economists will tell you that people are really having a hard time.

Mr Speaker, Our Colleague Ministers on the other Side will attest to what I am saying. No jobs recruitments are happening in the ministries. Because Ministers will not get money to do their work. Ministries, departments and agencies are not receiving any payment, to be able to provide goods and services for the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, we want to caution and encourage this Government to get their priorities right. They should invest in the real sectors. They should invest in agriculture, infrastructure and the service industry. They should invest in manufacturing. They should invest in areas which will unleash jobs and prosperity for the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, but instead what are they spending on? By that, let me refer us to the Monetary Policy Report of the Bank of Ghana (BoG), dated September 2025, specifically page 21. Where the BoG, the central bank of our country has said the three major threats to the national economy of our country continue to be in their own words, increasing energy sector payments, revenue performance, rising compensation costs. The emphasis is on the rising compensation costs.

3:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we have been promised a lean government and we have been told that we have a lean government. But they have a lean government that is lean on the arms, lean on the limbs, lean in every part, but very bloated on the stomach, a *kwashiorkor* lean government.

Mr Speaker, they have a lean government where we have a special envoy for reparations, special envoy to the Caribbean regions, 18 deputy heads of Missions. If we want to get the evidence, this is your evidence

Mr Speaker, in 2024, the Office of the President during the Government of the distinguished and illustrious former President of our country, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, in 2024, spent GH¢326 million on compensation in paying government workers, Ministers, Deputy Ministers and presidential staffers.

Mr Speaker, in 2025, President Mahama's administration, Office of the President, has spent a whooping

GH¢540 million on compensation; 50 per cent increment. Why can we not interrogate this? They have one government that is supposed to have a bloated government, another government that is supposed to have a lean government, the government that has a lean government has spent GH¢ 356 million on compensation, that is salary, paying salaries to their workers. The bloated government rather spends GH¢ 547 million, 50 per cent more, which is why I say that this is a *kwashiorkor* or lean government. It is lean on the legs, and limbs, but bloated with consumption because they are spending a lot.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude. In spite of all these problems, the Government wants to spend—[*Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker*] when they cannot pay nurses and teachers, they cannot buy farm produce and cannot recruit workers. President Mahama taught us and reminded the country that President Akufo-Addo should take charge. He should not engage in blame game and that he is responsible for resolving the problems of this country. President Mahama should take charge and this mighty NPP Minority are saying that so far, so not well; so far, so not good; so far, so much unemployment and suffering. That is what this 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is offering the Ghanaian people, suffering and unemployment.

Mr Speaker, I thank you—[*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we agreed from the onset to allow free flow of debate, and we are all committed to that. But then we cautioned that we should be accurate in our statistics and our figures.

Mr Speaker, he said that in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy—He should just show us which line item contained in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy has an allocation or a proposal

Mr Speaker, it is important. This is a house of records. Otherwise, it would have to be expunged from the records of this House. Because nowhere in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, is—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* How much does the Air Force One cost for us to allocate—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor? Mention the page so that everybody can be with you.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to respond to the Hon Majority Leader and to answer his enquiry.

Mr Speaker, may I refer the House to page 184 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. On page 184 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, you will see “retooling of the Air Force” as well as “CAPEX”, meaning capital expenditure. I referred only to the two presidential jets. If you have the Budget Statement and Economic Policy with you, you will see at page 184, you will see at CAPEX that what is actually being

budgeted for the retooling of the Ghana Air Force is 2.5 billion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it US dollars or Ghana cedis?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: GH¢2.5 billion — *[Uproar]*—

GH¢2.5 billion to buy two presidential jets. Again, at paragraphs 1087 and 1091 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy the Government says that— *[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* is being programmed to buy two presidential jets, four helicopters

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are mentioning another paragraph

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, no, I am making a point—*[Uproar]*—the point I sought to make was that if we have this amount of money, teachers and nurses have not been paid, farmers' produce is not being bought and market women are complaining about purchases. There are numerous problems in our country. Why would Government spend— *[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr Speaker, that is the point I want to make— *[Hear! Hear!]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think that when the figure is quoted in Ghana cedis and you want to quote it from the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, you have to quote exactly what is in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Ghana cedis is different from US dollars.

Hon Members, because the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources quoted US dollars on the record but when given the opportunity mentioned Ghana cedis instead of US dollars—[*Uproar*]

3:33 p.m.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, this is a House of records—

Mr Mahama Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: This is a House of records and it is a matter of personal integrity. Let me state my position. I am prepared to be corrected if I am wrong but in this case, I am not and this is a matter of personal integrity. What I have said—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But in your debate you quoted dollars.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: It is the use of—
[*Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which page of the Budget?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: That is the point I am making, and you will find it at paragraph 1087 and 1091 of the Budget.

Mr Speaker, what I referred to in the Budget itself, is a retooling of Ghana Air

Force at the Capital Expenditure column. It says retooling of Ghana Air Force with an amount of—[*Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker*]

Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, and in all humility and modesty, I am a lawyer. I have checked my facts out; I have crossed my “T’s” and dotted my “I’s”. I know what I am talking about. It is— [*Expunged by the order of the Speaker*] [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Ayariga?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this is a House of records, and the Hon Member who just spoke is the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. He was a Cabinet Minister and I need not to lecture him on the value and importance of accuracy.

Mr Speaker, he referred us to page 184, and I have opened page 184. On the item numbered 34 under Ministry of Defence, let us go through the items. The third item there is retooling of the Air Force with the CAPEX figure of GH¢2,532,000,000. Mr Speaker— [*Interruption*].

Mr Speaker, I attended a primary school in Bawku. We may doubt the quality of the schools in Bawku, but I cannot imagine which primary school he attended, where he was taught that if he converts GH¢2 billion into dollars, he would get—[*Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker*] I do not know which primary school he attended. I attended a primary school in Bawku, and I know

that if we use the exchange rate at the Bank of Ghana, we would get US\$260 million. How can he say that when he converts GHC2 billion, he would get—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* What kind of mathematics did he learn in school? Which primary school did he attend? How can he convert GHC2 billion and get—*[Expunged by the orders of Mr Speaker]*

In any case, Mr Speaker, he said, the allocation was for a presidential jet. The records will bear us out. The videos are there. If it is—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* how much is Air Force 1?

Mr Speaker, he must withdraw, and it must be expunged from our records. This debate has been plagued with lies, inaccuracies, fabricated figures by the Minority in order to bolster their argument; we will not accept it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, an issue has been raised about you quoting—for presidential jets. We are debating the Budget, and you claimed that the figure is emanating from the Budget. The question is, take us to the Budget item that indicated

If you do not have it in the line item in the Budget, then do the honourable thing.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, and I particularly thank you for your indulgence, as this matter borders on my personal integrity.
3:43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if I got it wrong, I will have no difficulty withdrawing, apologising and moving on. But, Mr Speaker, let me crave your indulgence, by indicating to my senior Brother, the Hon Majority Leader, that I also went to Fufulso Primary School in the Savannah Region. The Hon Majority Leader asked where I attended my basic school. I attended my basic school in Fufulso Primary School in the Savannah Region. When I was in primary school, I sat on the floor, and I was in a modest primary school. I know that the Hon Majority Leader, having attended school in Bawku, proceeded to school in Harvard, and he has had very great height, which is commendable. I salute him for that. Like many Ghanaians, I schooled in modest circumstances.

Mr Speaker, before I proceed, I would plead—I know you are a man of fairness and justice, and I know that you will not allow any Hon Member of this House, regardless of their status to disrespect, to denigrate, to demean me and by extension, the thousands and millions of Ghanaians who went to school in deprived communities.

Mr Speaker, before I proceed to answer the question, and with the greatest of respect to you, may I very humbly and kindly plead with my senior Brother, the Hon Majority Leader, the Leader of this House, the man who leads all of us, and the man who guides all of us, to kindly do the needful by withdrawing and apologising to my modest humble self and the thousands of

Ghanaians for this insult, before I proceed. *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order! Order! Hon Members, let us listen to each other in silence. So, just answer my question and in conclusion, you will see what I will do. *[Uproar]* Hon Members, I have listened to both Sides and I know what to do in the circumstances. So, let us get the main issue resolved and I will give consequential orders, so, my question is on the floor.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order!

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, may I proceed?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you have the floor.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, out of respect for you, I will proceed to give the answer. In giving the answer, Mr Speaker, I refer the House to page 136 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Mr Speaker, page 136, specifically, paragraph 1091 and 1092.

“1091. Mr Speaker, the Ghana Air Force will be retooled. Beginning 2026, the Government of Ghana will begin the procurement processes for the acquisition of four modern helicopters, one long-range and one medium-range aircrafts.

1092. Mr. Speaker, these aircrafts are expected to be delivered in four years' time, if the procurement processes are completed in 2026.”

[Uproar] And then, Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, why?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I then refer the House to page 184 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Mr Speaker, under item 34, titled Ministry of Defence, where it is captured, “Retooling of the AirForce.”, where the CAPEX is quoted as GHC2.5 billion. Mr Speaker, if we multiply that by four years, which the Minister for Finance has indicated in page 136 — *[Uproar]* — Mr Speaker, every year they will provide for it.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude that the statement I made in my contribution to the debate of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy is on firm grounds and on terra firma. They are beginning this year, and they are going to continue for four years—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker] [Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order!

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we are waiting for the apology.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order! Before I begin to name and shame. No one judges a swimmer by showing the certificate on the shore. The

Budget Statement and Economic Policy is before us, and I can conclusively say that nowhere in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy has the dollar been indicated. This is because in all the relevant pages that were referred to, we can all see that dollar has not been mentioned.

Therefore, the submission referring to page 136 as well as page 184 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy—we all have copies of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy and we cannot see any dollar mentioned. Paragraph 1091 and 1092 has been mentioned but if you look at those paragraphs, as a matter of fact, they never mentioned any figure.

Hon Members, I will consequentially order that because the Hon Member did not refer to a specific page in which the dollar is indicated, everything said by the Hon Member in dollar should be expunged completely from the record.

Now Hon Majority Leader, the Hon Member indicated clearly that because you said you have attended basic school somewhere but you do not know which school he has attended, he has taken offence to that. So, Hon Majority Leader, you are Brothers and Friends so I will call on you to have that withdrawn and then we can make progress.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, Fufulso Primary School is a very good primary school. I know senior civil servants and academics who are products of Fufulso Primary School. I know that the Hon Member had a good math teacher in that

school—*[Laughter]*—Because I know that he had a good math teacher in that school, I am surprised that when he converts GH¢2 billion into dollars, he gets—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* I was surprised because I know the school is very good, and I know he had a good math teacher. So, it is obvious that it is not the school. The school is good; the math teacher was good. But how he got— *[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* from GH¢2 billion still baffles me.

Mr Speaker, if he feels offended, I, who went to a primary school in Bawku was taught to apologise and withdraw. So, I apologise and I withdraw. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we need to make progress.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, thank you—
3:53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I have not given you the floor.

Hon former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources,

Hon Members, we need to make progress. I am not giving you the floor.

Hon former Minister for Land and Natural Resources, kindly resume your seat. Hon Members, how long are we going to continue to debate this issue? The Hon Member has withdrawn and apologised to you.

Mr S. A. Jinapor, we gave you the opportunity, and you referred us to pages 136 and 184 of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. What you said is not contained in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. That is why I have directed that it be withdrawn or expunged from the record. Our friends in the media have indicated again that the Hon Member referred us to paragraphs 136 and 184. I have not seen any 1.2 billion in paragraph 136. I have not seen it in paragraph 184. So accordingly, I have directed that the same should be expunged from the record. Can we make progress?

Hon Minority Chief Whip, I intend not to open this debate again, so we should make progress. With all due respect, Hon Minority Chief Whip, we have closed the curtain on this with an apology emanating from the Minister. He has withdrawn and apologized—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Leader spoke—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He took offence from something, and he has withdrawn and apologised.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we in Leadership have a responsibility—unless you do not want me to speak. This Parliament has two Sides, regardless of their numbers. Let us look at the figures. Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader got up three times and caught your attention. I have been trying to catch your attention.

Mr Speaker, we want to get to the bottom of this matter. I invite you to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic

Policy. Everybody should take the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Those who have copies should take it. Mr Speaker, I insist. Come with me to page 1—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, we have resolved this particular matter—[Uproar]

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: You should listen to us. Mr Speaker, I invite you—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, there is a principle that he who asserts must attempt to prove. You are not making any assertion—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I want to prove to you that what the Member said is true. It is captured in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are not making any assertion. I have given him the opportunity, and he took us to the relevant pages from which he is speaking—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I thank you, Mr Speaker. We will settle this matter here. With the greatest respect, you can take the Budget. Mr Speaker, if you have the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I am starting from page 184. If you look at page 184, item numbered 34, “Retooling of Air Force”, the figure there is GHC2.6 billion. Write it down. Let us move on to page 190, which is a commitment for 2027, under the same description, “Retooling of the

Air Force”, and that is GHC3.5 billion. Let us move on. Mr Speaker, at page 196, under the same description, “Retooling of the Air Force”, and that is GHC3.3 billion as against the year 2028.

Mr Speaker, come with me to page 202. Under the same description, “Retooling of the Air Force”, it comes up to GHC3.5 billion. Mr Speaker, I attended Ho Anglican Primary School—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have moved away from the school that we have attended.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, it is just by the way.

Mr Speaker, when you put all that together, granted that their mathematics is so bad, if we put all four together, it comes up to GHC12.9 billion. I want to convert to dollars. [*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, do a simple arithmetic, divide that figure by 10, you would get some GHC1.29 billion dollars—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are dividing it by what?

Hon Minority Chief Whip, you are dividing it by what?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I want to conclude.

Our Majority Leader’s Bawku Mathematics is a suspect. Majority Leader, revisit your Bawku Mathematics.

Mr Speaker, we are not inventing these figures. These figures were prepared at the instance of the President by the Minister for Finance. Majority Leader, do not oscillate. If he doubts these figures, I quoted the pages and the figures to him. If he doubts it, he should come back and respond to these figures—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Minority Chief Whip. Are you done?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I am not done. We have insisted in all our presentations—it has been based on facts, and we have continuously referenced the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I believe you would agree with me that all the pages that you have referred to and all the figures that you have quoted, none is in dollars. [*Uproar*]

Yes, Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I want to conclude so that he can speak. He is the Leader of the House, and he has had so much time. Let me conclude. My respected Ranking Member was on all fours in terms of the facts. One can argue that the figure is not quoted in dollars, but one can do the conversion. When you do the conversion, he is not far from right. I beg you. We do not need to belabour the point.

4:03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, why should you be converting the figure when it is quoted in our legal tender.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let us not forget what the issue was. Let us get back to what was really the issue. The Hon Member in the debate—[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, I think you have to stop what you are doing.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, what was the issue? In Hon Abdulai Jinapor's comments, he said that we were—[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker] That was why I got up. I usually do not interrupt debate. I have a book and I take note of everybody's arguments. As I am sitting, I am writing. I take note of everybody's arguments because I will have an opportunity to respond in the end. But when we throw out figures out there that we are buying—[Expunged by the orders of Mr Speaker] the cameras captured it. We can play it back. That was why I got up and said no, it is not possible. I even asked him how much does the Air Force I cost.

So clearly, he was wrong. When he now gets up and says that all commitments for the next four years for retool—[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am observing carefully the disorderly conducts.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I was in this Chamber, I think more than a decade, before many of them arrived. We have done worse things than what they are doing. So, I can assure them, it will not stop me from making the point I want to make today, even if we have to sit here till midnight, my point will be made.

The point is that he—[Expunged by the orders of Mr Speaker] when he said that we are spending—[Expunged by the orders of Mr Speaker] [Uproar] He—[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker], and he is now trying to correct himself by saying that all commitments for the next four years to retool the Air Force is—

[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]

Some Hon Members — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, with all due respect, the statement may not be correct, but the use of the word—I will direct that it is expunged. Hon Members, order! I have given my directives, so all should resume their seats.

Hon Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if there is nothing in the Budget that says that the Government is buying—[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker] and a Member stands and says that the Government is

buying—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]*. and when we try to correct him, he goes and takes a four-year commitment for retooling the Air Force, and now says that it justifies his earlier misrepresentation. He misrepresented the issue; it is not in the 2026 Budget we are discussing.

It is possible for us to change the figures in 2027. We can change the figures in 2028, depending on the performance of the economy. So, I do not have a problem. I am not running away from spending—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* to retool our Air Force. On the contrary, we in the NDC are very proud that we are able to spend—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* to retool our Air Force.

They ran the economy down; they mismanaged the economy and could not even raise money to support the Air Force. We are confident. We are proud. We are happy that we have the capacity, and in the next four years, we will retool the Ghana Air Force, and we will invest—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]* in the Air Force. *[Uproar]*

[Members of the Majority chanted]

So, Mr Speaker, I still stand my grounds: when he said that we are purchasing—*[Expunged by the order of the Speaker]* it is not in the records, and your decision that it should be stripped of the records is right. If one tabulates all planned expenditure on retooling the Air Force, not buying a presidential jet, I will oppose. I will lead this House; I will lead this Side, and if they do not support me,

I will lead whoever is willing to be led, to oppose using US\$1.2 billion of our money to buy a presidential jet. I will oppose it. But, Mr Speaker, I am happy; I am proud. I support the Minister for Finance to, in the next four years, invest US\$1.2 billion in retooling our Air Force. I support it. *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, former Minister for Defence?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader is the leader of the House, and he is supposed to, together with the others, help control the House. But when he misleads the House—*[Uproar]*—especially considering the fact that I am seated here, I have the right to correct him.

Mr Speaker, we came to this House in July 2022 and I laid in this House the purchase of six LNG Fighter Jets for this nation. The commitment we gave this nation as the cost of the aircraft at that time was €150 million, at a rate of GH¢15 to €1. If calculated, that is GH¢1.6 billion. We committed this nation to one-time purchase, not four years, to GH¢1.6 billion. So, when he says that we did not do it, that is not true. That is the first thing I want him to know.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, it is a fact that their Side, led the rejection of the purchase of just one presidential jet. Today they want to buy two, and they will not apologise to the people of Ghana. I will get the chance to speak

tomorrow. I will tell us why there are two presidential jets.

So when they say that we did not do it, that is not true. That is the first thing I want them to know.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, it is a fact that their Side led the rejection of the purchase of just one presidential jet, and today, they want to buy two. Yet, they do not want to apologise to the people of Ghana.

4:13 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, the issue on the floor is that, as a former Minister for Defence, does retooling amount to the purchase of presidential jets?

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I will say it, but I will repeat it tomorrow. Let me read page 136, paragraph 1091.

“Mr Speaker, the Ghana Air Force will be retooled. Beginning 2026, the Government of Ghana will begin the procurement processes for the acquisition of four modern helicopters, one long-range and one medium-range aircraft.”

These are presidential jets. A long-range aircraft is not for the Air Force. It is for their comfort. These are presidential jets. Boeing jets or Airbus jets are the long ones. And I mentioned that we needed one because they carry not less than 100 people. The medium-range carries at least 25 people. They are

all presidential jets. They are not military jets.

But tomorrow, I will expand on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, once you have chosen to set your questions instead of answering them. Kindly resume your seat.

Mr Nitiwul: They are not military jets; they are presidential jets meant for the comfort of the Executive, not for the soldiers. But tomorrow I will expand because I will get my chance. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, when it comes to the military, I may be a layman, but I do not understand retooling to amount to the purchase of presidential jets. I have looked at the relevant pages referred to by the Minority Chief Whip for four years. I have not seen any quotation of any amount in dollars. I still stand by my directives that everything said by Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor relating to US\$1.2 billion be expunged from the record as not being correct. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Hon Members, let us make progress.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We want to thank you for your directives. But we on this Side are not worried even in the least. All we will say is that the Hon Member did not say anything inaccurate. I will leave this for another day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Thomas Worlanyo. You have five minutes.

Mr Thomas Worlanyo Tsekpo (NDC — Hohoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to also comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, I am very surprised to see our Colleagues try to find one fault in this beautiful document that has given hope to the people of Ghana, the ordinary man on the streets. It was a great surprise that they brought all their mathematicians and calculators to the Front Bench, calculating figures to find one fault. Thank God they could not find one.

Mr Speaker, it is also a surprise to hear them propound solutions to problems they could have solved in the last eight years. Today, we have taken over and provided solutions to the problems that they have created. Today, some market women in Hohoe called me, and they were very happy. Because, according to them, the Budget was written to their understanding. The Value Added Tax (VAT) reforms that the Government has brought will relieve most of them of tax burdens.

Mr Speaker, I heard one of our senior Colleagues talk about food inflation, and how people are not able to buy a lot of things. Because I am a bachelor, I went to the market yesterday and was able to buy what they were talking about. Last year, Christmas, this rice, which is Abena rice, [*Hon Member displays a bag*

of rice], was sold at GH¢164. This Frytoil [*Hon Member displays a bottle of oil*] was sold at GH¢60. Just yesterday, I bought the rice for GH¢99 and the oil for GH¢39 — [*Hear! Hear!*] — . This is evidence of the economy that we have transformed from where they left it, the junk status, to the status that we have.

Mr Speaker, according to the market women, the COVID-19 levy that will be taken out of the Budget next year, which one of the Members of Parliament says has not been taken out, is going to be put back in the pocket about GH¢3.7billion. All this is good news for our businessmen, traders, and the ordinary man on the street.

Mr Speaker, on unemployment, last year, the former Vice President said he created 2.1 million jobs, which is more than the unemployed Ghanaians in the country. We have come out with holistic programmes that will give jobs to our people. Eight hundred thousand jobs have been mentioned in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Eight hundred thousand jobs to be created in all angles.

Mr Speaker, one is the 24-Hour Economy. Today, when one goes to the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency (DVLA) office in Adenta, they run a 24-hour shift. The Passport Office also runs a 24-hour shift. It means we began something last year, and we are going to continue.

Mr Speaker, when we look at Agriculture, Modernisation, and Agro-Industry Jobs under the Ministry of Food

and Agriculture, Feed Ghana, summer service centre and farm banks are creating jobs for the youth, including our Brothers on the other Side, the NPP Members. All of them are getting jobs, and that is unlike the failed projects that they introduced, which collapsed under their watch just last year.

Mr Speaker, aside from this, we have the Youth Employment Agency, the Digital Skills, the One Million Coders programme, and digital centres that are opening regional offices to create more jobs for our youth. The Youth in Apprenticeship Programme has been allocated—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

I will give the floor to Hon Nana Asafo-Adjei. You have 15 minutes.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I am grateful for the opportunity to also comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy made by the Minister for Finance for and on behalf of the President of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, before I begin, I want to pay tribute to the young ladies who lost their lives during the military recruit stampede. I share with their families, and I want to console each and every young person who fell victim as part of that job recruitment stampede. Those from Kumasi, those in Accra and the rest of the country.

Mr Speaker, this brings me to a very important point, which is job creation. These young men and women left home to look for jobs. Mr Speaker, not just any jobs, but secured sustainable jobs. That is what they went to look for. When the Minister for Finance in 2025 read the Budget, some young men of this country were happy with that Budget, as the Minister for Finance made some provision for job creation.

Mr Speaker, he mentioned the National Apprenticeship Programme, where he allocated GH¢300 million for that project. He mentioned the Adwumawura Programme, where he allocated GH¢100 million to that programme. He mentioned the Digital Job Initiative, the One Million Coders, and allocated GH¢100 million to that. Then *nkoko nkitinkiti*, he allocated GH¢245 million. The Agriculture for Jobs and the National Employment Trust Fund.

Mr Speaker, when we were making comments on the Budget here, I reminded my Colleagues on the other Side that President John Dramani Mahama, and the *Hansard* will bear me out, is not a new entity in the scheme of things. We know him; he has been a president before. I recounted the things he mentioned to entice the youth. Yet, he failed to achieve them.

Mr Speaker, I mentioned the Ghana Youth Empowerment and Entrepreneurial Agency (GYEEDA) Programme. I mentioned the Savanna Accelerated Development Authority (SADA) Tree Planting Programme. I

mentioned the *Nkonfem* Programme. I mentioned the youth in bead making. I mentioned the youth in pothole patching. I mentioned the youth in movie-making. All these were programmes that President John Dramani Mahama promised the young people, but ended up as a sham.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the appropriation, or the disbursement, all the programmes I have mentioned here, some of them did not even get any allocation at all. Those who got allocation were not more than 20 per cent. So, the young people in this country who were hoping for jobs to be created by the 2025 Budget ended up not having any jobs.

Mr Speaker, again, when we look at the 2026 Budget, he has rehashed and mentioned these same programmes. He mentioned the *Adwumawura* Programme and allocated GHC160; he allocated GHC250 million to *nkoko nketenkete*, in the National Coders, he allocated GHC100 million. The National Apprenticeship Programme, he mentioned GHC300 million, but has now reduced it to GHC100 million in the 2026 Budget.

Now, in the 2025 Budget, they did not mention any figure, but told us in this House that the National Coordinator for the 24-Hour Programme will come to this House. Mr Speaker, he came to this House to put his figures, and the Programme was launched.

At the launch of that programme, they mentioned that the 24-Hour Programme,

which is the flagship programme of the NDC, would require GHC4 billion. In that document, the component of the Government's commitment to that 4billion will be seven per cent, and that is GHC280 million.

Mr Speaker, when we look into the allocation of the 2026 Budget, the Minister and Government allocated GHC110 million. That GHC100 million in dollars is US\$11 million, which is 3.92 per cent of the allocation they provided. The question I want to ask is whether this Government is committed to job creation. Should the youth who are looking up to this Government to create jobs still be hopeful?

Again, in the Budget, there were some components of jobs that they were going to create. They mentioned that they were going to create 800,000 jobs. Four hundred and ninety thousand jobs out of the 800,000 are going to come from the "Big Push". First and foremost, the allocation to the "Big Push" is questionable based on the 2025 disbursement.

Second, when we look at the World Bank report, it says that only 13 per cent of Ghanaian young men have sustainable jobs, and the majority of the Ghanaians who are out there, who died at El-Wak, those who were stampeded in Kumasi, are skilled labourers and professionals. Mr Speaker, yet the major component of the jobs by the 800,000 jobs are going to labourers and *kponkpon* work.

Mr Speaker, out of the 800,000 jobs, 250,000 are going to come from the

National Policy on Oil Palm Development. It is a good initiative, I commend it, but what is interesting is that in the 2026 Budget, paragraph 929 states that the oil palm programme is one that starts from 2026 to 2032. So, the 250,000 jobs they are even mentioning are not for 2026, but 2032. Yet again, they are not sustainable jobs but temporary jobs.

Mr Speaker, I want to submit on this point and say that the youth of this country have been deceived. The youth of this country who queued and were singing “Mahama is the hope”.

[Members of the Majority Caucus sang “Mahama is the hope”]

The youth have ended up singing “Mahama adaadaa me”

[Members of the Minority Caucus sang “Mahama adaadaa me”]

Mr Speaker, what is important here is that there is a hidden agenda of non-job creation. The austerity measures of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) are hidden in this Budget. I will take you back to the 2025 Budget, paragraph 478, and with your permission, I will read:

“In 2025, Government will implement the following measures to keep the wage bill within sustainable levels:

- i. Consistent with our fiscal consolidation agenda, Government will rationalise public sector payroll through

headcounts and biometric registration, among others.

- ii. Heads of Services and public institutions are to undertake internal restructuring to place staff in understaffed areas and undertake training to reskill or upskill others.”

The public services and recruitment again did not find expression in the 2026 Budget. This tells us that the hidden IMF agenda of austerity measures is playing here. And the youth of this country have no hope and nowhere to turn to.

4:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I again want to submit to the youth who are hoping and looking forward to the President and this Government to give them jobs, that there is no commitment of this Government to create jobs. None! Mr Speaker, a government that is interested in creating jobs now allocates GH¢290 million for the distribution of sanitary pads, and allocates GH¢100 million for the training of 1 million coders. The youth out there, I am telling you that the distribution of sanitary pads is more important to the NDC Government than the training of the coders they mentioned. The National Apprenticeship Programme has been allocated GH¢170 million, yet sanitary pads have been allocated GH¢292 million. The Adwumawura has been allocated GH¢160 million, while sanitary pads have been allocated GH¢292 million. I am not surprised that all these things put together is telling the youth of this

country that their hope is hopeless, and there is nothing to look out for in the NDC administration or the NDC Budget, particularly the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, I am saddened that the President made some mentions of allocations in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, yet nothing was done about it. It gives me so much difficulty to believe and accept the allocations that were mentioned in the 2026 Budget. Mr Speaker, in paragraph 629, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy mentioned the creation of the Ho Airport, making it a training hub. Mr Speaker, nothing of that happened. Now, when you come to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, he mentioned again in paragraph 999 that the Bolgatanga Airport will be created. If I am somebody in Bolgatanga, I will not believe this Government because even the people in Ho have not had their allocation to the airport in 2025.

Again, he mentioned in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that there is an allocation of GH¢242.5 million to the victim support of Akosombo Dam spillage. That support to the Akosombo Dam spillage never happened. Now they are making another allocation in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that GH¢500 million is being allocated to the victims of the dam spillage. Mr Speaker, I ask, is it an addition to the GH¢242 million that was in the 2025 Budget, or they have scrapped the GH¢242.5 million and they are now giving them a new GH¢500 million? Clearly, the commitment of the

Government to job creation is questionable. It is in doubt, and it is not something we must place our—

I am not surprised that the President is now rather committing to the purchase of—*[Expunged by the order of the Speaker]* Our Side still holds the argument; we still stand by it—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, as was admitted by the Majority, that is fair. Our position and the prices for the purchase of the—*[Expunged by the order of the Speaker]* We are surprised that there are important commitments that need to be done for the young people of this country to have jobs, yet the NDC Government is interested in—*[Expunged by the order of the Speaker]* Mr Speaker with these few words I thank you for the opportunity and I am grateful for the contribution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, would you kindly withdraw the phrase—

I will again give consequential directives that nowhere is it stated in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that US\$1.2 billion will be used to purchase aircraft. Accordingly, same is ordered to be expunged from the record as not being a correct statement.

I will then give the floor to Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey.

Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (NDC — Keta): You are saying *hwan?* Look at me very well. No amount of propaganda, no amount of voodoo calculation, no amount of *odeshie*

calculation will stop me from setting the record straight.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for giving me an opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year: Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation. The vision of this Government is anchored on agriculture. Agriculture is the way to go. In the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it is stated clearly that Government is embarking on commercialisation, modernisation, mechanisation, value-driven and market-driven, youth and women-led centred policies. This means that the youth and the women are there. So when it comes to “gendered” budget, gender factors have been factored into the agriculture.

As I speak to you, I am not going to talk about the whole policy because in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it is like the good book, the Bible. There are so many things in it that we cannot finish today. I will just dwell on two policies. One of them is the national policy on integrated oil palm development from 2026 to 2030. Ordinarily, in policies or strategic documents, it is five or six years. So, what they stipulated in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy is correct; six years is the framework for the oil palm. Mr Speaker, this is the red gold and this is the way Ghana should go.

Previously, we were leading in the production of oil palm. We were able to bring the Malaysians to Ghana and

taught them. At the end of the day, they are moving faster than us. Mr Speaker, as I speak to you, Ghana is importing over 200,000 metric tonnes of palm oil into this country. When you check on the palm oil markets, a tonne of palm oil is going for about US\$1,000. If you multiply it by 200,000 metric tonnes, Ghana is woefully losing about US\$200 million. In terms of that, it can do a lot for this country.

In this light, the red gold is going to bring a lot of jobs for the youth and women and a lot of foreign exchange also. In terms of the value chain of the red gold, the palm tree takes about four to five years to fruit. Meanwhile, it will take you 25 good years of continuous harvesting before you replant. Then in terms of replanting it, the palm tree can be used for palm wine, and *akpeteshie*.

Mr Speaker, as I speak to you, when you look at the palm in terms of fruits and drinks, we have palm oil, palm wine, palm sugar, palm kernel oil—*[Interruption]*—He should do his research because he does not know. He should do his research; there is palm sugar. Bio shell fuel, palm kernel cake, palm oil, and palm kernel oil. In terms of construction industry, the palm leaves are used for making roof for shelter, and for fencing. The trunks are used for log, pillars, and the leaves and fibres are woven into basket etc, as well as wall woven materials.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member for Suhum, why are you shouting?

4:33 p.m.

Mr Gakpey: In terms of households, the palm tree can be used for broom, furniture, and utensils. The nut can be used to craft utensils. These are all value, in terms of the value chain of palm alone. If government is investing in palm plantation, it is the way to go. This is going to generate about 250,000 jobs when the plantation takes off. Government is going to cultivate over 100 hectares of palm plantation. Government is putting over US\$500 million into this investment which is fulfilling, when you look at SDG 14, life below water.

In view of this, this is the way to go. I urge everyone, including our Colleagues on the other Side, to take this initiative positively. So, when they say that this Budget has nothing in it, I disagree with them. There is good news in this Budget Statement. So, it is a good initiative and all hands must be on deck to actually move on with this policy.

Mr Speaker, it will marvel you to know that, it is only in this era that a Budget Statement will be read without a Bible quotation. No Bible quotation was read, but in view of this, I want to give my Colleagues one Bible quotation. They should go to Psalm 145 or 1 Chronicle 16:34—*[Interruption]*—listen to the wisdom. The Lord is good to all and his tender mercy are all over President Mahama and the Minister for Finance. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, these are the good news in this Budget Statement.

Mr Speaker, I will quickly move to aquaculture. This year, this Government was able to take the revised version of the Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 and it was passed by this House. The Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025, (Act 1146) was marked as one of the turning points with regard to the fisheries industry in this country.

As I speak to you, Cabinet has approved Ghana's first maritime protected area, which very soon will be in this House, because the National Petroleum Authority (NPA) is very crucial. Why will Ghana need this? It was actually located at the Greater Cape Three Points into the Western Region where the protection of this endangered species will rest and the eco-marine system and then the fish habitat will continue to grow. Because there is shortage of fish in Ghana.

Ghana is importing a lot of fish in millions of dollars. When we go into aquaculture, the millions of dollars that are actually going out of this country, can remain in this country and that can boost our local economy. This aquaculture initiative is going to unlock the full potential of the ocean economy.

One of the things I would like to say is that, Government is on course with the National Blue Economy and the National Blue Economy is anchored on Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) 14, which talks about life below the water.

One good thing about the law we passed is the Exclusive Economic Zone

(EEZ), which has been extended from six nautical miles to 12 nautical miles and that is good news for our fisher folks. Government has allocated a lot of resources to aquaculture. Why am I saying this? Government has allocated an amount of GH¢100 million for aquaculture, where 200 farmers will be involved and then 50 professionals will be trained to actually guide them. Women and youth will benefit from this project.

In addition to that, on input alone, Government has also budgeted about GH¢50 million.

In terms of mini harbour and markets, Government has allocated GH¢50 million for doing that in the next year. So, if you claim that there is no good news in this Budget, these are some of the good news I am sharing with you. So, this Government is committed and the Budget is inclusive in terms of gender issues. There is transparent budget tracking and accountability in terms of inclusivity in the Budget Statement.

In all, I would like to urge the House to fast-track the approval of the Budget, so that the good news in this Budget would kick off.

Mr Speaker, I would like to use this opportunity to thank you for giving me the opportunity to comment on this Budget.

Thank you very much for giving me the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will give the floor to Mrs Korkor Laurette Asante. You have 15 minutes.

Ms Korkor Laurette Asante (NPP — Atiwa West): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented by the Hon Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy presented to this House last week paints a glowing picture of prosperity and transformation. But beneath the glossy language and rhetoric, lies a document full of half-baked measures, inconsistencies and misguided fiscal priorities. The NDC Government has left Ghanaians high and dry. They have left Ghanaians and kicked them to the curb.

Mr Speaker, the Government plans to purchase four helicopters, two jets and two offshore vessels, what my great-grandmother in my constituency would call two ships. This will cost a whopping GH¢12 billion and over, which some of my constituents and other average Ghanaians can understand in Twi as *ɔpipiipii*. Do we know what that money can do for the average Ghanaian to ease their lives, like my constituents in Kwabeng, Nwoso and Pameng, at the time that the Government is asking Ghanaians to sacrifice more? This is a clear case of *Medɔfo adaada me* Budget.

Mr Speaker, how come the Government seeks to purchase four helicopters with landing gear? It means it

is extremely expensive. Two offshore vessels and two presidential jets—*[Interruption]*. Hon Members, please listen to me, this is very important. I am not playing partisan politics here. At a time when the maternal mortality rate in Ghana is rising—I made a Statement on this last week and with facts, when young women are dying during childbirth or immediately after childbirth, which could be prevented because their causes are known and treatable. It is heartbreaking. It breaks my heart when I see the funeral flyers of these young women who probably have recently married, dying—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mrs Korkor Laurette Asante, I will ask that they should stop your time.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: I would not ordinarily do this, but you have given firm directives that we should stay within the terms of the Budget in making our comments. There is nowhere in this document that this Government is purchasing presidential jets. By all means, comments on the matter stated on page 135 and paragraph 1075 onwards—But do not deliberately label them presidential jets. They are not. So, the guide—*[Interruption]*. Please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Mr Dafeamekpor: The guide given by the Speaker is something that should be binding on all of us. Let us be guided, then we can enjoy the comments.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Minority Leader, you have the floor.

4:43 p.m.

Mrs Patricia Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I think we have a clear identification of aircrafts that are meant for military or defence intervention and aircrafts that are for normal travels and for the Presidency. I do not think it is very wrong to say or imply that this is a presidential jet—*[Uproar]*—and it is something—We cannot change it. It is because when on this Side, the Majority denied us the opportunity to do so, that is why they want to hide from it.

But there is no gain saying that, that particular aircraft, described in this thing, is a presidential jet, and we want to insist on that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is not what is stated in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy; it may be your own interpretation. Yes, Hon Korkor Asante, you have the floor.

Mrs Asante: Mr Speaker, as I was saying, how can the Government seek to purchase jets, helicopters, and offshore vessels, when cocoa farmers were given a paltry 12.27 per cent increase, which is about GH¢396 increase in price this year, when public sector workers were given a mere 9 per cent increase, when emergency care is practically non-

existent in Ghana because of the failure of our emergency care system which remains severely under-resourced, or entirely absent.

When basic life-saving skills, like defibrillators—when we go to other countries, they are in supermarkets and public places; they do not cost anything to jump start a person's heart, if they have a heart attack—when ventilators and oxygen are missing and lacking in regional and district hospitals, when the country lacks catheterisation labs in regional or district hospitals to diagnose and treat heart attacks and heart conditions, as a result, patients die in transit.

We all remember Dr Kwame Adu Ofori, at Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital, a dedicated doctor, who saved lives. He was an emergency room doctor, and yet, when he needed his life to be saved, when he needed an intervention, there was no catheterisation lab at Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital. So, what happened? He had to be transferred to Accra, and he died on the way. Is that not heartbreaking? So, I want my Hon Members on the other Side, to think about Dr Adu Ofori before they approve the jets and the vessels. Because if a catheterisation lab—and a catheterisation lab does not cost that much. It is used for diagnostic treatment, so it does not cost that much.

Yet, in spite of the urgent needs of the Ghanaian people, the NDC Government still plans to buy the two jets, four helicopters, and two ships. The cost of these jets, helicopters and vessels can

provide many catheterisation labs, life-saving tools and medicines to equip regional and district hospitals to prevent tragedies. This significant sum, Mr Speaker, can be better directed towards health and education, which have a more direct, positive impact on the livelihood of the ordinary Ghanaian.

Mr Speaker, will traders who are suffering sit in the two jets? No. Will farmers who are suffering sit in the four helicopters? No. Will teachers who are suffering travel in the two jets? No. Will the nurses who are suffering use the offshore vehicles or ships? No.

Mr Speaker, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy does not have any immediate relief for the high utility tariffs. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy failed to announce specific strong measures to drastically reduce the base tariffs that households pay for electricity and water. High utility costs remain a significant burden on families every month. The Government's approach to utility costs does not provide for immediate and direct subsidies or tariff cuts for households. Electricity tariffs saw three increases this year at least, 14.75 per cent in May, 2.45 per cent on July 1st, and 1.14 per cent in August 2025. Water tariffs also rose by 4.02 per cent on 3rd May, 2025. But what the Government plans to do, again, is to buy two jets, four helicopters and two ships. The Government's priorities are clearly misplaced.

Mr Speaker, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy also lacks a well-defined roadmap for execution of stalled

projects. Despite the allocation of GH¢100 million for completion of 10 Agenda 111 hospitals. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy lacks detailed execution plans necessary to resolve the backlog of these stalled projects quickly and comprehensively. Specifically, there was no clear project-by-project schedule or phase completion date, meaning that the communities cannot determine when the hospitals will be completed. Is it the first quarter of 2026, the second quarter or the third quarter; they cannot determine.

This leads to fears in the community, that the very commitment is too limited and risks further delays, frustrating local community members who are anxiously waiting for these benefits, like my constituents in the township of Abomosu, where there is an Agenda 111 hospital and is 93 per cent or more completed. They are anxiously waiting to use it. The Government, instead of completing the 10 Agenda 111 hospitals, are rather prioritising the purchase of two jets, four helicopters with landing pads, plus two ships which are no ordinary vessels. I ask, is that the priority of the country? Traders, farmers, nurses and teachers are suffering.

Mr Speaker, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy also lacks a dedicated programme to support Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises to overcome the current high interest rate and the cautious nature of banks at this time. This leaves businesses, Mr Speaker, who are the main drivers of job creation without the quick funding they need to invest and grow, which slows down job creation.

Mr Speaker, the Women's Development Bank, which was not established in spite of it being in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, has found its way again in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy; thank you, Jesus. But while the GH¢401 million allocation meets the Bank of Ghana's capital requirement for a commercial bank threshold, it is not sufficient to really boost the capital base, even though it is GH¢401 million now, it is not sufficient for the overall operational and capital expenditure.

Mr Speaker, the question for the Women's Development Bank is how much of the allocation will go into the real delivery of the micro enterprises. Women entrepreneurs do not need another public relations gimmick. They need access to credit. As it stands now, the Women's Development Bank is merely a promise without delivery.

As we saw earlier in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, Mr Speaker, traders are suffering. The 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, instead of consolidating and strengthening existing structures, simply repackages old promises to score political points. Women deserve better. They deserve practical economic empowerment, backed by realistic financing.

Mr Speaker, the much-touted 24-Hour Economy was announced by the Government as one of their flagship initiatives, intended to boost productivity and job creation. But the Budget lacked clear details with regards to how the

government's allocation of the GH¢110 million will be spent, the exact incentives offered, and a definite timeline.

While the plan is to involve the Development Bank Ghana (DBG) and the Ghana Infrastructure Investment Fund, the programme's ultimate success hinges on private investment, which requires the Government to quickly provide a clear and detailed blueprint that the stakeholders are still requesting. The funding is also inadequate. I would not even get into the jobs—the 133 or the—*[Expunged by the orders of the Speaker]*, I do not want to get into that.

The 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy undoubtedly shows no clear road arrears clearance. There is no schedule and no transparency on how accumulated arrears will be cleared. Mr Speaker, contractors are still in financial distress. Many of them cannot pay workers—

4:53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Korkor Asante, hold it. Hon Richard Acheampong, you have the floor.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

I think we have a time allotment for every Member speaking. Leaders are supposed to speak for one hour; other Leaders are given 35 minutes, Chairpersons, Ranking, Vice Chairpersons are given 15 minutes, and other Members are given 5 minutes. I do not know if—she has done more than 11

minutes. Ranking Member for which Committee? Mr Speaker, she has exceeded her time allotment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Richard Acheampong, I believe before submitting the list to me, you have to cross-check all these. What I have before me, Hon Laurette Korkor Asante is supposed to speak for 15 minutes, so if the case is that she is not supposed to speak for 15 minutes, before Conclave, all these should be have been ironed out.

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the information, but I remember that the Majority Leader used certain words; you called upon him to retract those words. How can a Member of Parliament describe something as—

Mr Speaker, this is unparliamentary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Korkor Asante, the record will show that at the point, for instance, when I described an event with—I was asked to withdraw and apologise. So, kindly withdraw the word—and apologise. It is something that is associated with criminality. Please withdraw.

Mrs Asante: Mr Speaker, if I recall correctly, I said I do not know if it is 133; I do not want to get into that. That is what I said.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I direct that the use of—which is associated with criminality, should be expunged from our record as if it does not exist.

Mrs Asante: Mr Speaker, I am guided, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You may continue.

Mrs Asante: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Many of the contractors, as I was saying, are under distress. They cannot pay their loans, cannot pay workers, have had their equipment repossessed, and yet the Government wants to buy two jets, four helicopters, and two ships, when contractors are suffering; teachers are suffering; nurses are suffering; traders and farmers are suffering.

Mr Speaker, switching to education, which is critical for our national development. The education sector received a large nominal sum totalling GHC43.2 billion; GHC33.3 billion for the Ministry of Education, and GHC9.9 billion for GETFund, which constitutes about 14.3 per cent of the 2026 total Government expenditure. However, this is still inadequate because it falls below the 15 to 20 per cent international benchmark recommended by organisations like the UNESCO. It is barely enough to solve the longstanding massive problems, such as the need to improve teacher quality, teacher vacancies, and the acquisition of necessary resources to meet global standards.

Mr Speaker, in underserved and rural communities like my constituency at Atiwa West, the teacher shortage has reached real alarming levels. Schools in these areas operate with one or two

teachers handling multiple classes, leading to chronic loss of instruction and deteriorating performance. There is a widening learning inequality between rural and urban areas, poor performance in core subjects, and rising dropout rates.

Mr Speaker, the problem of teacher shortage must be fully addressed. It has not. Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) funding has also not received any major funding push for the long-term job skills mismatch. The youth need this, Mr Speaker. The youth are suffering, and they need skills training.

In conclusion, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is heavy on rhetoric and light on substance. The Government came to power with loud promises. However, all we have now is spin. Ghanaians deserve better. They deserve a government that feels their pain and responds to their struggles. It is about time the Government stopped playing *chaskale* with the Ghanaians. This 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy is *medofa adaadaa me's* budget.

[Hon Members from the Minority Side sang medofa adaadaa me]

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Mr Kofi Benteh Afful.

You have the floor. You are speaking for ten minutes.

Mr Kofi Benteh Afful (NDC — Sefwi Wiawso): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the President as presented by the Minister for Finance to this House.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, Ghanaians all over the country were in despair as to what was happening to the extent that some have even lost confidence in the nation of not wanting to go to the polls to vote. Then came a saviour, in the person of President John Dramani Mahama. In his first budget, which was presented to us this year, we saw that most of the things he did to reset the economy. However, our Friends from the other Side have tried to argue that before the President took power, they had grown the economy by 5.7 per cent.

Mr Speaker, if the growth of an economy, and for that matter its development, is only to be realised in the GDP growth rate, then what will it profit an economy if it grew by 5.7 per cent and had to borrow so much to the extent that it became bankrupt and had to go begging for its creditors to forgive of its debts to the extent of even creating different shades of haircuts, including *sakora*?

Mr Speaker, if this is what we do to grow an economy, then I beg to differ because, what will it profit an economy if it touts itself to have grown by 5.7 per cent and yet unemployment rates was 14.7 per cent, a remnant of which we saw at El-Wak recently which a responsible

President in the person of John Dramani Mahama has taken responsibility to take care of all the injured and even the deceased?

Mr Speaker, what will it profit an economy if it says it had grown by 5.7 per cent and yet the inflation rate was hovering around 50 per cent at a point in time to an end of year rate of 23 per cent, making the cost of living so high for each citizen?

Mr Speaker, what will it profit a country if it says it has grown by 5.7 per cent, and yet exchanges were hovering around 28 and 30 per cent? If this is how a political party, for that matter, will manage an economy, then I have no doubt to believe that the result of what we saw in the 2024 election has come to this far.

Mr Speaker, before I became a Member of Parliament, I heard that this House has two Sides, your left-hand side and your right-hand side. But ever since I came here, I have seen a median. However, what I have seen are corners, four of them, one of which is occupied by the NPP, who were in the previous government. So today, our Friends in one corner are trying to tell us that they have forgotten the basic economics of the distinction between economic growth and economic development.

Today, we are presenting a Budget which does not only seek to grow the economy but to develop it. Even though we have started to grow the economy by 4.8 per cent, Mr Speaker, in this 4.8 per cent, 800,000 jobs are going to be created

to solve some of the problems they left behind. In this 4.8 per cent growth rate we are estimating, exchange rates are currently hovering around 10.9 per cent. Inflation is below 8 per cent and we are targeting 5 per cent by the end of the year.

5:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if this is how they want us to grow the economy like they did, then let them know that we are not going to manage the economy the way they did. I am not surprised that they went into the examination in December 2024 and their best score was 87 out of 276. They have been reduced to one corner. In this one corner, as Minority, they are enjoying. We do not want to be like them, and so we are treading cautiously. The Minister for Finance is not only a finance expert; he is also an accountant and has taught us how to prudently manage an economy. That is why he is “not running his mouth”. He does not want to run away. He does not want to be a fugitive of justice. He wants to be able to come back home and attend funerals of relatives and that is why he has given us this Budget.

Mr Speaker, their only fear is that by the time the programmes in this Budget have been executed, they would have become extinct and that is why they are doing everything they can to say this Budget cannot transform us. However, the matter speaks for itself.

All that the Minister has done can clearly tell us that not only is he looking at raking in more revenue; he has also put in measures to stop the leakages, most of

which he inherited from the previous Administration. They know, to the extent that he is deploying an Artificial Intelligence (AI) mechanism to make sure all the loopholes occurring at our ports are plugged so that we can rake in more revenue.

In fact, if you want to do well in economic management, it is not only the case that you focus on raking revenue. If you are also able to plug the leakages, make spendings optimum and try to be disciplined in spending, obviously if you cannot even rake in more, you will plug the leakages and still be better off as an economic manager.

This is what we want them to learn. This is what we are doing and by the time we are done, Mr Speaker, I know these Egyptians we are seeing today, we will not see them anymore. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is now the turn of Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah. You have 15 minutes.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to take part in this debate. Mr Speaker, I pray your indulgence to join my Brother, Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh, to pay tribute to the six young gallant women, the young patriotic women who sought to serve their nation but unfortunately met their untimely death. At this point, I wish to mention their names for people to know that we acknowledge what they have gone through.

Mr Speaker, my condolences go to the families of Prudence Ayisi, Alice Owusu, Abigail Boateng, Sarah Mensah, Esther Appiah and Mercy Owusu. These women were not seeking to only serve their country, but to also join the many Ghanaian women who have succeeded in breaking traditional boundaries and stereotypes. Unfortunately, they met their untimely death.

It was unfortunate. To the many that sustained different forms and degrees of injuries across the country, consistent with Exodus 15:26, I assure them that the Lord is their healer. These young ladies unfortunately met their untimely death just so they could get meaningful, well-paying jobs. It is unfortunate and that as a House, we need to commit to ensure that there would be abundant jobs for the Ghanaian, particularly our teaming youth who are graduating from our various institutions of learning. This is why we are concerned about the 2026 Budget.

Mr Speaker, unfortunately for us as a nation, yes, we do concede that there are some good macroeconomic indicators. No matter the disconnect between the indicators and the reality, there is that concession. That said, there is one thing that has eluded us as a country and that thing is the sustainability of the indicators. We cannot say that the indicators we are seeing today is unique. There may be some improvements. That said, it has become cyclical that once we subscribe to an IMF programme, we begin to experience good indicators. The question we have failed to ask ourselves, indeed, even if we have asked ourselves,

the question we have failed to answer is why has the sustainability of the indicators eluded us?

Mr Speaker, the answer is not far-fetched. It is in our expenditure choices. When you are running a revenue shortfall, definitely you need to be careful with your expenditure. But when you choose to spend GHC13 billion in the procurement of aircraft, that certainly is not a prudent expenditure choice. When you choose to spend GHC3 billion over a period of four years to procure aircraft, that is not a prudent expenditure. You know why it is not? I will tell you why.

Mr Speaker, firstly, we need to convert the GHC13 billion into dollars. The US\$1 billion that they have been pumping into the economy, they pump it with their left hand and take it with their right hand and export it to a foreign country just to procure jets. While they make that choice, what they forget is that they are not just giving the foreign country revenue, they are also giving them jobs while the people in our country are not getting jobs. The taxpayers, the people from whom they obtained the GHC13 billion, are struggling to get jobs. And this is the decision they chose to make. At this point of austerity, Mr Speaker, it is certainly not a prudent choice.

Mr Speaker, I am not a prophet but there is one thing I can prophesy on the floor of Parliament today, that in no time, the NDC Government led by H. E. John Dramani Mahama will be running back to the IMF because of the choices it is

making. **[An Hon Member: Woboa]** It is a very imprudent economic choice.

Mr Speaker, why would they spend GH¢13 billion to procure aircraft when they have 78,000 unemployed nurses in the country? Why would they spend GH¢13 billion to procure aircraft when more than 6,000 teachers are struggling to get employment? Why would they spend GH¢13 billion to procure aircraft when about 60 per cent of the 300,000 Ghanaian graduates on a yearly basis do not get employment? Unfortunately, we have learnt our lessons and we are advising them. When they are struggling to get the people employment, these are the choices they have made.

Mr Speaker, when we say they are not creating employment, their reaction is that they are creating 800,000 jobs. We have reminded them that the 800,000 jobs are mainly fleeting by-day jobs, *w'ala tu w'ala sa*. That is all they are. Which of these jobs will the 60 per cent of the 300,000 graduates do? None.

5:13 p.m.

Which of these jobs will the 78,000 nurses do? None. Which of these jobs will the over 6,000 teachers, who are struggling to be recruited, do? None.

Mr Speaker, little wonder that the World Bank, in its annual update in June 2025, stated as follows, “a state where economic growth has critically failed to translate into meaningful job creation.”

Mr Speaker, our economic growth continues to fail to translate into

meaningful job creation because of such choices, the choice to spend GH¢13 billion to procure aircraft. I have heard some of our Colleagues say that it does not include presidential jets. The record of this House will bear us out that any time presidential jets have been procured in this country, they come in the form of military retooling. Therefore, we know that what is being procured is a presidential jet.

Mr Speaker, our President prefers comfort over the employment of the Ghanaian youth. That is what is happening. The many youth who had hoped that the NDC, through its reset agenda, was going to create meaningful jobs for them; some of whom had stayed home for 10 years.

Some of whom had remained unemployed for 5 years—they have disappointed them, and it does not look like the two years ahead of the year 2026 are going to create the needed jobs. They have been disappointed, and it is unfortunate that this is happening.

Mr Speaker, Malaysia did not develop by making such expenditure choices. It did not become an Asian tiger by procuring aircraft when its teeming youth did not have a job. Singapore did not develop when its teeming youth were struggling to procure aircraft. When the NDC said it was going to reset, the expectation was that they were going to do something different. However, what they pursue is the status quo; Creating unemployment. They have no interest in creating jobs for our people. And it is unfortunate.

Mr Speaker, at this point, in our quest to assist the Government to consolidate its finances to create jobs, having advised them on the need to abandon the procurement of the jets, I would draw their attention to the need to consolidate the institutions of state in the fight against corruption.

Mr Speaker, I take you to the Budget of the Office of the Special Prosecutor. We are told that this year, we are giving the Office of the Special Prosecutor a budget of GH¢158 million. It is about time we take a critical look at our expenditure. We have too many institutions fighting corruption. The question we have to ask ourselves is whether the Office of the Special Prosecutor remains a necessity. The question we need to ask ourselves is whether what the Office of the Special Prosecutor is doing, the Financial and Intelligence Centre and the Economic and Organised Crime Office cannot do.

In this light, we are told that the Office of the Special Prosecutor, as part of its achievements this year, helped the Controller and Accountant General to recover some money through a corruption risk assessment. Mr Speaker, the Controller and Accountant General already has an integrated solution for fighting fraud. It is either that we are not being told the truth, or the integrated solution for fighting fraud at the Office of the Controller and Accountant General is not working. It is obvious that corruption risk assessment in and of itself can never help in uncovering fraud when there is computer software for doing so.

We need to consolidate the institutions that fight corruption in this country by making sure that we avoid duplicity and enhance investment in those institutions to ensure that corruption is fought well without losing good money, as we have seen over the period.

Mr Speaker, as I conclude, I would like to invite the Attorney-General to review the Office of the Special Prosecutor. We have tried it for more than seven years. The results are there for us to see. It is good money chasing bad money.

Very respectfully, Mr Speaker, these are my submissions. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I give the floor to Dr Jasaw.

Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw (NDC — Wa East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my comments to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the financial year 2026.

Mr Speaker, please allow me to make some preliminary observations from some of the submissions that some of my Colleagues have made.

Mr Speaker, I see that there appears to be a fetish for referring to the retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces as buying a presidential jet. Assuming that were even the case, I submit that buying a jet, therefore, is better than hiring a jet that you need to bathe in the sky. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, if they have the courtesy to complain about maternal mortality, they will also have to explain to us why you sank US\$400 million in a hole that they described as a capital—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are speaking for 15 minutes.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, at the same time, I have heard complaints that there was no compensation to the Akosombo Dam spillage victims. Mr Speaker, the NDC, even in opposition, led initiatives that resettled these victims. Led initiatives that built clinics, schools, and fed the victims. When His Excellency, the former President Akufo-Addo, got there, he said they did not vote for him, and therefore, he had no way to care for them. This is the record of this country.

That said, let me commend the Minister for Finance for coming to this House in fulfilment of his constitutional obligation under Article 179 and also the Public Financial Management Act, 2016, Act 921, Section 21. He came and delivered a budget on the theme, “Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation”. Mr Speaker, having read through the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I am convinced that a lot of deliberate thinking was put into place to be able to come up with this economic policy.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the sections that relate to agriculture in our country, we would realise that there is a deliberate agenda to see how we can improve what we have observed in our Budget Statements in the last few years.

5:23 p.m.

One of them is that we always talk yet the programmes and projects that we create are not anything that contributes to economic growth. But, on this particular Budget, there has been a deliberate effort to speak to the productive capacity building of our economy. Why do I say so? If we take the cocoa subsector, we would observe that a lot of arrangements have been put in place that is contributing to growth of the subsector. Growth of that subsector would translate into value-added jobs that many Ghanaians will benefit from.

Mr Speaker would recall that in the last Budget debate, we complained about cocoa sector debt of GHC32.5 billion. I am happy to report that the debt has reduced drastically. At the same time, the cocoa sector roads alone has a debt of GHC21 billion. One would recall that we complained that we owed the International Financial Institution's cocoa of 333,000 metric tonnes that we could not pay for. They had to be rolled over. Now production has increased from the under 500,000 metric tonnes that we witnessed last year to at least 603,000 metric tonnes.

This is so significant because it has been able to allow us to pay that debt by contributing 243,000 metric tonnes of cocoa. We just have about 90,000 metric tonnes to go. With the current projection and production levels that are ongoing, I am convinced that we will be able to make up the production quantities, be able to pay our debts and raise some more additional income.

Mr Speaker, some of the programmes that have been budgeted for in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy that is so important, and we must encourage as part of the reasons we should support the passage of this Budget, is that we have free cocoa spraying that is coming up and will cost us about GH¢2.4 billion. At the same time, free fertiliser is back for the cocoa subsector. Mr Speaker, this means that the cost of production of the cocoa per unit area for the farmer is going to be less. Once it is less, more growth will come into the economy and the farmer is likely to reap more gains. So, this is something we must support.

Mr Speaker, paragraph 296 of the Budget tells us that we are going to have an additional 200,000 hectares of cocoa under cultivation. This is a highly decisive step, and a highly decisive strategic policy. I think that we must support this and make sure—this gives us security because now we are not going to depend on only individual farmers with their 3 acres, 10 acres, but we have a 200,000 hectares security of cocoa farms that we can project in real time how much cocoa beans we will be able to harvest and sell to the international markets.

Mr Speaker, complementing this is oil palm that is referred to as the red gold. The oil palm sector is also another productive sector that is complementing the cocoa. If we can have this growing in the ways that we envisage, where we are going to have—in paragraph 933, it refers that we are going to have about

100,000 additional hectares of new oil palm plantations.

This is clearly investing in productive sectors whose value chains is going to translate into a number of jobs for our people. Government is deliberate about this. There is a budget of US\$500 million that is going to be rolled over four years to be able to handle the production of this sector in a way that we can eventually be competitive with other countries such as Malaysia. Complementing this is also rubber. Ghana, at the moment, has about 178,000 metric tonnes capacity, but the only raw rubber that we get in the country is just about 100,000 metric tonnes. Government have again been decisive in projecting a policy of restricting the exploitation of raw rubber. If we restrict the exploitation of raw rubber, complemented with additional production capacity of the rubber subsector, it means that we will be able to process this rubber in the country. If we can achieve processing rubber in-country, in fact, that would definitely throw a lot of jobs along the value chain. I see these three crops, cocoa, the oil palm, and also rubber, as strategic. I am very excited that this Budget has deliberately handled these and then allocated a lot of financing budgets to it. I call on all of us to even consider taking some plantations in these oil palm fields.

The other complementing one is the Feed Ghana Programme. We realise that the food price inflation has come down. This year, we are recording 8 per cent food price inflation. That tells us that the rate at which food prices had increased in the past, has actually slowed down. It

means that many more families are able to afford food. One cannot underrate this. At the same time, the 2026 Budget is adding additional measures that will encourage and consolidate this. One of them is that all institutions that are going to be government-subsidised will need to buy food that are made in Ghana. It means that all these production levels are going to find markets in these institutions that we are talking about. For the first time, the National Food Buffer Stock Company has found expression in our Budget. Actually, the money allocated to National Buffer Stock Company to be able to execute their mandate, which is to mop up excess food that is produced at the farm gate, store it, and bring it back to the market in a logistical arrangement that will make sure food prices do not exceed a certain limit.

Mr Speaker, if we can do this, again complemented by the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* programme, where we are going to have poultry for every district, up to 10,000 birds and more in coming years, meaning that these *nkokɔ nketenkete* will need to feed from the maize and soya that farmers produce. Very soon, that issue of glut in the market will be a thing of the past.

An additional aspect that we need to talk about is irrigation for wealth. One would realise that all of us are experiencing the vagaries of climate change. We do not know when the next rain is coming, and so farmers are really unable to predict how their production cycles are going to run. The irrigation for wealth creation is a well-thought-out programme, which is a very direct

intervention that will help our farmers maintain take care of the risks of the rainfall patterns that they cannot predict.

Mr Speaker, there is a huge budget for solar boreholes that are going to be sunk as part of the irrigation for wealth creation. I see this as a deliberate response to some of the challenges we are facing in the agricultural subsector. Complementing all these is the Big Push road projects that are ongoing. This is going to support drastically the logistics of carting food from production centres to market centres or consumption centres. At the same time, the Government is complementing this with an additional 1,000 kilometre road that will be directed at farm producing areas and farming areas. These roads will do a lot in reducing costs of food production, selling food and sending these foods to areas that they are needed for consumption.

If we look at this gamut of projects, amongst others, we will be convinced that Government has thought through these projects very carefully and strategically, and invested the needed resources that will help us grow the sector in the ways that we want.

5:33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, allow me to make a further comment on the fisheries subsector. We remember, that recently we just passed the new Fisheries Act, 2025 (Act 1146). This law is being given expression to in the new Budget and Economic policy. Mr Speaker, Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated fishing

(IUU) is something that will be a thing of the past because there is adequate provision for us to fight IUU, and the law buttresses and backs that as well.

At the same time, there is a huge conversation around aquaculture in the law and also in the Budget. This sector is linked very conveniently with the 24-Hour Economy policy of Government, where women and youth employment are emphasised. So, there will be aquaculture for women and youth, and there is a huge budget outlay for that. That means that a lot of our youth in the coastal bed and fishing communities will be taken care of adequately under this project.

Mr Speaker, we should support this. Fishing inputs and fishing market constructions, have also been budgeted for.

Mr Speaker, even with these three interventions, we can they see that they have been deliberately thought through, consciously provided for and are things that will help the growth of the economies of those local areas, and at the same time, create the jobs that we need for these local areas.

Mr Speaker, allow me to conclude by submitting to you one significant thing that is happening which is that the production levels that we have found increased in this country are not out of an accident. It is something that has been deliberate. So, what we are going to do, and that is what the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy comes to solve, is that we are going to make sure that we pay attention to value

addition of the produce that we generate in the country.

Mr Speaker, I am very confident that by close of year 2026, every one of us would have been satisfied that we do not have food security challenges anymore and that we are on the path of growth and that agriculture would be truly contributing to the growth of the economy. I thank you for the opportunity and I call on this house to endorse the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we now proceed to give the floor to Hon Kennedy Nyarko Osei. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei (NPP — Akim Swedru): Mr Speaker, we are already tired so I do not intend to keep Members sitting for long even though you have given me 15 minutes. I have been sitting here. Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to make a few comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was presented to this House on behalf of the President by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, I have gone through the Budget trying to find out what exactly Government's policies are when it comes to the road and transport sector. It will surprise the House that I could not find any; there is none. All that we see in the Budget Statement is the Big Push, and the rehash of their own manifesto promises. Mr Speaker, the occasion of presenting a Budget Statement and Economic Policy in this House is a critical moment for Members of

Parliament because this exercise gives us the opportunity to critique and scrutinise the various documents or allocations that have been brought to this House.

Mr Speaker, no wonder that if we look at the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and go through Government's performance when it comes to infrastructure, it is nothing to write home about. This is as compared to even 2024 when the previous administration was described as a government that has criminally managed the economy.

I hold in my hands, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was presented to this House. On Appendix 1C which we can find on page 151, if we read section 2.05, which is under industry—If we want to know how the economy has performed, we talk about the industry which includes manufacturing and construction, which normally talks about the infrastructure development of this country.

If we read, we will see that under 2024, in terms of contributions of infrastructure development to our GDP growth, it was 9.6 per cent. Sadly, in 2025, it declined to 2.9 per cent. I was expecting that now that Government says that under the Big Push, it is going to spend over GH¢51 billion in the next three to four years, we would see some kind of improvement or growth in this sector. But, Mr Speaker, even when we go to 2027, they are doing 5.2 per cent. So, if we are to juxtapose it with the performance in 2024, where they said that the Akufo-Addo government was

not doing much, we did 9.6 per cent growth. It tells us how committed the government was, and invested into the infrastructure of this country.

Mr Speaker, today they said they are going to inject GH¢30 billion into the Big Push. Out of this GH¢30 billion, 70 per cent will go into road construction, which is about Gh¢21 billion. Mr Speaker, even in 2025 they promised that out of the GH¢13.8 billion, they were going to invest 70 per cent of it, which is about GH¢9.6 billion. I have in my hands here a document signed by the Minister for Finance. This is the commencement authorisation that has given a total of how much they are going to spend under the Big Push for the next four years. There are about 32 projects that the Government wants to invest in this year and it is about GH¢51 billion. They have given a breakdown – they said in the first year, which is 2025, they are giving a commencement certificate of GH¢7.6 billion. Meanwhile, in the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Government told us that it is going to spend 70 per cent of the GH¢13.8 billion, which is GH¢9.6 billion. The question is, why is there GH¢2 billion extra? They promised the people that they want to invest this much, and now they are telling us that they can only invest GH¢7.6 billion. So, does it mean they lied to the Ghanaian people? They deceived them?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, withdraw the word “lie”.

Mr K. N. Osei: I am guided, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am asking you to withdraw.

Mr K. N. Osei: I have withdrawn. So, they cannot deceive the people. They cannot say one thing and deliver the other.

Mr Speaker, the next thing that I want to talk about is the Government decision to construct an expressway of 198.7 km from Accra to Kumasi. I have no problem with it, but the question is, how is the Government going to fund it? In the Budget, there is no allocation for the Government to fund this project. The Big Push – that is why I am saying I have it here. All the project they want to do within the next four years is captured here. An authorisation certificate has been given that they cannot go outside this limit. I cannot find the new expressway in it.

Mr Speaker, it is good if Government is looking for any other alternative to construct the expressway, but we must give priority to it. Mr Speaker, already we hear stories about the Accra to Kumasi Road. It has become dangerous.

The previous government has invested so much in constructing the eight bypasses. Yes. The entire stretch from Accra to Kumasi is about 249.1 km. Out of this stretch, Mr Speaker, if we put the bypasses that the previous government did, and the one that they have already done, the dual carriage from Nsawam to Apedwa Junction, and currently, the one they are doing from Ofankor to Nsawam, if we put them together, the previous government has already done about 155

km of this road. What is remaining is just about 94 km. So as a prudent Government, if they want to invest, will they go and look for a new funding to start a new project, or they will just look for money to complete the 94 km which is left to dualise to make the road motorable and safe for people who are driving on it?

5:43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this will cost the Government less than even going to invest over a billion dollars in constructing the expressway. It is good if the Government want to look for a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) to develop it. But the Government should look for money to complete an investment. This is a huge investment that the previous government has sunk into. It is the Ghanaian taxpayers' money. So, why are we leaving that project or just delaying the project when we could have invested half of the money that we want to use to start a new project? We could have invested in it to complete this project.

Mr Speaker, it is not going to cost us more than US\$500 million to complete this project, but it is going to cost us, in essence, a billion dollars if we want to do the 198.7 km expressway. Maybe in the future, when we are able to solve this problem, and we have completed the bypasses, we would look for funds and do it. I would be happy because at least when the expressway project is done, it will go through Akim Oda, and I will drive on it.

But now, the most economic route in this country is the Accra-Kumasi Road. It connects almost about 11 regions. So, if the previous administration has taken a bold step—yes, it is true that there have been some variations to the contract because the scope of work has increased. It is far better to look for funds to complete that project than to start a new one.

In the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Government says that it is going to take almost four years before the completion of the project, whereas the bypasses will not take more than nine months to complete. Why are we doing this to ourselves as a country?

So, Mr Speaker, the Government may have nice policies, they want to do it, but they should not reduce these policies to just a mere rehash of manifesto promises. There should be a commitment.

Mr Speaker, let me move to the railway sector. In 2025, a zero allocation was made to the railway sector. A sector that the previous government invested hugely, not less than US\$1.2 billion, in various ongoing projects, and zero allocation was made in 2025. The sad part is that in 2026, the Government says it is committed to invest in the railway sector, but it has just budgeted just GH¢73 million. Do you know the cost of a kilometre of a railway line?

Mr Speaker, we are talking about US\$5.5 million. So, the GH¢73 million that is allocated, what is it going to do? It means the Government is not committed to developing the railway sector. But in

the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they said they want to develop the railway sector. They cannot develop the railway sector by just rehashing their manifesto promises in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. The real commitment will show in the various allocations that is given.

Mr Speaker, as I stated early on, I do not want to bother Members with my comments. Before I conclude, Members from the Minority have mentioned the Government's decision to procure four jets, two aircraft, and one ship. The ship is a warship—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I thought you said you would speak for five minutes.

Mr K. N. Osei: Yes, I am within the five minutes. I would end very soon.

Mr Speaker, I do not have any problem if the Government wants to retool our security agencies. I have no problem with it. But there is a way that we can prioritise and do it. The Government can buy one or two jets instead of four, and use the remaining money for urgent programmes.

Mr Speaker, look at the nurses and the teacher trainees who are home. This year's allocation in the Budget, the GH¢2.6 billion, if the Government decides to acquire only two of the jets and use the remaining money, they can employ about 60,000 trained teachers and nurses to work and pay them fully. This is just a misplaced priority by the

Government. They are just interested in acquiring those aircraft and planes for their own comfort.

Mr Speaker, I want to end, but before that, I want to send a word of caution to them. We have been in government before, and we know how things became at a point in time. They should not be comfortable with where they are now. They have to be very careful. They will think that they have the goodwill of the Ghanaian people, but the real test of this Government will start showing in 2026. That time, they will say that we did not tell them—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude. In less than one minute your 15 minutes would be over.

Mr K. N. Osei: Mr Speaker, I want to end here. I do not want to add more.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, due to a technical challenge, we may have to take a ten-minute break. It is not my fault; it is a technical challenge. So, we would come back after ten minutes for that technical issue to be resolved. The House is temporarily suspended for ten minutes.

5:58 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

6:23 p.m. — *Sitting resumed*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly get seated.

Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader, any indications?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we want to revert to the item numbered 6 on the *Order Paper*, and take the Urgent Questions 6(a) and (b)

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, Leadership engaged and agreed that we should take the Questions for the Ministry of the Interior. Let me also put on record that there were other considerations that both Sides were supposed to engage on. That we were not able to do because of the extended Sitting.

So, on our Side, when we are done with the Minister for the Interior, we cannot do any other Business. We have made our suggestion strongly to the Leadership because there was an earlier directive in respect of—Well, if they want to do it, I am stating my side of the case. If they still want to insist, that is alright.

Mr Speaker, you gave an earlier directive in respect of the Questions for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and I had engaged the Majority Chief Whip and told him we do not have any problem. We can take it as first Business tomorrow morning. So, we can take the Questions for the Ministry of the Interior, and then we draw the curtains for the day. That is it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: I can understand that we have had a long day, but the Minister for Foreign Affairs is here. He came in the morning with a whole retinue of staff to support him answer the Questions, and I pleaded with him to allow us to have the debate, and after the debate, he will come back and answer the Questions. If Hon Members noticed, yesterday, we arranged things in such a way that we had the debates and reverted to Government Business and then we went back to the debates. So, I told him we could do the same thing today. My plea is that he is here. I actually asked him to come back. I called and pleaded with him to come back. I also called Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, who had left, and pleaded with him to come back to which he agreed that I should give him 15 minute and that he will be back here to ask the Minister the Questions. I have already informed the Minister that I have called Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor. So, I am pleading for us have the Minister.

Once the Deputy Minister for the Interior is answering his Questions, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor has time to get here to ask his Questions. So, it is a plea. The truth of the matter is that, whether we like it or not, he is the Minister for Foreign Affairs, and he has obligations to travel abroad to execute business on our behalf as a country. He is leaving town tomorrow morning, and that is why I pleaded with him to come back, no matter how late, to have his Questions asked, so that he can—*[Interruption]*—How many Questions? He asked eight

Questions. Who asked the eight Questions? Can we go through the eight Questions to see who have asked them? Seven of the eight Questions have been asked by NPP Members of this House. The NDC Member asked only one, making a total of eight Questions.

If he leaves tomorrow, I know, the Hon Minority Chief Whip will say that Ministers do not come to answer Questions. And the Minister for Foreign Affairs is pointed at mostly, even though he knows that his job means that he should be outside the country most of the time, executing our business. Today he is here, and I am insisting that they ask all their Questions so that the Minister can answer them. The records will capture it, and then your constituents would see that they have asked the Questions, and that the Minister has provided the Answers. Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor is here. He gave me his word that he will come and ask the Questions. I am pleading with him to let us have the Minister answer the Questions.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you earlier gave a directive that because of the volume of Business we have for the day, especially in respect of Questions, we will have to go by the one follow-up question rule. Mr Speaker, we intend to respect your directive, and that itself puts a certain limitation on us. However, because of the consideration and the exigencies of Business, we have to endure. But I do not agree with the Hon Majority Leader when he used the language, “he is the Minister for Foreign Affairs whether we like it or not”. That is not a good language to use.

Let me say it *ab initio*, nobody has any issue—I find it very difficult that when it gets to the Minister for Foreign Affairs, it becomes a banter on what we are to do. Nobody has issues with Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa—[*Interruption*]—Would they listen to me. They sit at the back and—Catch the eye of Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader should hasten with caution when he says, “whether we like it or not, he is the Minister for Foreign Affairs”. What kind of language is that?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: People are saying, Chairman and Ranking. [*Laughter*]

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, the respected Minister for Foreign Affairs—He is the Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic. We will not take that away from him. We respect him. He knows I respect him. But I am speaking on principle.

I have a problem when the Hon Majority Leader goes behind me. He has been foraying into my backyard. He goes talking to my Members without routing it through me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, it is not everything that is for our record. You know, my practice is for you to continue to engage.

We will take the Question for the Minister for the Interior, the item numbered 6(a).

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you are my best Friend.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, and that is why I am asking that you to engage.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, treat me with some kid gloves.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, there is no issue that I know, with Hon Annoh-Dompreh involved, that cannot be resolved.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we will resolve it, but I was just about concluding.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that one I know.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: But the point has to be made that my backyard is for me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. That is what I am telling you that it is not everything that you place on record

6:33 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I cannot go to his backyard without routing it through him. For all you know, he may try to take my seat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But I know you have been penetrating very deep into his backyard.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: And now when he says that Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor is here, there are eight Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am saying that I know you have also been penetrating deep into his backyard.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: When the Minister for Foreign Affairs comes to this House, he comes with detailed response, and that is characteristic of him. But the Chamber is almost empty, and we are to hurriedly rush it through?

This is our Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Ghana, Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa. He is capable of handling it. Mr Speaker, for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, all the questions are important. If we scan through the Questions related to our Friends, they are very important Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, a humble directive, engage, as we take the Question for the Minister for the Interior.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do not go behind you with ill motives. I was in the Clerk to Parliament's office when the Whip came to me and said there is a decision to not take the Minister for Foreign Affairs because Hon Jinapor, who asked the Question, had left, I indicated that I could call him. So, I did and pleaded with him to come back. And he said he would be back in 15 minutes. It was not with any ill motive.

Indeed, it is pursuant to our effort to listen to the Minority Chief Whip in particular because every Friday, he reminds us of the backlog of Questions. He has repeatedly mentioned that there are over 300 Questions outstanding, and insisted that I produce every Minister to answer Questions. He has accused me in this House of being in the habit of shielding Ministers and not allowing them to come and answer Questions and that their Questions are so important.

I am surprised that today they are running away from their Questions. I am surprised that I have managed to drag the Minister for Foreign Affairs here, and the Minority Whip of all people — the *Hansard* will bear me out of how many times he, singularly, has complained bitterly about the non-availability of Ministers in this Chamber to answer Questions.

Now, the Ministers are available, then he says, no, that the Chamber is empty. Why? The person who is asking the Question is sitting here. The Clerks-at-the-Table are here. The media is here to convey it. The records will capture it. So, please, I beg.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: On what I said earlier, that he forayed into my backyard to do his own thing, clearly portends some sort of ill motive. So, unreservedly, I retract that, and we can make progress.

Mr Speaker, you had cautioned that leadership should engage. There are fundamental things that the Majority Chief Whip must do. He knows. So, he

should engage appropriately. In the meantime, we can start with the Minister for the Interior.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chief Whips, engage. It is a directive from the Speaker. We would take the item numbered 6A.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: We will take the Minister for the Interior, who was here earlier. He was scheduled to travel. He called me this morning, pleaded that we should take him first. But due to some other assignments, he got in late after we had started with the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. And then, after that, the Minister for Roads and Highways. So, when it was time for him to catch his flight, he pleaded that I ask you to indulge him and allow his Deputy to answer the Questions on his behalf.

Again, Mr Speaker, I want to put on record that my very good Friend, Hon Annoh-Dompreh, has insisted that wherever a Question is asked of a Minister and the Minister is not available, the Minister must ensure that his Deputy is here in this House to answer the Question.

And given that the Minister for the Interior is not available and his Deputy is here, I am not sure he is opposed. We can go ahead and have the Deputy answer the Questions.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We are not opposed. We have always taken a principled position. And besides, the

Deputy is very friendly, not like others—*[Laughter]*—So, we will agree for him to answer the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 6A—Urgent Questions, which stands in the name of Mr Frederick Yaw Ahenkwah, Hon Member for Jaman North. You have the floor.

Mr Adama Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I have the authority of Hon Ahenkwah to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF THE INTERIOR

Curfew imposed on Sampa Township

Mr Adama Sulemana on behalf of Mr Frederick Yaw Ahenkwah (NDC — Jaman North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for the Interior when the curfew imposed on Sampa Township on 18th April 2024, as a result of some Chieftaincy disputes, will be lifted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Deputy Minister for the Interior (Mr Ebenezer Oklety Terlabi): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Ministry of the Interior on the 18th April 2024 imposed a curfew on Sampa in the Jaman District of the Bono Region.

The curfew imposition was based on the advice of the Bono Regional Security Council and in accordance with the appropriate Legislative Instruments following the chieftaincy dispute. The curfew was to run from 4:00 p.m. to 7:00 a.m. each day, but has undergone a number of reviews, with current hours running from 10 p.m. to 4 a.m. each day.

Mr Speaker, just as the curfew was imposed on the advice of the Bono Regional Security Council, the Ministry of the Interior will rely on the return of peace in the area and the advice of the National Security Council to lift the curfew. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions? Subject to the ground rules, you are entitled to one.

Mr Sulemana: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific question. Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed—Very well.

I will proceed to the Question numbered 6B, which stands in the name of Prof Kingsley Nyarko, Hon Member for Kwadaso Constituency.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I come under Order 88(3).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Measures to Promote and Enhance Security During the Christmas Period

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib *on behalf of Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso):* I beg to ask the Minister for the Interior, the measures the Ministry has put in place to promote and ensure enhanced security and safety in the Country, especially during the Christmas period.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

6:43 p.m.

Mr Terlabi: Mr Speaker, the Ministry of the Interior, through the Ghana Police Service, has instituted a comprehensive nationwide Christmas security strategy covering 25 police regions to ensure safety, law and order before, during and after the festive season. The strategy is anchored on enhanced visibility, community engagement, intelligence-led operations, inter-agency collaboration and targeted deployment to crime-prone locations.

As part of the preparations, the Police Administration has suspended all annual leave and recalled all able and essential personnel back to duty, effective Monday, 17th November 2025, to augment operational strength nationwide. In addition, the Service has taken delivery of 40 multi-purpose armoured vehicles, which are being deployed to strategic violent crime hotspots across the country to enhance police response and deterrence.

Mr Speaker, highway patrols have also been significantly intensified along major national corridors to ensure safe movement of people and goods during the period.

Across all Regions, the police have intensified day and night foot and mobile patrols, and snap checks in business districts, markets, transport terminals, beaches and entertainment centres and all tourist sites, motorbike and highway patrols along major corridors, including Accra-Kumasi, Kumasi-Techiman, Tamale-Bolgatanga, and Paga, Takoradi, Agona Nkwanta, Elubo, Accra, Aflao, Kintampo, Tamale, and all regional intercity routes.

Increased barrier and checkpoint operations including random stop and search operations. All police regional intelligence units have been directed to strengthen community informant networks, monitor emerging threats such as robberies, terrorism spillover, and cyber-enabled crimes affecting mobile money and electronic transactions;

Provide security for concerts, carnival, church conventions, crossover services, and open-air gatherings. Deploy rapid response teams to manage large crowds and emergencies;

Conduct targeted operations in identified criminal hotspots across the regions such as Aveno, Ashaiman, Kasoa, Suame, Tanoso, Krofuom, Tamale-Central, Walewale, Sunyani Zongo, Tarkwa, Koforidua Central, Ho Central, and other known high-crime suburbs;

The police administration is also working closely with other security agencies such as the Ghana Immigration Service, the Ghana National Fire Service, Narcotic Control Commission, and the National Intelligence Bureau to ensure security and safety during the period.

Mr Speaker, given the increased commercial activities during Christmas, the police, in partnership with MMDAs and market associations, will roll out deployment of additional uniformed personnel in some major markets and trading centres in the country; Fire safety

inspections and removal of illegal electrical connections in the market nationwide, and support banks, ATM, mobile money operators, and electronic transaction points.

To address congestion and reduce accidents, the police Motor Traffic and Transport Department (MTTD) has deployed personnel along all major highways and urban traffic choke points to enforce speed limits, drunk-driving regulations, and roadworthiness checks. The police will also conduct point operations with Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency (DVLA), National Road Safety Authority, to minimise crashes and fatalities. All regional commands have intensified community policing, radio and TV awareness campaigns, public education on personnel safety, cyber safety, and property protection, monitoring of social media platforms for security-related intelligence. These major measures are expected to reduce robberies, assaults

and thefts, manage congestion and traffic crashes, ensure secure movement of people and goods, provide safe environments for Christmas activities, and guarantee a peaceful, safe and enjoyable festive season for all residents of Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I want to follow up by first of all commending the Deputy Minister for such a comprehensive respond, but to find out from him whether with all this enhanced security—you would hear what the police is likely to do, including stop checks, mounting barriers and ensuring that people are not drunk driving and—he also indicated that they would not be going on leave. I just want to find out from him, are we going to give them any compensation for staying on track during this period?

Also, I would want to find out, when there are issues of fireworks, how do we intend to control or manage those as well? Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Terlabi: Please, the last part of your Question. How do we quench fire?

Mr Ahmed Shaib: There is an indication that we are now intending to purchase some fire tenders. I am also asking, when there are issues of fireworks—because Christmas, you would see a lot of fireworks—how do we intend to manage or control that?

Mr Terlabi: Thank you very much. I think that in my answer, I mentioned the fact that there is collaboration between the Ghana Police Service, Ghana Immigration Service and the Ghana National Fire Service. Therefore, through that, they would be able to attend to issues that would lead to outbreak of fire through those fireworks and things that you described.

So, there is a serious collaboration. It is not the Ghana National Fire Service and the Ghana Police Service alone, but all of them work together to take care of our safety. Thank you.

Compensation? I think the police administration will take care of that. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, these are housekeeping matters within the ambit of the police administration.

That ends the Urgent Questions for Ministry of the Interior. We then move to Oral Questions.

Question number 343, standing in the name of Sulemana Alhassan, Member of Parliament for Yunyoo.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF THE INTERIOR

Establishment of District Police Command in the Yunyoo/Nasuan District to Address Security Concerns

Mr Sulemana Alhassan (NDC — Yunyoo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the

Minister for the Interior plans the Ministry is implementing to address the pressing security concerns in the Yunyoo/Nasuan District to establish a dedicated district police command rather than sharing with Bunkpurugu District.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister?

Deputy Minister for the Interior (Mr Ebenezer Oklety Terlabi) (MP): Mr Speaker, I wish to state that Yunyoo/Nasuan Police District was approved by the Police Administration as a Police District in 2023. A Senior Police Officer was posted to the district before the 2024 general elections to oversee seven (7) police officers but was reposted out due to lack of office and residential accommodation. The District is currently putting up a Police District Headquarters which is about 85 per cent complete. The District has also made available a two-bedroom self-contained apartment for the occupation of the District Police Commander.

Mr Speaker, it is envisaged that the District will have a full-fledged Police Command when the project is completed. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr S. Alhassan: I am satisfied with the answer. Thank you.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us have some order.

Hon Members, this is a constituency specific Question, we will move to question number 344 also standing in the name of Mr Sulemana Alhassan, MP for Yunyoo.

Deployment of additional police personnel to Yunyoo/Nasuan District

Mr Sulemana Alhassan (NDC — Yunyoo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for the Interior what measures are being taken to deploy additional police personnel to the Yunyoo/Nasuan District to effectively address the rising crimes and armed robbery incidents. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you have the floor.

6:53 p.m.

Deputy Minister for the Interior (Mr Ebenezer Oklety Terlabi) (MP): Mr Speaker, just as I indicated in my earlier response on policing in the Yunyoo/Nasuan District, the Police Administration is considering beefing up its presence in the area with the posting of additional police personnel to augment the strength of the current officers in the District as a measure to curb rising crimes.

However, in the interim the Bunkpurugu District has been instructed to intensify patrols in the area.

Mr Speaker, another measure the Police Administration is considering to reduce, if not eliminate robbery in the

area, is the intensification of public engagement and the creation of Neighbourhood Watch Committees in selected communities in the enclave.

This initiative allows police personnel to interact with community members, providing them with essential security tips and encouraging them to share information with the police. It fosters a sense of involvement thus empowering the community to play an integral part of the security framework in the constituency.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr S. Alhassan: No, Mr Speaker, I am satisfied with the answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also a constituency-specific Question.

We will move to the Question numbered 394, for standing in the name of Hon Lawrence Agyinsam, MP for Hemang Lower Denkyira Constituency.

Ms Fatahiya Abdul Aziz: Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 88 (3) —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please proceed to ask the Question.

Furnishing of Two District Police Stations in Twifo Hemang Lower Denkyira

Ms Fatahiya Abdul Aziz on behalf of Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (NPP — Hemang Lower Denkyira): I beg to ask

the Minister for the Interior the plans of the Ministry to furnish the two district police stations in the Twifo Hemang Lower Denkyira District that face transportation challenges and logistical support.

Mr Terlabi: Mr Speaker, the two Police stations in the Twifo Hemang Lower Denkyira District fall under two separate Police Districts. The Jukwa Police Station falls under the Cape Coast Police District and the Twifo Hemang Police Station under the Twifo Praso District. The Police Administration has recently transferred a number Police Constables to every Police District in the country hence the two police stations will soon have their share of the transferred officers.

Mr Speaker, with respect to logistics, the Ghana Police Service is generally facing shortage of vehicles. It is envisaged that under the Government's retooling of the security services every Police station, including the two police stations under consideration, will benefit from the Programme.

Ms Abdul Aziz: There will not be any follow-up question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We will now move to the Question numbered 549. I think you asked Question number 549 instead of 394. The Minister answered the right Question. So, we move to the Question numbered 549, standing in the name of Mr Charles Owiredi, MP for Abirem.

Long-Term Strategy for Electoral Security Reform to Curb Politically Motivated Violence During Elections.

Mr Charles Owiredù (NPP — Abirem): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for the Interior whether the Ministry has developed a long-term strategy for electoral security reform particularly one aimed at curbing the impunity of politically motivated violence during elections.

Mr Terlabi: Mr Speaker, the Ministry of the Interior, through the Ghana Police Service and in collaboration with other security agencies has developed a comprehensive long-term strategy for Electoral Security reform aimed at curbing politically motivated violence and promoting credible, peaceful elections.

A Key component of this strategy is the establishment of an Election Command Centre to coordinate and manage all election-related security operations nationwide ensuring effective engagement and communication from the National level. Police are also deploying personnel equipped with body cameras and other electronic surveillance tools to promote transparency, accountability and real-time response to incidents during Elections.

Mr Speaker, a strategic framework document has been developed to outline pre-election, election-day, and post-election security measures. This framework emphasizes stakeholders' engagement, public education and

collaboration with political parties, civil society and the media to build trust and reduce tensions.

The Police Service now actively participates in Inter-Party Advisory Committee (IPAC) meetings to listen to stakeholders' concerns, contribute to decisions and address election security issues directly. Institutional coordination has also been strengthened through the National Election Security Task Force, which fosters close collaboration between the Police, the Electoral Commission, the Armed Forces and other security agencies.

Finally, enhanced community engagement and monitoring have been instituted to improve early warning systems, assess post-election security performance, and inform continuous reforms for future elections. These interventions collectively demonstrate the Ministry's sustained commitment to ensuring safe, transparent and violence-free electoral processes across the country.

Mr Owiredù: Mr Speaker, in the Minister's Response, he did say that they have outlined some measures, that is, police participating in IPAC meetings and also the setting up of an election command centre as measures that have been put in place to ensure that —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is your question?

Mr Owiredù: Mr Speaker, my question is that if these measures are actually in existence, how come we still

have a high incidence of election-related violence in Ghana?

Mr Terlabi: Mr Speaker, this is an ongoing process and definitely there might be some limitations. As usual, we are human beings and therefore it is not all of us that behave well sometimes. So, we expect that as we continue to engage and work together—Now the Ghana Police is also attending IPAC, but it was not like that. They will understand things better, the parties who engage them further will understand them better and I believe that going forward, the incidence will reduce. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That brings us to the end of the questions related for the Minister responsible for Interior. Hon Members, on your behalf, I sincerely thank the Deputy Minister for attending upon the House and providing answers to the Questions asked. Hon Minister, thank you very much. You are hereby discharged.

We then move to Urgent Questions numbered 6C, standing in the name of Hon Samuel Samuel Abdulai Jinapor. So, Hon Jinapor, the Minister — yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I wanted to draw your attention to the *Order Paper Addendum*, with same thing advertised on but it has a different number.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Order Paper Addendum, page 1. It is the same Question but the numbers are different. Hon Members, let us turn to the Order Paper Addendum, Urgent Questions

numbered 1, standing in the name of Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor. May I ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs to take the designated seat?

Yes, Hon Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, just for your information, both Sides have engaged that we should consider varying the original understanding, that it would not just be a follow-up question but there will be more follow-ups questions. I have been told the Minister is aware of that.

Mr Speaker, we are doing that out of deference. Thank you.

7:03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is the agreement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, you have the floor.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Impact of the U.S.A. Executive Order 14159 on Ghanaians and Measures to Ensure their Safety

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask

the Minister for Foreign Affairs how many Ghanaians are affected by the Executive Order 14159 of the President of the United States of America titled “Protecting the American People Against Invasion” and the measures the Ministry has put in place to ensure their safety.

Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP): Mr Speaker, I wish to thank the Hon Ranking Member for the Question relating to how many Ghanaians are affected by Executive Order 14159 of the President of the United States of America, titled, “Protecting the American People Against Invasion”, and to outline the measures the Ministry has implemented to ensure their safety.

The Executive Order of the President of the United States of America aims to strengthen the United States’ immigration enforcement by expanding the use of expedited removal, allowing deportation without court hearings. It proposes withholding federal funds from sanctuary jurisdictions and imposing criminal and civil penalties on immigrants who fail to register as undocumented.

The Order also calls for a substantial increase in hiring Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) and Customs and Border Protection (CBP) agents, restricts immigrants’ access to public benefits, expands Section 287(g) of the Immigration and Nationality Act, 1952 agreements with local enforcement, and increases federal prosecutions of immigration-related

offences. Updates from the Ghana Embassy in Washington D.C., regarding the deportation of Ghanaians from the United States since my last briefing to Parliament in March 2025 are as follows.

So far, Mr Speaker, 388 Ghanaians have been in detention since January this year on immigration-related charges. Of this number, 120 are awaiting final decisions by the Board of Immigration Appeals. Forty-nine have exhausted all legal processes and await final deportation arrangements.

As of today, per the Ministry’s records, 169 Ghanaians have been deported to Ghana since January 2025. Of this number, 90 arrived in Ghana unaccompanied on commercial flights and 66 on chartered controlled flights supervised by ICE agents. As of 18th November 2025, the Washington Mission has only one pending request from the U.S.A. ICE Agency in respect of the issuance of travel documentation.

A key development instituted by the Department of Homeland Security since 5th May 2025, is the launch of the Customs and Border Protection Home App, designed to facilitate the voluntary deportation of undocumented migrants residing in the U.S.A. The app allows immigrants to initiate the self-deportation process, providing financial and travel assistance to support their return to their country of origin. Additionally, it has been disclosed that any migrant who uses the app to self-deport will receive a payment of US\$1,000 upon confirmation of their return to their country of origin.

Mr Speaker, measures taken by the Ministry. Upon receiving notice of detained Ghanaians from the U.S.A. Government, Ghana's Mission in Washington visits and provides legal and consular assistance. The Ministry, through the Mission, verifies their nationalities and issues them with the required travel documents before deportation. The Ghana Immigration Service, the National Security, Ghana Port Health, the Ambulance Service, and the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO) are duly informed of the list of deportees, the date of their arrival, and flight details.

The deportees, upon arrival, are provided reintegration assistance, including food, social support, psychosocial services, money, skills, counselling, and medical support to facilitate their smooth reintegration into the Ghanaian society.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, if you look at the U.S.A. Department of Homeland Security data, it shows that countries like Liberia have an overstay rate approaching 50 per cent, Djibouti has 53 per cent, and Guinea has a similar percentage.

Yet, Mr Speaker, they were not included in this Executive Order 14159. The question, therefore, is, why is it that Ghana, with comparatively lower overstay levels, is captured under this

Executive Order 14159 and further subjected to visa and deportation-related sanctions? Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I am grateful to you. It is important to emphasise that Executive Order 14159 is not targeted at specific countries. ICE officials are emboldened by this Executive Order to remove those they consider "aliens". That is the terminology U.S.A. authorities use. So, it is important to recognise that the 388 Ghanaians who have been in detention since January this year were rounded up not because of their nationality or a targeted operation against Ghanaians. It is a general implementation of Executive Order 14159.

Now, on the matter of the overstay rates, from official documentation, Ghana is currently doing about 31 per cent of those overstays. I am glad to place on record, Mr Speaker, that we have had engagements with our counterparts in the U.S.A. and that is why, following those engagements, Ghana has been removed from the 36-country restriction list because the overstay rate was a criterion used by the Trump administration to impose visa restrictions. So, we lost the privileges, five-year visas, and other visa privileges that we used to enjoy.

But following those bilateral engagements, Ghana has since been removed from that 36-country restriction. We can confirm that

Ghanaian visa applicants are now enjoying a restoration of the five-year visas. So, for the record, Ghana is not currently under any form of sanction whatsoever so far as our bilateral relations with the United States of America is concerned.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

7:13 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any further questions?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, let me begin by thanking the Hon Minister for the lucid clarification he has given to this subject and proceed to ask my second supplementary question. Mr Speaker, can the Hon Minister explain to this House what specific factors led to Ghana's inclusion while these other high-risk countries were exempted? And by that, I am referring to the visa and deportation-related sanctions in the first place.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: I am grateful to you, Mr Speaker.

In the specific case of Ghana, the official communication from the United States of America indicated that it was a case of visa overstays. The second concern the United States officials raised had to do with official delegations that did not see 100 per cent return of all of

those who were on those delegations over a number of years. But as I indicated, we are out of that restriction, and I think that we have to commend all our officials for the high-level diplomatic engagement that I humbly led. I must thank everybody for the support, particularly the Committee on Foreign Affairs, my hardworking staff at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and then our Colleagues at the Washington Mission. They facilitated these engagements with the State Department.

I must also place on record that there was an eight-point criteria that led to countries being placed under those restrictions. In the case of Ghana, it was just visa overstays and then official delegations and all those on the official delegations not returning. And so, we should place on record that, unlike other countries that faced grave allegations, I am not saying that visa overstays is something we should be proud of, but compared to other items of the criteria like sponsoring terrorism, harbouring terrorists, engaging in money laundry, all of those matters that were listed in that eight-point criteria put out by the Trump administration, ours was just a case of visa overstays. And I think that in terms of the culpability of Ghana, it is just this issue with students not returning after their courses of study.

But we must really be honest in this discussion that it is also the U.S. companies that really lure students with very juicy offers when they graduate. And they then find it difficult to return to their motherland after graduation. We have intensified public education, and

we are urging our students that when they are graduating and are offered these very lucrative offers, they have the right to consider them. But they should not proceed to start working with a student visa. They can reapply for the appropriate visa, a visa that allows them to work as a fresh graduate in the United States of America if they so decide.

So, we have intensified public education. Our Information and Public Affairs Bureau is running all kinds of public education to help our students in particular and visa applicants generally to take advantage of these various visas. Some of our citizens genuinely do not know that there are different categories of visas, and that if you travel to the U.S. with a student visa, you can work with that visa after graduation even if the visa is still valid. What you need to do is to come back home and reapply, or even you can apply from the U.S., reapply for a different category of visa, a visa that allows you to work. So, we hope that with the public education, we are going to have this challenge of visa overstays by our students, which is at 31 per cent resolved once and for all.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is any further question? Probably, that will be your last supplementary question.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Thank you, Mr Speaker. This will be my final supplementary question.

The Hon Minister in his response alluded to the bilateral relations between

Ghana and the United States. I concede that the world, and Ghana as well, is going through very unusual and extraordinary times when it comes to American foreign policy.

Mr Speaker, by way of foundation to ask the question, the Hon Minister has been on record to have written a copious article about the United States, which gained a lot of international reportage. Mr Speaker, you know also that H.E. the President has also had occasion to write a full-blown article about the United States' President's handling of the President of South Africa—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what then is your question?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I am laying a foundation so that I can ask the question, so the Minister can—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, advert to Standing Order 88 (7).

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, respectfully, that is why I began by saying that the Hon Minister himself in his Answer alluded to the bilateral relations between the U.S. and Ghana. And finally, Mr Speaker, before I pose a question to the Minister. The Minister is also on record to have had some issues with U.S. Senator Jim Reese. The question is, what is the state of Ghana's bilateral diplomatic relations with the United States?

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, guided by the rules, the question is disallowed. It is not emanating from the original Question.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I just want to put on record that the Ghana overstay rate is 21 per cent and not 31 per cent as the Hon Minister alluded to. Also, the Ghana visitors' visa overstay rate is 7.5 per cent—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are completely out of order. Kindly resume your seat. Hon Member, this is a House guided by rules. So, let us look at the relevant rules and then see whether the Hon Member is really out of order or not. Hon Members, this is what Standing Order 88 (7) states:

“A Member, in asking a Question, shall not:

- a) address the House;
- b) raise any argument; or
- c) offer an opinion.”

So, you have to operate within the rules.

Mr Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the guidance.

Mr Speaker, the Minister put out some records: out of 388 Ghanaians, 49 of them awaiting deportation, 90 of them already in Ghana, one person pending and all that.

I want to ask the Hon Minister if he has averted his mind to the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) website, which have over 30,000 Ghanaians listed. Now, the difference is that when ICE has not apprehended you—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are again completely out of order. Hon Member, put your microphone off.

Yes, Ms Patricia Appiagyei?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

If I heard you, the reference you made was 87 (c), but it is 88 (7).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is what exactly I mentioned, Order 88 (7), and that is what I have read. It is Order 88 (7). Should I read it again? Order 88 (7),

“A Member, in asking the Question, shall not

- a) address the House;
- b) raise any argument; or
- c) offer an opinion.”

In this case, in asking Questions, we do not need your opinion. You need not raise any arguments or address the House. You go straight to ask the Question.

7:23 p.m.

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I respectfully take a cue, but I do not see how I can ask the Question without the foundation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, unfortunately, that is the rule that governs the House. I also do not see how I can bend the rules to allow you to offend same.

Mr Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Minister that the number of Ghanaians listed on the United States Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) website far outnumber the number of Ghanaians who have been written to the Embassy. In case there are additions, has the Ministry made some preparations towards that?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Hon Minister.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I would like to place on record that the number 388 is the official number provided to us by the Department of Homeland Security of the United States of America, and that is the figure we are working with. We have seen those publications, websites, media reports, and all of that. But we work with official documentation. We

have the names of these persons. We know where they are.

As I indicated earlier, our diplomats at the Washington Mission have gone to visit them. We are extending consular assistance to them. We are supporting them with legal support as is required of us as a country that cares about its citizens and always cherishes the consular obligations that we owe our citizens.

So, for the record, we are working with 388. That is what we have been provided by the U.S. authorities. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredi: Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

There have been some complaints from the deportees that on the flights during the deportation, they are put in shackles and chains. What efforts have been put in place to ensure that their rights are not abused?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, that is a very important question from the former Deputy Minister for Foreign Affairs. I would like to emphasise that the Government of Ghana would not condone any attempt to violate the fundamental human rights of our citizens. We have made clear that deportees have rights and that they should be deported within the confines of international law. They should not be abused. Their rights should be respected.

And that is why we insist that before these compatriots of ours are deported, we should be informed. And when we are informed, we ensure that we are at the airport to welcome them and to properly reintegrate them.

We ensure that we engage them, and so far, our engagement with these deportees has not shown any evidence of violation of their rights. But we have made clear that Ghana would not countenance that. I want to use this opportunity to assure Members of this august House that we are keeping an eye on their rights, right from when they are arrested and detained. We ensure that we visit them and ensure that they are detained under conditions which are humane and which do not affront their dignity as human beings. We do not compromise on that at all.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question numbered 6(d), which also stands in the name of Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, Member of Parliament for Damongo.

Assessment Conducted on Third-Party Deportees

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs what assessment was conducted on Third-Party Deportees and their potential risk to Ghana's security and social stability before receiving them into the country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Ranking Member for the Question and for the opportunity to provide the necessary clarification.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs operates strictly within the framework of Ghana's laws and the established interagency coordination mechanisms governing the admission of foreign nationals into the country. In matters involving persons of special status or third-party detainees, the Ministry does not act unilaterally. Instructions are sought from the President of the Republic and the Cabinet. The Ministry also works in close collaboration with the relevant national security and immigration agencies.

In accordance with established procedures, all communications concerning such individuals are received through formal diplomatic channels and duly verified. Upon receipt, these matters are immediately referred to the competent security agencies, including the Ministry of the Interior, the National Security Council Secretariat, and the Ghana Immigration Service, for the required background checks and threat assessments.

Mr Speaker, I wish to assure this Hon House that in all matters involving the admission of persons under special circumstances, the requisite security assessments and interagency clearances are undertaken by competent authorities. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs

proceeds only under express directives of the President, the collective advice of these agencies, and in full compliance with the procedures governing such engagements.

Furthermore, the Government of Ghana has consistently maintained in its engagements with all relevant states and institutions that individuals with criminal records will not be accepted into the country. This position reflects Ghana's unwavering commitment to safeguarding national security and ensuring that all processes involving the admission of foreign nationals comply with domestic law and international obligations.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has a long and respected tradition of providing refuge to persons on humanitarian grounds consistent with our national laws and international humanitarian obligations. Over the decades, the country has received refugees from diverse countries such as Liberia, Sierra Leone, Lebanon, La Côte d'Ivoire, and many others, reflecting our enduring commitment to humanitarian principles and regional stability. This tradition, Mr Speaker, has over the years also included the reception of individuals admitted under special arrangements, such as the well-known case involving the two former Guantanamo Bay detainees resettled in Ghana under an international agreement.

In all such instances, the Government has maintained a firm commitment to stringent security assessments, robust interagency coordination, and continuous monitoring to ensure that

national security and public safety are effectively safeguarded. Ghana has, over the decades, maintained its enviable track record as a bastion of peace and stability despite our friendly and humanitarian posture, which is a vindication of the thorough background checks, security assessments, and safety protocols we have enforced over the years.

The Ministry continues to work closely with the relevant national security and immigration agencies to ensure that all individuals admitted under such arrangements are handled in strict accordance with established procedures and that Ghana's security and public safety are upheld at all times.

The Ministry continues to closely monitor such matters in coordination with the appropriate security and immigration agencies to ensure that Ghana's sovereignty, security, and international responsibilities remain fully protected. Mr Speaker, the Government remains fully committed to maintaining the peace, stability and security of our nation and will continue to collaborate effectively with all relevant institutions to uphold these objectives. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

7:33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, any supplementary questions?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Minister for this very comprehensive response he has given.

On the strength of Article 75(2) of the 1992 Constitution and the express and clear Supreme Court decision in *Banful v. Attorney-General*, why has the Minister not brought the agreement between Ghana and the United States, which has resulted in these deportees to this House for ratification in the light of these clear provisions of the Constitution and the Supreme Court? Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker. It is our understanding that the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the United States of America, is an understanding, just an exchange of notes, and it is not a binding agreement. We can walk away from this at any time. The Attorney-General and Minister for Justice has well advised us that because it is an understanding, which you know as a Ranking Member, we go into on a daily basis. If you look at the work we do at the Foreign Ministry, on a daily basis, we can go into about 50 MoUs.

If we were to bring MoUs, which are not legally binding, to Parliament, it would be impractical. Our foreign policy will grind to a halt. We will not be able to function. So, loose understandings, note verbales, and exchange of notes cannot be treated as agreements or treaties, as we have been well advised by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

But Mr Speaker, I also want to use this opportunity to place on record that the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice has formally informed us of legal action which has been brought by a citizen of this country, the activist, Oliver Barker Vormawor. The Attorney-General and Minister for Justice has advised that in our public pronouncements and discussions on this matter, even in the House, we should be guided to contain our commentary in a way that it does not prejudice the outcome of the case that has been brought by a citizen at the Supreme Court. So, I will be well guided because of the Attorney-General's advice on how we proceed on this matter. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I am happy you are a senior lawyer. My Question to the Hon Minister is that, in the light of the clear decision of the Supreme Court in the *Banful v. Attorney-General case*, where the Court went as far as saying, even note verbales require Parliamentary ratification, the Court said, even note verbales and said MoUs require parliamentary ratification. This decision is in black and white, and it was very explicit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you talking with reference to Article 181(5)?

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I am making reference to Article 75(2) of the 1992 Constitution, which was interpreted by the Supreme Court in the

case of *Banful v. Attorney-General, 2017-2020 Supreme Court of Ghana Law Report* at page 82. You would find these express decisions of the Supreme Court, where they said even note verbales— The Minister refers to note verbales, and says exchanges of notes between States.

The Supreme Court said that even exchange of such note verbales, requires parliamentary ratification. The Question to the Minister, my very good Friend is, why has he not, in the teeth of this clear decision of the Supreme Court, brought this important agreement to this this sovereign House of the people for ratification?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, it appears you are repeating your Question. The Question has been answered. I have heard the Minister stating that this is not a binding agreement, a binding memo, and that on a daily basis, they do that. Parliament would therefore be inundated if that is what they are supposed to do. So, I consider your Question to be repetitive.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect, this is a completely different Question. I ask the Question as to why the Minister did not bring the agreement for ratification. In the Minister's answer, he said, the advice given to him by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is that MoUs are not binding and therefore are not to be brought for ratification.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He said this particular MoU is not binding.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: I said, the note verbales, the Supreme Court decided that a none-binding MoU—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let me year the Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I did not hear the Minister say it is an MoU; I heard him say an understanding. I heard him say it is an understanding between our Foreign Ministry and the government. Let us keep to the wording. He said understanding, so unless the Hon Member shows that in the Supreme Court decision, they included understandings.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, the Question is simple. The understanding between the Government of Ghana and the United States of America, is it an MoU or not? Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you, Mr Speaker —

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, is it an understanding or MoU?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Our rules are clear. A Question shall not solicit the expression of an opinion or the solution of an abstract legal case. Mr Speaker, to ask him to make a determination— He is

asking him to make a determination whether an understanding is an MoU or some other legal document. He is asking him to make a legal determination, to give an opinion on what he thinks—*[Interruption]*—He asking him to give a legal opinion, to make a legal determination, clearly in violation of our rules.

You cannot ask him. He earlier indicated that this matter is even in the court, and these same issues that we are discussing will come up in arguments in court. The court will be expected to take a decision on that. What we say here definitely will have an impact on the outcome—*[Interruption]*—The rules are clear, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. As I said earlier, for the avoidance of doubt, this is an understanding which is not legally binding. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, your last question.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, my very good Friend, the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs, has a very big reputation of being very intelligent, smart and clever. The Majority Leader is almost—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member you are completely out of Order.

7:43 p.m.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: The final question, Mr Speaker. Deutsche Welle, DW Africa, a reputable German, international news broadcast station, has reported that Eswatini, which is in a similar situation as Ghana, has been paid US\$5.1 million from the United States of America. On the account of receiving third-party deputies, the question to the Minister is, what stands in for Ghana, especially since our peers such as Nigeria, Senegal and the rest are not part of this arrangement—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question completely overruled for not being within our Orders. Hon Member, your Question is to ask the Minister of Foreign Affairs what assessment was conducted on third-party deportees and their potential risk to Ghana's security and social stability. You are talking about receipt of money.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I will ask a new question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, if you do not have any other question—

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I will ask a new question, but before I do, this question arose from the Minister's answer. That is why I was getting more clarification from the Minister. This is because the Minister veered into those areas—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then you should have been quoting the Minister rather than quoting Eswatini.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: But I quoted him first, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, ask another question.

Mr S. A. Jinapor: The question to the Minister, and I take out Eswatini and DW Africa. The question to the Minister is that, given the obligations Ghana has taken, arising out of this understanding with the United States of America, to quote the Minister's words, what is in it for Ghana, our national interest and the promotion of the public interest of Ghana? What is the quid pro quo? What is the consideration?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, let me reiterate for the record that the Government of Ghana has not requested any monetary support, logistical support or any material support for this intervention. The understanding is purely on humanitarian grounds. We are pan-Africanists. These are fellow West Africans who are in distress, being detained, treated shabbily, without dignity, and we cannot look on as Kwame Nkrumah's Ghana, a pan-Africanist country. We are saying that Ghana is their home; they can come here.

In any case, under ECOWAS protocols, West African nationals do not need visas to travel. In the spirit of regional integration, they can enter Ghana without visas and stay here for 90 days at least. So, Mr Speaker, this is the decision we made purely on humanitarian and pan-African grounds, and we did not ask for a cent or a pesewa, from President Trump's America.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Anyimadu-Antwi?

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from the Minister if he distinguishes an understanding of Ghana as a government with another country as not falling under Article 75.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, once again, our rules are clear. Soliciting the "expression of an opinion or the solution of an abstract legal case or a hypothetical proposition" is not allowed by Order 86 (1) (f). What the Hon Member is asking the Minister to do is to express an opinion. He has already indicated to us that we have an understanding, we are not bound legally, and in any case, those citizens are equal citizens who have a right. They have a right to even tell the American government to alight them in Ghana. And when they arrive at our airport and show that they are an equal citizen, we cannot say they should not enter Ghana. So, what is the legal issue here?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I am not invoking his opinion. He is rather interpreting Article 75 of the Constitution that this understanding, to quote the Minister, "is an understanding between government of Ghana and the United States of America". And I am asking that is he saying that the framers of the Constitution, under Article 75, did not anticipate understanding as he is quoting—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Anyimadu-Antwi, the Minister indicated clearly that he got an advice from the Attorney-General's Department. So, having told you that he was advised by the Attorney-General's Department, if you are not soliciting his opinion, why will you not take the advice given to him by the Attorney-General? So, clearly, you are soliciting the opinion of the Minister.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I am not arguing with you. But I believe that as the Minister of Foreign Affairs, it is not every advice that the Attorney-General gives that the Ministry is bound by.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Anyimadu-Antwi, you know that when it comes to legal matters, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is the advisor. Do you want the Minister to ignore Article 88 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana? The Minister cannot ignore the constitutional imperative in Article 88. Yes?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the whole question is premised on Article 75 and the original person who asked the question made reference to it. Article 75 says that "The President may execute himself or cause to be executed treaties, agreements or conventions in the name of Ghana." So, a treaty, agreement or convention was executed.

So, first to make a claim that there is a treaty subject to parliamentary ratification, we must establish execution.

But when a Minister for Foreign Affairs meets his counterpart and says, we want to do this, can we let the citizens come to the country? And he says, well, in any case, they are equal citizens and have a right to come, we will receive them if they come, except that they should give us prior notice.

I sat in Cabinet and heard all the conversations so I know what deliberations went into it. No treaty executed must come before this House unless a manifestation of an executed treaty is produced. Execution is an operational term there.

If it is "executed"—execution is a term of action. So, please, let us not go there. He is asking the Minister for his opinion on complex legal matters and he says he has been advised by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, so let us leave it at that. The Speaker has ruled.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I do not intend to litigate this. If Mr Speaker permits me, I will ask another question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I would want to find out from the Minister what he means by "understanding" under the circumstances.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Minister, according to Hon Anyimadu-Antwi the word "understanding is nebulous. So, what do you mean by "understanding"?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, in diplomatic terminology, “understanding” simply means that we are *ad idem* and are proceeding together in deepening our bilateral understanding.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, if I am permitted, again, the Minister uses a legal terminology to mean that “when two countries act *ad idem*,”. I want the Minister to explain further. Thank you.

7.53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Anyimadu-Antwi, acting *ad idem* is acting with a common purpose.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I want to ask the Minister whether the advice from the Attorney-General was in writing or verbal.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the 1992 Constitution says the Attorney-General should give advice. The 1992 Constitution did not indicate such advice should be oral or in writing. If you have another question, ask. You can look at Article 88 of the 1992 Constitution.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, respectfully, he said that he has been advised. I am not challenging that. I am only asking the Minister whether this advice was in writing or verbal. That is all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am also referring you to Article 88 of the 1992 Constitution. Any further questions?

Dr Mahama, you have the floor.

You asked your question, and I intend not to put that question to the Minister. If you have a new question, ask.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Thank you.

Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Minister whether the understanding between Ghana and the U.S.A. was in writing or verbal.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The understanding was communicated via the exchange of notes. And in diplomatic corridors, I am sure the Hon Member understands what the exchange of notes are. So that was the format.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any other questions?

Mr Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Per the answer of the Minister and his reference to the answers to the Ranking Member's question, I heard the Minister saying on TV3 that we have visa restrictions, we have African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA) extension, and we want to reduce the 15 per cent tariff. Mr Speaker, I want to ask if these things, per what he said on TV3, influenced —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I have not heard those things on the floor, so the rules do not allow you to bring TV3 issues which have not emanated here. I believe you can also look for a media platform and do it.

Dr Kabiru Mahama, do you have a question to ask? I think that will end the question. We have a lot of oral questions to be—

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: Mr Speaker. I thank you very much for indulging me.

I would like to find out from the Minister whether the understanding was reduced to a note verbale, and could the House be furnished? Because Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kabiru Mahama, tell me the rules in Questions and supplementary questions that allow you to make a demand of note verbale.

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: Mr Speaker, the rules have not specified whether I cannot also make requests for such. The rules have not also made any requirement unless, of course, there is a rule that refers me to the fact that we cannot—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kabiru Mahama, if you want to make demand of something, you know how to do it. This is not the appropriate platform. So, kindly resume your seat.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, for most countries, there are classifications of documents that can be shared. So, it is not every document that one can just give out. Even if from the Ghana side, we do not have a problem giving it out, from the U.S.A. side, there are a lot of clearances that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if he is using the appropriate channel, he will realise that some documents are classified information.

Yes, Jerry Ahmed Shaib.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

I want to ask the respected Minister how many deportees we have received so far, and if he has checked their security backgrounds before taking them?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that was the essence of the Question asked and answered. Hon Member, the Question is, to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs what assessment was conducted on third-party deportees and their potential risk to Ghana's security and social stability before receiving them into the country.

So, the Question that was asked and the question that you are asking, what difference do we have? I think it amounts to the same thing.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am not too clear if he mentioned the numbers we have received.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Ablakwa: I am grateful, Mr Speaker.

So far, the number of the third-party deportees we have received is 38. The first group was 14, and the second group was 24. So, 38 deportees have so far been received.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I just want to find out from the respected Minister, how many are Ghanaians and what other countries are they coming from?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He is talking in terms of third-party deportees. That is the number that he has given. So, regarding the third-party deportees, why are you talking about how many are Ghanaian and how many are —

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you for the correction. Beyond the third-party deportees, which countries are they coming from?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What do you mean by “beyond the third-party deportees”?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am trying to find out the nationalities of the third-party deportees.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That was not what you said. You said “beyond the third-party deportees”, and I am asking, what you mean by “beyond the third-party deportees”?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I have changed my question. What are the nationalities of these third-party deportees?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I urge you to ask a specific Question so that the Minister can prepare the answer about all 38 deportees and their countries. Hon Members, I think we are moving to the oral Questions, which are a lot, and we need to take all of them today. We will move to the Question numbered 472, standing in the name of Rev John Ntim Fordjour. The Member of Parliament for Assin South.

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I rise on Order 88(3) to seek permission from you to ask for and on behalf Rev John Ntim Fordjour.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, it does not lie on my permission. Once you have not been authorised to ask the Question, please resume your seat.

Nana Ayeh: Mr Speaker, he has authorised me, and I am seeking your approval.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you can ask the Question.

8:03 p.m.

**Ghana's Abstention at the UN
Human Rights Council on the
Renewal of the LGBTQ Independent
Expert Mandate**

Mr Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh *on behalf of Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South)*: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs which factors accounted for Ghana's "abstain" vote taken at the UN Human Rights Council in Geneva in July 2025 in respect of renewing the mandate of the Independent Expert on LGBTQ rights.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, as you are aware, Ghana was elected to the Human Rights Council in 2023 for a three-year term, commencing on 1st January, 2024. Since Ghana's tenure began, Ghana has demonstrated exceptional leadership, serving as the coordinator of the African Group of the Human Rights Council in 2025.

We have also successfully led the African Group to negotiate and table several pivotal resolutions, including, one, the negative impact of the non-repatriation of funds of illicit origin and the importance of improving international cooperation, HRC 58. Two, technical assistance and capacity building for South Sudan and Mali, HRC 58; the elimination of female genital mutilation, HRC 59; reparatory justice and a world of sports free from racism, HRC 60.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, Ghana has strategically co-sponsored 12 resolutions aligned with the government's priorities, including those on the right to food, the human rights of older persons, women in diplomacy, water and sanitation, and the rights of women and children in conflict. Ghana's tenure on the council has strengthened our reputation as a champion of human rights and social justice.

Ghana's delegation to the Human Rights Council meeting on 7th July, 2025, which voted on the renewal of the mandate of the independent experts on protection against violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity, was led by Ghana's permanent representative to the United Nations in Geneva, an accomplished and experienced career diplomat. Before the vote, our delegation in Geneva held extensive consultations on the matter in Geneva and Accra.

The voting on 7th July, 2025 was on resolution number 59, the mandate of independent experts on protection against violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity. This was not a vote on LGBTQ, whether a country supports LGBTQ or not. We need to clarify that.

Mr Speaker, it may be noted that the resolution on the mandate of the independent experts was first adopted by Human Rights Council in 2011 and subsequently renewed in 2014, 2016, 2019 and 2022. The resolution requests the independent experts to continue to report annually to the Human Rights

Council and the General Assembly on the implementation of the mandate in accordance with their respective programmes of work. During the 59th Session of the Council, Ghana's permanent representative used the occasion to state clearly Ghana's position on LGBTQ. And Mr Speaker, with your permission, I quote from the permanent representative's address:

“Our understanding of the traditional definition of gender is the male sex or female sex, especially when considered with reference to social and cultural differences. Similarly, sex, in our view, refers to the two main categories, male and female, into which humans and most other living things are divided, used for statistical and policy purposes”

Mr Speaker, Ghana therefore abstained from the vote in accordance with Chapter 5, Article 17 of the 1992 Constitution, which specifically prohibits discrimination on the grounds of gender, race, colour, ethnic origin, religion, creed or social and economic status. For the avoidance of doubt, there was no vote on the support of LGBTQI+++, for which Ghana abstained. Misleading and baseless media reports on this matter were clarified by the Ministry through a press statement on 9th July, 2025. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs is very mindful of the Ghanaian public's general and strong opposition to the practice of LGBTQI+++, and the Government's strong stance against the subject of LGBTQI rights.

It will, therefore, Mr Speaker, be totally against the will of the Ghanaian people and the Government led by President Mahama if the Ministry of Foreign Affairs undermines this position.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Ayeh: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I want to ask the Hon Minister who authorised the decision to abstain, whether it was from him or from the President.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, for the avoidance of doubt, I have the resolution which the Human Rights Council voted on. I brought a copy here, and I would like to lay it for the House to consider.

The resolution is very clear. It says that a vote on the mandate of the independent expert on protection against violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity. That was the resolution. There was no vote on support for LGBTQI. So, Mr Speaker, I will table the resolution.

For the second part of the Hon Member's question, I have stated that our permanent representative, a distinguished career diplomat, consulted extensively at headquarters and the

African group in Geneva, where Ghana is currently the chair of the African Group on the Human Rights Council. And this was the decision we came to, that on extending the mandate of the independent expert, Ghana will abstain, because we do not really want to take a position on whether the tenure of the independent expert should be extended or not. To us, that was really not a significant matter as far as our foreign policy priorities are concerned at this point in time.

So, Mr Speaker, let me reiterate, for the record, there has been no vote on support for LGBTQI. I have no doubt that if the Ministry of Foreign had gone to abstain or vote for LGBTQI, as some misleading media reports claim, President Mahama would have relieved me of my position immediately, because I know President Mahama's position, I know the position of the people of this country, including our constituents, as Members of Parliament, and the Speaker of Parliament, the Rt Hon Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin, we all know, is strongly opposed to LGBTQI, and indeed, all of us.

That day, I recall, during the Private Members' Bill, all MPs were asked if there is any Member who does not support the Private Members' Bill to stand up. We were all here. All 275 of us at the time, including me, nobody stood up to oppose the Private Members' Bill. So, I will not, after that, go to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and give instructions to the contrary. Mr Speaker, let us clarify the point.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary questions?

Mr Ayeh: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I think the long and short of the Minister's response is that Ghana abstained.

Mr Speaker, I also want to—

8:13 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, why do you always like running commentary contrary to our rules? The question I asked is whether you have a supplementary question?

Mr Ayeh: Yes, I do.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then ask the supplementary question.

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I have the mandate of the General Assembly with me here, and I do not know if I have to tender it. But the 59 mandate, is for the promotion and protection. I want to ask the Hon Minister if he agrees that Ghana abstained from the promotion and the protection of—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, once you have resumed your seat, if any other person is not ready to ask a supplementary question, then let us

move to Question numbered 416, which stands in the name of Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey. You have the floor.

Current State of Ghana's Chancery in Nigeria

Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (NDC — Keta): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the current state of Ghana's Chancery in Nigeria, given recent reports of deterioration, and what measures the Ministry is implementing to rectify structural defects, outdated furniture and improve poor sanitation.

Mr Ablakwa: I thank the Hon Member for Keta, my good Friend, Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey, for his timely and important Question regarding the current State of Ghana's Chancery in Nigeria, and the measures being implemented by the Ministry to address reports of deterioration, structural defects, outdated furnishings, and sanitation concerns.

The Ministry is fully cognisant of the vital role our diplomatic missions play as the Republic of Ghana's physical representation abroad. I wish to assure this august House that the Ministry has taken concrete steps to address these concerns, ensuring our Missions operate in an environment befitting the dignity of our nation. Before I address the specific interventions, allow me to provide context by reflecting on the historical and strategic significance of our bilateral relations with the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

Mr Speaker, Ghana and Nigeria share a longstanding and multifaceted relationship, rooted in shared history, cultural affinity, and regional cooperation. As founding members of the ECOWAS and key actors in continental diplomacy, both nations have consistently collaborated on peacekeeping, trade, migration, and democratic governance. The presence of vibrant Ghanaian and Nigerian communities across borders further underscores the depth of people-to-people ties and mutual interdependence. Ghana and Nigeria also share a deep and complex history, rooted in our common colonial heritage under British rule, where both nations inherited similar administrative and legal systems.

While our relationship has experienced moments of tension, notably the Aliens Compliance Order of 1969 and Nigeria's mass deportation of Ghanaians in 1983, it has matured into a robust partnership, anchored in ECOWAS cooperation as well as shared security interests. Our diplomatic missions in Abuja and Lagos serve not only as administrative outposts but are symbols of Ghana's enduring commitment to regional solidarity, sovereign dignity, and strategic engagement with Nigeria.

Mr Speaker, I undertook a three-day working visit to Nigeria from 5th to 7th April 2025 to inspect all our diplomatic properties in Abuja and Lagos. This visit was prompted by persistent reports of infrastructure deterioration and was aligned with the Ministry's renewed commitment to prudent asset stewardship and institutional accountability.

During this visit, I personally witnessed the extent of deterioration at both Missions, manifesting in structural defects and operational deficiencies that not only undermine the welfare of our diplomatic personnel but also diminish the image and structure of Ghana's representation abroad. The conditions I observed during the inspection were not merely technical shortcomings but reflect a broader pattern of infrastructure neglect that has accumulated over years of deferred maintenance and underinvestment.

Mr Speaker, our diplomatic Missions in the Federal Republic of Nigeria, namely the High Commission in Abuja and the consulate in Lagos, have historically operated from refurbished or acquired facilities, many of which were not originally designed to meet the evolving demands of modern diplomacy.

Over the years, these properties have served Ghana with distinction, but they now bear the weight of time, deferred maintenance, and changing operational requirements. In Abuja, the Chancery building, while still functional, exhibits visible signs of structural fatigue, cracks in the walls, outdated electrical and plumbing systems, and limited spatial configuration have constrained the mission's ability to operate at optimal capacity.

The residential units which house home-based staff have also deteriorated, with issues including water seepage, an unreliable power supply, inadequate ventilation, and security vulnerabilities.

Mr Speaker, regarding Ghana's consulate in Lagos, the situation is even more acute. The consulate is located at No. 12 Oba Akinjobi Street, GRA, Ikeja, and was acquired in 2008 from a private consortium. However, due to delays in transferring the title to the Government of Ghana and securing budgetary allocations, the facility has not undergone any major renovation since its acquisition. The building now suffers from severe leakage from the roofs and compromised ceilings, persistent plumbing failures and sanitation hazards, non-functional air conditioning systems in a high-humidity environment, outdated and broken furniture, fixtures, and fittings, diminished security infrastructure, and poor lighting conditions.

Mr Speaker, it is important to underscore that these infrastructure challenges are not isolated incidents, but symptomatic of a broader pattern of under-investment in our foreign service infrastructure. The Ministry has, therefore, resolved to treat the rehabilitation of our Missions not as routine maintenance, but as a strategic imperative, one that aligns with our national identity, institutional pride, and commitment to ethical governance.

Following my inspection, Mr Speaker, I issued the following directives, which were communicated through official press releases and parliamentary statements. Immediate submission of renovation proposals by both missions, suspension of all asset disposal activities pending audits, prioritisation of sanitation, security, and staff

accommodation upgrades, and acceleration of property registration processes in Lagos. These directives are part of a broader policy shift to restore dignity, functionality, and institutional pride to Ghana's foreign service infrastructure.

As part of the Ministry's strategic transitioning from rental to infrastructure development initiative, we have successfully reviewed a comprehensive proposal submitted by the Abuja Mission for the extensive renovation of the main Chancery building. The proposal outlines a detailed scope of interventions to address structural defects, modernise the facility, and elevate the Chancery to a standard that reflects Ghana's diplomatic stature and operational relevance, while the comprehensive plan for the main Chancery undergoes final budgetary and technical review.

The Ministry has already approved the immediate rehabilitation of four residential units located directly behind the chancery block. This proactive measure is essential to maintaining acceptable accommodation standards for our home-based staff and ensuring continuity in operational readiness and staff welfare.

The Ministry places the highest premium on the safety of its personnel and the protection of national assets. In line with this commitment, I am pleased to inform this honourable House that approval has been granted for a substantial enhancement of the security infrastructure at our Chancery in Abuja.

The approved upgrades include the deployment of comprehensive closed-circuit television CCTV systems throughout the chancery compound to strengthen surveillance coverage and support real-time incident tracking, the establishment of an additional strategically positioned security outpost to reinforce perimeter surveillance and enhance the Mission's capacity for swift incident response, the installation of solar-powered compound and street lighting systems to guarantee continuous illumination independent of the national power grid, thereby enhancing night-time visibility and strengthening overall security coverage.

The Ministry undertook the following actions in respect of the Lagos Consulate. The Ministry moved with urgency to initiate remedial action guided by our commitment to institutional accountability and the restoration of dignity to our foreign service infrastructure. As part of this effort, we have received a formal renovation proposal from our consulate in Lagos through our Mission in Abuja, which has been incorporated into the broader framework of the Strategic Transition from Rental to Infrastructure Development, the STRIDE initiative.

Our new policy, STRIDE, has received Cabinet approval. Its implementation begins in 2026. The 2026 Budget has made provision for the STRIDE initiative. STRIDE will end the unacceptable phenomenon of spending, on average, US\$50 million annually on rent and significantly transform the state of Ghana's diplomatic properties.

8:23 p.m.

I wish to assure this Hon House that the renovation proposals being reviewed will comprehensively address the matters raised. Specifically, the plans include corrective measures for long-standing plumbing and sanitation deficiencies, as well as the development of obsolete fixtures and furnishings.

Our objective is not merely to undertake repairs but to transform the Chancery into a modern, functional, and aesthetically appropriate environment, one that supports the well-being of our staff and offers a dignified, welcoming space for all who engage with our Consulate.

It is important to note that, having initiated all necessary steps to rectify these problems, one of the key factors in realising our goal remains the finalisation of the property registration in Lagos. This process is being actively prioritised and is expected to be completed imminently by our Mission, serving as a critical prerequisite for the commencement of the outlined renovation works.

Cancellation of Sale and Update on Prosecution

Upon assuming office, I immediately cancelled two controversial transactions initiated by the previous administration to sell Ghana's diplomatic properties in Nigeria and Zambia. In the case of Nigeria, a part-payment of US\$1.5 million had already been made to a private individual, Mr Bright Mensah

Bonsu, under questionable circumstances. I am pleased to inform this House that the said individual has since been arrested, and criminal prosecution is underway.

This decisive action reflects our zero-tolerance stance on state capture and our unwavering commitment to the principles of Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL).

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs remains resolute in its commitment to restoring Ghana's diplomatic infrastructure to standards that reflect our national dignity, operational excellence, and international obligations. The Missions in Abuja and Lagos are being prioritised under the STRIDE Initiative, and we are actively pursuing legal, financial, and technical pathways to ensure their full rehabilitation.

These efforts are not merely infrastructural; they are emblematic of our broader vision for ethical governance, prudent asset stewardship, and the preservation of Ghana's legacy abroad.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Gakpey: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would like to find out from the Minister, in terms of cost-effectiveness, what would he prefer: renovating *vis-à-vis* pulling down the structure and bringing a new one?

I would like to find out from you which one is cost-effective whether pulling down the whole structure for new building or renovation?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I would like to place on record that a structural integrity report is available and the structural integrity that was carried out advises that for the Abuja Chancery, we should carry out major renovations, and that the foundations and the columns and pillars are still strong. On Lagos, we are awaiting the structural integrity report. It has started, but that has not been concluded. We also have the hurdle of securing the title, making sure that we get all the appropriate documentation on the Lagos Chancery. So, Mr Speaker, these are the progress reports.

I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Gakpey: Mr Speaker, no. I just want to use the opportunity to thank the Hon Minister for saving this country yearly US\$15 million every month.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredu (NPP — Abirem): Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs, under the first tenure of H.E. President Mahama when we had the Ms Hanna Tetteh being the Minister for Foreign Affairs, there was this facility

that was assessed from the Société Générale, about US\$50 million, that was used to purchase some of these properties. Would you want to avert your mind to that kind of facility to be able to get that needed funds to embark on this project that you want to do? Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member of Parliament is right about the US\$50 million facility which was secured by the Ms Hanna Tetteh from Société Générale. Except that the records available at the Ministry, which I am sure the former Deputy Minister can confirm, is that the US\$50 million has been exhausted. That fund is no longer available, so we need to have a new arrangement which can take care of the challenges we are facing with rent. We still are renting in too many of our countries where we have diplomatic missions. We are renting Chanceries Ambassadors' residence, and residence for staff. Even though the US\$50 million facility helped, it really did not address the issue comprehensively. We are hoping—We have done the analysis, and we will need about US\$350 million according to what a transaction advisor appointed by the Ministry of Finance has indicated.

They are currently going through the processes of negotiating with the banks to put together a consortium of banks to take care of these urgent requests of transitioning from rental to owning our own property, so that we can save scarce

taxpayer resources. Mr Speaker, when the negotiations are concluded, I am sure we shall return to this House for the final arrangement to be approved by this House, and then we will know exactly how much is going to be committed to the Strategic Transition from Rental to Infrastructure Development (STRIDE) initiative.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 191 standing in the name of Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe, Member of Parliament for Suhum.

Strategy for The New Foreign Policy Document

Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (NPP — Suhum): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the strategy of the Ministry for the new foreign policy document per the National Security Strategy of 2020.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member for his Question.

It is well known that the current Administration pledged in its 2024 manifesto to restore Ghana's global influence and enhance our role in international relations by pursuing a comprehensive Foreign Policy that reaffirms our founding Pan-African

vision, considers contemporary geopolitical realities, and emphasises strategic engagement.

Upon assuming the post as Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Ghana, I tasked the Ministry to initiate the process of formulating a comprehensive foreign policy that aligns diplomacy with economic development, security needs and global trends to enable the country to secure its national interests and support domestic priorities.

A Ministry Committee, after several meetings, prepared a proposed document, which was circulated for staff input. This process, which is critical to ensuring ownership and buy-in of frontline executors of Ghana's Foreign policy, culminated in a draft concept paper.

Subsequently, a committee comprising Foreign Service Officers and Members of the International Relations and Foreign Policy team of the NDC manifesto held a meeting in the Ministry on Wednesday, 21st May, 2025, to evaluate the draft concept paper. The meeting, which was chaired by the Chief Director of the Ministry, after extensive deliberations, concurred on the need to consolidate the draft concept paper and a policy paper submitted by the team, as well as establish a joint working committee to plan and organise a workshop for the finalisation of a comprehensive Foreign Policy.

The draft concept paper emphasises economic diplomacy in support of macroeconomic stabilisation, trade and investment promotion, manufacturing

and agriculture, digital transformation, clean energy, youth employment and infrastructure-led development, all of which are central pillars of the government's agenda and have parallels in the National Security Strategy 2020.

The comprehensive policy will operate across multiple, interrelated dimensions of international engagement. It would serve as a strategic framework that enables our foreign policy practitioners and implementers to fully appreciate and navigate the complex web of international relations, ensuring that our national interests are effectively promoted and protected.

8.33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the core components of the draft policy, which will be considered at a stakeholder workshop scheduled for 8 to 9 December 2025 to finalise the policy document, include political and diplomatic engagement, economic diplomacy, security and defence cooperation, cultural and diaspora diplomacy, environmental and climate diplomacy, and multilateral and regional engagement.

Mr Speaker, it is worthy of note that the core components of the draft comprehensive policy will align with the National Security Strategy 2020, which also recognises cooperation with other friendly states at the regional, continental, and global levels. The strategy also recognises that security threats require not only national but also regional and global countermeasures.

The draft policy is being crafted with the same mindset of an intricate connection between national security threats and the regional and global challenges that confront Ghana. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Bekoe: Going by this position, do the Hon Minister mind expanding the consultation processes?

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, that is a very important proposal, and I would work with this House to expand the consultative process. We certainly had already earmarked consultations with Parliament, but I am sure that we can all work together to have a wider scope to include as many Ghanaians, Civil Society Organisations (CSOs), and experts who are willing to join us to prepare this National Security Strategy document and the comprehensive foreign policy. So, we will work with Hon Colleagues to expand the consultations. Thank you very much.

Mr Bekoe: Since the National Security Strategy document tends to deal with traditional and human security issues, can the Minister give me some timelines?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Give you what, guidelines?

Mr Bekoe: Timelines.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Timelines? Very well.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I did indicate that the broad consultations that

we have planned will come off on the 8th and 9th of December this year. Our programme is that by the first half of 2026, we should have this comprehensive foreign policy launched by His Excellency the President. So, we are working towards July 2026 for this important comprehensive foreign policy document to be out-doored. But, Mr Speaker, let me also place on record that we are not waiting for this document to be out-doored before we really address the threats that we face, particularly the threats of terrorism and violent extremism.

So, in February next year, we shall be convening an international conference on the security threat, particularly from the Sahel region, and we will be working with Colleagues. I know that the Hon “Protozoa”, as we all call him, would want to work with us because I know that these are matters that are of enormous interest to him.

So, Mr Speaker, we are really conscious of the threats which keep escalating day by day, and even before we outlaw this comprehensive foreign policy, we are engaging and putting together this conference to make sure that we replace the Moribund Accra Initiative and have a platform that is fit for purpose to address the extremist threat that we face.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions? We then move to the Question numbered 329, standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel K. Ntekuni, MP for Pru West.

Efforts Made to Bring Back Ghanaian Youth Trapped in Côte d'Ivoire by Q-Net Scam

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni (NDC — Pru West): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity. I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the efforts being made by the Ministry to locate and bring back the Ghanaian youth who are currently trapped in La Cote d’Ivoire by Q-Net under the guise of aiding them to travel to Europe and other countries for greener pastures.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I commend the Hon Colleague for his Question.

Background

In recent years, a significant number of vulnerable Ghanaians, particularly the youth, have fallen victim to the increasing activities of cross-border fraudulent syndicates operating in some African countries, including Côte d’Ivoire, under the banner of Quest Net International (QNET). The syndicates that exploit Ghanaian nationals mainly comprise fellow Ghanaians who lure unsuspecting compatriots to supposed transit countries in West Africa, including Côte d’Ivoire, under the pretext of facilitating their onward travel to France or other destinations in Europe or elsewhere for paid jobs.

Mr Speaker, in January 2025, 160 cases were recorded by our Mission in Abidjan. Out this number, 60 Ghanaians are in Abidjan district and 100 are in three locations in the hinterland of Cote

d' Ivoire namely; Ganao, Nisia, Daloa and Divo. Out of the 60 in Abidjan, 40 Ghanaians screened were found to be victims and were released by the Ivoirian authorities. The other 20 were found to be perpetrators and are still in detention facilities in Abidjan. They have appeared in court three times since June 2025. The last court date was 17th October, 2025. Investigations and the trial process are still ongoing.

Measures taken by the Mission in Côte d'Ivoire: The Mission has undertaken consular visits since June 2025. The Mission has also worked with the family members of the 20 Ghanaians who are being prosecuted to provide legal services. The Mission has also alerted Ghanaian border authorities to enhance efforts to curb the flow of Ghanaians through our land borders.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs would, therefore, encourage all Ghanaians to acquaint themselves with the evolving modus operandi of these QNET scammers and assist in creating awareness in their families and communities.

In conclusion, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is appreciative of the collaboration it has with other MDAs in Ghana and the authorities in Côte d'Ivoire in taking joint action towards tackling this menace, which is causing significant financial strain and emotional stress on affected Ghanaians and their families. The Ministry will continue to take necessary measures to ensure the

public is well informed on this fraudulent scheme and ways to avoid becoming victims. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Ntekuni: Mr Speaker, I have no supplementary question. I want to thank the Minister for his answers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We will move to the Question numbered 330 standing in the name of Hon Frank Asiedu Bekoe. You have the floor.

Mr Bekoe: Mr Speaker, with your leave I rise to advert our minds to Order 88(4) which says,

“The answer to a Question shall, whenever practicable, be printed and a copy delivered to the Member asking the Question not less than fifteen minutes before the time fixed for the sitting at which the Question is to be answered.”

Conspicuously missing in the *Order Paper* is my answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, turn to page 15 of the *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr Bekoe: I do not have a copy. It is not there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Member, it appears it is just a repetition of the Question.

Mr Bekoe: The people of Suhum should be respected. Conspicuously missing in the *Order Paper*—

8:43 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, who is showing you the disrespect? Is it the Minister for Foreign Affairs or the Clerk? Hon Member, you said the people of Suhum should be respected. Who is showing disrespect to the people of Suhum?

Mr Bekoe: Mr Speaker, I feel that my answer should be captured.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, resume your seat. We should all be guided in the language that we use on the floor.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am sure it was an oversight. He did not know. He actually came to ask me and I had not seen it until the Minister also —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I do not have a problem. That is a problem which we are all trying to address. I am particular about the language used that people of Suhum should be respected. The question, therefore is, what has anybody done to show disrespect to the people of Suhum?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we apologise and withdraw.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Question that the Hon Member has asked, I believe, is to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs, the psycho-social support the Ministry has taken to help the Foreign Service workers/Diplomats and their families who were asked to leave Ghana embassy in Washington impromptu. What has this got to do with the people of Suhum? The Question is not about the people of Suhum. If it was a constituency-specific Question, then you could even relate it to the people of Suhum and say that somebody is trying to disrespect them. The Question is about Washington, D.C. and he is claiming that the people of Suhum are being disrespected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, I am tempted to give the floor to the Hon Member to do the needful.

Mr Bekoe: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Withdraw.

Mr Bekoe: I withdraw.

With that established and with your leave, Mr Speaker, I will go ahead and ask my Question.

Psycho-Social Support for Diplomats and Families Affected by the Impromptu Closure of the Ghana Embassy in Washington

Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (NPP — Suhum): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the psycho-social support the Ministry has taken to

help the Foreign Service workers/Diplomats and their families who were asked to leave Ghana embassy in Washington impromptu.

Mr Ablakwa: I thank you very much, Mr Speaker, and I commend my Colleague for the Question.

Pursuant to the findings of a special audit team that I constituted following allegations of malpractices involving officers at the Washington, D.C. Mission, I directed the recall of all officers at the Washington mission and caused a forensic audit to be undertaken by the Audit Service. Initial reports submitted by the Audit Service indicate substantial amounts of money involved, and there are currently ongoing investigations into the IT systems, passports, and visa equipment to ascertain the full details.

Pursuant to Chapter 4(13.3) of the Foreign Service Regulations (FSR), which stipulates that: “all officers, including ambassadors, shall undergo briefing and debriefing before and after their tour of duty in Ghana Missions abroad”, the affected officers who were recalled were subsequently taken through a debriefing session. Mr Speaker, key actions taken include the debriefing sessions, which allowed them to share and reflect on their experiences at post, thereby enhancing their mental and emotional well-being.

Furthermore, on humanitarian grounds, an officer who was near term, was granted an extension to allow for delivery and postnatal recovery before

returning to Ghana. The officers concerned were also encouraged to schedule appointments with the Ministry’s clinical psychologist to assess any necessary emotional and wellness support.

Also, in addition to the statutory 10 days of disembarkation leave, the affected officers were granted an extended leave period to support their overall well-being and settling-in process. They have since assumed official duties at the Ministry. Subsequently, one officer has been reposted to our mission in Brussels. These interventions reflect the Ministry’s continued commitment to the welfare and well-being of the affected officers. Those found to have committed infractions have been queried.

Further recommendations to be considered by management, including the establishment of an anonymous channel such as an online suggestion box, provision of continual professional psychological support to the recalled officers. The Ministry has also extended investigations to cover all the officers who served at the mission from the time of the engagement of Mr Kwarteng with the Mission. The forensic audit of the Auditor-General will soon be made available to this House, as soon as it is received.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have a supplementary question?

Mr Bekoe: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Considering the issues surrounding their reposting, is the Ministry prepared to go public on those who did not cause any infractions?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

As I have indicated, the forensic report will be published and made available to this House. I agree that it is important that those who led us to this international embarrassment will have to be sanctioned, and they have to be named and shamed. That is why I support the work of the Public Accounts Committee, which this House has been doing for decades.

Also, those who the audit will determine are innocent and are not culpable, I think that it is also important that that distinction is made, so that they are not all lumped together. We are conscious of that and we will make sure that everybody's rights are protected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Bekoe: In the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 18th June, 2025, he promised to bring to this House the Report. When are we getting it?

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

As a former Chairperson of the Government Assurances Committee, I take assurances to this House very seriously because I know the consequences. And true to the pledge I made, the next day I promptly brought the audit report, which is available in this House. If you check with the Clerks-at-the-Table, they received it, and acknowledged receipt of the audit report.

So, Mr Speaker, it is in this House, and I did comply with the pledge I made.

Mr Bekoe: Mr Speaker, I thank the Minister for showing up.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 439, standing in the name of Mr Emmanuel Tobbin. The Member of Parliament for Anyaa Sowutuom.

Strategic Objectives and Resource Allocation for the Establishment of Ghana's New Mission in Hungary

Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (NPP — Anyaa Sowutuom): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration the strategic objectives the Ministry seeks to achieve through the establishment of a new Mission in Hungary and what resources have been allocated for its operationalisation.

8:53 p.m.

Mr Ablakwa: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member for his Question.

The decision to establish a fully operational Ghanaian Diplomatic Mission in Budapest, Hungary, was not merely an act of expanding our geographical footprint or simply planting a flag; it was a meticulously calculated strategic intervention designed to accelerate our nation's economic and political advancement.

We seek to anchor our economic and diplomatic interests firmly within the vital Central and Eastern European bloc, capitalising on Hungary's unique position as a gateway to the region and a willing partner in Ghana's national development agenda.

Mr Speaker, Hungary reopened its Embassy in Accra on 1st April, 2016, after a 30-year hiatus since 15th December, 1987, signalling a renewed commitment to Ghana-Hungary bilateral relations. This was part of the Hungarian Government's Southern Opening foreign policy programme to expand ties in sub-Saharan Africa, restoring its diplomatic Missions that had been closed since 1989.

Our decision to establish a Mission in Budapest is a reciprocal gesture, one that restores diplomatic symmetry and affirms Ghana's status as a responsive and strategically engaged partner in Central Europe.

The establishment of this Mission is fundamentally anchored on three strategic pillars, which align directly with Ghana's core foreign policy objectives of development, diplomacy, and enhancing global influence.

The foremost objective is to aggressively leverage Hungary's established industrial base and market access to the European Union (EU). The Mission will serve as a dedicated platform to execute a targeted economic diplomacy agenda. Specifically, we will be attracting Hungarian investments into Ghana's priority sectors, particularly our Free Zones, to accelerate industrialisation and job creation.

Hungary has demonstrated specific interest and expertise in areas such as chemical materials production, poultry operations, and agro-technology, which directly address our national priorities for reducing import dependency and modernising our agriculture sector under the Reset Agenda. Hungary also offers a robust manufacturing base, particularly in automotive and IT. We will use the Mission to actively target Hungarian businesses for investment in our priority sectors, including energy, infrastructure, and ICT.

Furthermore, the Mission will actively facilitate structured business matchmaking and engagement, working to increase the volume and diversity of our non-traditional exports such as cocoa products, cashews, and handicrafts, by establishing efficient trade corridors into Central and Eastern European markets. This positioning is strategically vital as

we seek to diversify our international investment partnerships beyond traditional sources.

Hungary has extended a credit facility of US\$100 million to Ghana, targeting critical sectors such as wastewater management, energy, agriculture, and infrastructure. A resident mission in Budapest will allow Ghana to negotiate, monitor, and implement these agreements with greater precision. It will also facilitate direct engagement with Hungarian development agencies and private sector actors, ensuring alignment with our national development priorities and building on existing agreements to support Ghana's development agenda.

The strategic partnership with Hungary's ANY Security Printing Company to produce Ghana's new chip-embedded passports underscores the potential for mutually beneficial collaboration, informing part of the decisions to establish a diplomatic presence in Budapest. A diplomatic presence in Budapest will enable us to deepen cooperation in cybersecurity, e-governance, security printing, and border management technologies. This aligns with Ghana's broader digital transformation agenda and enhances our institutional resilience.

On human capital development and knowledge transfer, Mr Speaker, a critical component of our strategy is maximising the benefits of the bilateral educational cooperation, particularly the prestigious Stipendium Hungaricum Scholarship programme. Hungary offers substantial opportunities in technical

education and specialised fields, notably medicine, engineering, and water management.

Mr Speaker, since 2016, over 750 Ghanaian students have benefitted from Hungarian government scholarships under the Stipendium Hungaricum programme, leading to a growing Ghanaian community in Hungary. The Mission will prioritise the efficient administration and maximisation of Ghana's over 200 scholarship slots offered annually.

This ensures that as many qualified Ghanaian students as possible benefit from tuition-free education, monthly stipends, and accommodation support, thereby building a pool of highly skilled human capital relevant to Ghana's industrial and technological needs.

The Mission will also serve as a coordination hub for scholarship administration, alumni engagement, and academic diplomacy. It positions Ghana to advocate for expanded quotas and tailored educational programmes that address our national skill gaps.

Beyond scholarships, the Mission will facilitate knowledge transfer by establishing partnerships for vocational training initiatives and technical skills development, using Hungarian expertise to strengthen our own educational and extension systems, especially in areas like sustainable farming, advanced irrigation techniques, engineering, medicine, and technology, to better align with the specific industrial and developmental needs of Ghana.

Strategically, the Mission enhances Ghana's political presence within the European Union and, crucially, the Visegrád Group (V4) made up of Hungary, Poland, Czechia, and Slovakia. Hungary is an influential member of the European Union and a key player in the Visegrád Group. This diplomatic seat allows Ghana to maintain a high-profile presence, providing a direct and influential channel to advocate for our national interests on trade, security, and global governance within this key European bloc.

It will also support our position on regional integration and collaboration. Establishing a Mission Hungary strengthens Ghana's multilateral diplomacy, trade negotiations, and access to European development instruments. It complements our Missions in Brussels and other European capitals, creating a more cohesive continental footprint.

Mr Speaker, Hungary has expressed interest in supporting African peacekeeping, migration management, and climate resilience. Ghana's Mission in Budapest will enable direct political dialogue on these themes, positioning Ghana as a continental voice on shared global challenges. It also supports our role in AU-EU engagements and South-South cooperation.

Equally important is the commitment to the Ghanaian diaspora. The Mission will provide essential, high-quality consular services, including passport services, visas, and emergency support, to over 1,000 Ghanaians residing in

Hungary and the surrounding Central European countries. This will eliminate the need for them to travel long distances to other Missions.

The Mission ensures the welfare and full participation of our nationals abroad in the national development agenda. The Mission will serve as a cultural outpost promoting Ghanaian heritage, tourism, and creative industries in Central Europe. It will also provide a formal channel for engaging the Ghanaian diaspora in Hungary and neighbouring countries, fostering national identity and remittance flows.

I now turn to the critical subject of resource allocation and the current operational status of our new Diplomatic Mission in Budapest, demonstrating the Ministry's commitment to equipping this strategic post for success.

The operationalisation of the new Mission is being executed with utmost fiscal prudence, leveraging existing budgetary allocations for the expansion of our diplomatic network. The Ministry has ensured a robust financial commitment to the Mission from the outset. As part of our 2025 Budget, an amount of GH¢1,233,488.32 per month has been allocated to the Hungary Mission's operations. This continuous funding ensures that the Mission has the necessary recurrent resources to maintain its functions.

Since the commencement of operations in July 2025, a substantial total amount of GH¢3,733,464.96 has already been released to the Mission as

of September 2025. This upfront release of funds has been crucial in accelerating the initial establishment phases, including securing accommodation and commencing essential legal and administrative processes.

The Mission is rapidly moving towards its full operational strength, although some key personnel are still in transit. Mr Speaker, because of time constraints, I will ask that the *Hansard* should capture the full staff establishment and the leadership of the Embassy which is led by His Excellency Dr Daniel Kwame Ampofo, a distinguished former Colleague of ours.

His Excellency Dr Daniel Kwame Ampofo, Ghana's Ambassador to Hungary, was commissioned on 1st October, 2025, and is expected to assume duty shortly. The approved staff strength for the Embassy is five diplomatic officers. Currently, three core officers have been posted and have already assumed duty: the Minister/Head of Chancery, the First Secretary, and the First Secretary/Account. The remaining two officers will be posted in due course to complete the diplomatic complement. The recruitment of local staff to complement the Mission's full strength is in process, with a request for approval of the local staff establishment having been sent to the Ministry.

On infrastructure and logistical achievements, Mr Speaker, significant progress has been made in establishing the physical presence and logistical backbone of the Mission since the team's arrival in July 2025, despite the

disruption caused by the official Hungarian vacation month of August.

The Ambassador's Residence and accommodation for the three posted officers have been successfully secured. The location for the Chancery has been identified, and the requisite legal processes for the contract signing are underway. The signed contract and necessary renovation works are expected to be completed by November 2025.

On logistics, Mr Speaker, the Mission has finalised the procurement of three vehicles, including the official representational vehicle, which are scheduled for delivery by the official agent by December 2025.

On administrative milestones, the team has successfully secured Diplomatic Identity Cards and residence permits, established bank accounts for financial transactions, and received six months' rent payment upfront, which were critical initial requirements for establishing legal and financial capacity in the host country. On staff welfare, we are also proactively arranging for a dedicated medical centre and exploring comprehensive health insurance options to ensure the well-being and security of all Mission staff.

The Ministry continues to work diligently with the team in Budapest to complete all remaining establishment processes, and we are grateful for the support received from all stakeholders, including this august House, which enabled the approval of the necessary budget proposals.

9:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in closing, the establishment of the Ghanaian Diplomatic Mission in Budapest is not an expenditure; it is a strategic investment. The Mission is a critical vehicle for advancing Ghana's national interests, specifically by accelerating our Economic Diplomacy drive, ensuring a sustainable pipeline of Human Capital Development through Hungarian scholarships, and solidifying our political influence within Central Europe and the EU.

With the necessary financial resources secured, including a robust monthly allocation and significant initial releases and a dedicated core diplomatic team already on the ground, the Mission is on track to be fully operational. The successful acquisition of residences, the near finalisation of the Chancery, and the procurement of logistics all testify to the diligence of our Ministry and staff.

We are confident that this Mission will yield substantial and quantifiable benefits for the people of Ghana. Opening new doors for trade, investment, and education, we will continue to provide this august House with regular updates on its progress as we complete its operationalisation by the end of this year.

I thank you, Mr Speaker and this august House for your continuous support and collaboration in securing Ghana's prosperity on the global stage.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Tobbin: No, Sir. I just want to thank the Minister for answering the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question Time has ended. I thank the Minister for Foreign Affairs for attending upon the House to respond to the Questions scheduled for him.

We are moving back to item numbered 8(a)—Continuation of the Commentary. I will proceed to give the floor to Dr Kwamena Minta Nyarku. You have 10 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

*[Resumption of debate from
Column 44]*

Dr Kwamena Minta Nyarku (NDC — Cape Coast North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Ghana for the 2026 financial year, under the theme, Resetting the Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation.

Mr Speaker, please allow me to make some preliminary comments. Submissions from some Members of the other Side drew my attention to two different issues, and I want to address that, please.

The first one is about the Office of the Special Prosecutor. We all know that the Office was established under the previous Government, that is, His Excellency the Former President. Today, it was very interesting to hear Members of the other Side were calling for the Office to be scrapped. That clearly indicates that they were in a haste to come up with an Office that could not even generate any issues to be able to suffice the reason that it was established.

Mr Speaker, another Member called this Budget a *Kwashiokor* Budget, and it was very interesting to hear a Former Minister claiming that our Budget is a *Kwashiokor* budget. In their eight years in power, we all witnessed the cedi to the dollar ratio, we saw inflation, we saw issues concerning Agenda 111, we saw issues concerning One District, One Factory, we witnessed One Village, One Dam, and the One Million, One Constituency. They even wanted to build an airport in Cape Coast.

They came out with an ad hoc initiative, which is the Nation Builders Corps (NABCO). They came out with an unemployment rate of 13.4 per cent. In all these years, we did not label their Budget as a *Kwashiokor* budget. Today, Members on the other Side are claiming that a budget that has an overall growth of 6.3 per cent in 2025, compared to that of 2024, which was 5.1 per cent, cannot be deemed as a budget that is more prudent.

We have seen agriculture grow at 6 per cent. We see the services sector also grow at 8.8 per cent. Mr Speaker,

industry is growing at over 3.2 per cent. Households are spending more, we are exporting, and the Government is also spending less. That shows prudent and careful management of the public purse. I am surprised that those on the other Side of the aisle could not appreciate the fact that public debt has dropped from 69 to 45 per cent. This is the first drop in 10 years from today. That is something that they should appreciate.

This particular Budget is one I would say is *Obia b3 didi* Budget instead of the *Kwashiokor* Budget. The Budget talks about the 24-Hour Economy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, what is the meaning of *Obia b3 didi*?

Dr Nyarku: *Everybody go chop some.*
[Laughter]

Mr Speaker, the flagship programme of the NDC, which is a 24-Hour Economy, has been assigned GH¢110 million by the Government, and the goal is to create 1.7 million jobs. Unfortunately, when they introduced One District, One Factory, the One Million, One Constituency, the One Village, One Dam, cumulatively, they were unable to create 1.7 million jobs. If the 24-Hour Economy would create 1.7 million jobs, especially in areas of agriculture, manufacturing, logistics and services, then we should all be supportive.

Mr Speaker, I am of the view that the 50 initiatives that the 24-Hour Economy is targeting, such as government,

transport, air cargo facilities and agro-industrial goods, are areas that we should all contribute to and support in ensuring that many of our youth who are currently unemployed will have access to jobs.

Mr Speaker, when we go to page 68, paragraph 471 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, if I may read, it says,

“Mr Speaker, illegal mining remains an existential threat. The Government has declared critical water bodies and forest reserves as high-security zones. All Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation 2026 Budget 69 importers of excavators now require prior approval from the Ministry of Transport, verified by shipping lines and Customs. The Minerals Commission has begun installing GPS tracking on heavy equipment for real-time monitoring.”

Mr Speaker, I am picking on this particular paragraph mainly because I want us to appreciate the fact that the current President has taken good initiatives to be able to fight *galamsey*. The Budget also wants us to appreciate the fact that one commitment that this particular Government has taken is the initiation to be able to ensure that we are going to repeal L.I. 2462, which has already been revoked, and as I speak now, people have not been given any permission to go and mine in any of the forest reserves.

This Government has taken the step to set up the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS),

which is to ensure that all *galamsey* operations across the country are dismantled.

Mr Speaker, the Government has placed a permanent military presence in 44 *galamsey* hotspots across the country. They have also initiated geofencing and geo-tracking of all excavators, as I initially reiterated, to ensure that illegal mining is not done in Ghana. The Government has repossessed nine forest zones, which are declared as a no-go area under the NPP regime, and the Government is now ensuring that no one will mine in these respective nine forest zones.

If I recall, Mr Speaker, the Former President was saying that he was going to put his presidency online if he failed to fight *galamsey*. Unfortunately, the time that he declared was the time that they were able to register 1,990 companies to mine across legitimately and illegally. According to the Ghana Mining Repository, from 1988 to December 2016, only 19 licences of various types of companies were registered to mine. That would indicate the fact that even though the Former President was asserting that he was willing to fight *galamsey*, his actions proved otherwise.

Page 69, paragraph 473 of the Budget also states that;

“Mr Speaker, to formalise small-scale mining, the Government launched the Responsible Cooperative Mining and Skills Development Programme

(rCOMSDEP) in August 2025. Three cooperative schemes, namely, Obuasi, Bibiani, and Anwia-Teleku Bokazo, have been launched to promote responsible mining and rehabilitation.”

Mr Speaker, I would like to pick up on the last bit, which talks about the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA). Page 72, paragraph 497 of the Budget, again states that

“The Environmental Protection Agency issued over 13,000 environmental permits, monitored more than 12,000 projects, and restored nearly 4,000 hectares of degraded land. The new Environmental Protection Act, 2025, gives the EPA stronger enforcement powers and establishes the Ghana Carbon Office to implement carbon market projects.”

Mr Speaker, I am very happy and I want to ensure that we push and support this Budget, and also assist the EPA to advocate, educate and work across the country to fight the depletion of our environment, minimize *galamsey* and also to improve the unemployment situation across the country. Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to present this case. [*Hear! Hear!*]

9:13 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, very much. I will then proceed to give the floor to Mr Charles Owiredi. Hon Member, you are speaking for 15 minutes.

Yes?

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central): Mr Speaker, people are not concerned about your health, but I am. It is past 9 o'clock. It is past 9:00 p.m., Mr Speaker, and that may not— the Rt Hon Speaker is not here and the Second Deputy Speaker is not here, and we have sat throughout this afternoon. I think I am concerned, and I think that we need to be— We can continue tomorrow. That is my prayer. The time is far spent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Anyimadu-Antwi, I appreciate your concerns but I just do not want to place on record the message that I have given you. He is our last speaker.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Charles Asuako Owiredi (NPP — Abirem): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Budget as read by the Hon Minister for Finance. At the onset, let me say that in terms of elegance, the Minister for Finance looked elegant in his Italian suit matched with an Italian silk tie. But in terms of substance, I have issues with some of the statements that he made on Thursday, 13th November, 2025.

Mr Speaker, in terms of job creation, we all know that the anchor of NDC's victory in the last elections had to do with the promise they made to Ghanaians that they will be creating enough jobs for the teeming youth of Ghana, to the extent that they suggested this 1-3-3 formation. In paragraph 1182, it is stated clearly that

under the 2026 Budget, the NDC government looks to create about 800,000 jobs at the end of 2026. They go further by breaking these 800,000 jobs down. If you check paragraph 1183, they make mention of 490,000 to come from road construction. Here, they are talking about labourers for road construction.

If you check paragraph 1185, they also state that 20,000 will come from jobs in the garment industry. Again, if you check paragraph 1186, they again make the claim that they will get 700 jobs from the agro-processing sector. Then when you come to paragraph 1187, they say they are going to create 250,000 jobs in the oil palm development policy that they intend bringing up.

So, when you do this addition—I just did this, like people say, is it arithmetic or algebra? I just did basic addition. When you add these figures together, you are at a total figure of 760,000. So clearly, there is a shortfall, from 800,000 to 760,000, meaning there is a shortfall of about 40,000. I do not know where they are going to generate the figures to fill in this gap.

Again, on the issue of the one million Coders programme, we all know that this was a key campaign issue in the last general elections. The NDC promised that they were going to get enough youth, register them, and then train them under this coders programme. They plan to train one million people. Last year, for the 2025 Budget, when we saw that they earmarked about GH¢100 million for the training of 100,000 youth, we all thought that, okay, this is a first step, so

let us wait for 2026. In 2026, the anticipation was that if you have reduced the number from one million to 900,000, simple division will tell you that if they train 300,000 in 2026, 300,000 in 2027, and 300,000 in 2028, they will exhaust the one million Coders programme that they have planned to train the youth in. When we heard the Minister speak, I was surprised, because for the 2026 Budget, again, the Minister is repeating GH¢100 million for the same 100,000 people, meaning that now there is going to be a backlog of close to 800,000 youth who are yet to be trained. From the way it is going, as they say, *agorɔ be sɔ a na efiri anɔpa*.

Again, it is clear that the NDC Government does not prioritise issues of the youth. They say one thing, and then they come to do something different. When it comes to rural telephony, for 2025, we all know that in our communities, most of us here are MPs representing rural constituencies. I come from Aberim; it is a rural constituency, and most of the areas lack connectivity. People cannot even make calls in most of the towns in my Constituency. I know because I have had a lot of discussions with my Colleagues here, most of them tell me that in their communities, they cannot make calls. That is why the NDC, when in 2025, earmarked GH¢100 million to connect the communities that are underserved, we all thought that, if this is a start, let us look forward to it, because even the GH¢100 million was not enough. We have so many communities out there that are waiting to be connected. In this year's Budget, instead of increasing the quantum of

money that has been earmarked for this project, they have rather reduced the amount from GH¢100 million to GH¢30 million. From GH¢100 million to GH¢30 million, Mr Speaker. When you do this, where lies your commitment to the people in the rural communities? I really believe that the NDC Government, led by H.E. the President, is shortchanging the people in the rural communities. If we are really sincere about getting them connected, we will not give them this paltry with GH¢30 million.

Mr Speaker, in paragraph 369, and with your permission, I want to read:

“Mr Speaker, through sustained diplomacy, Ghana successfully negotiated the restoration of five-year multiple-entry U.S. visas for Ghanaian citizens, a major relief for frequent travellers and the diaspora community.”

Mr Speaker, this, to me, should not be in the Budget, because it is not an achievement. We bequeathed a country to you where citizens of Ghana were able to apply and secure five-year United States of America (USA) multiple visas. They come in, and then by whatever means, the USA Government says that due to one reason or the other, we want to restrict the issuance of five-year USA multiple visas to you. They decide to go and negotiate with the USA Government. After the negotiation, they came back to tell us that we should hail them, we should clap for them because they have done something that has never happened before. Mr Speaker, they are

forgetting that when we handed over the reins of government to them, Ghanaians were receiving five-year multiple USA visas.

9:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, what even makes me laugh is this coordination, that the very moment our Minister for Foreign Affairs announced that the decision had been reversed, President John Dramani Mahama, also announced that henceforth Ghana will be receiving deportees from the United States of America. Mr Speaker, when we sit down and analysis this situation, it tells us clearly that there was a barter trade somewhere. *Quid pro quo*.

Mr Speaker, just last week, the Government of Eswatini, led by their Minister of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation, addressed their Parliament. Their Minister said that from that arrangement they had with the USA Government, they got US\$5.1 million. Again, Mr Speaker, the Rwandan Government, their Minister of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation, has also come out to say, per this same arrangement, they have also received close to US\$7 million. My question is, how much did Ghana receive for this arrangement? If we did not receive anything, then our money is stuck somewhere and they should go for their money.

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, our rules are very clear. We cannot impugn improper motives. He cannot say that because, coincidentally, at a time when the USA eased the visa restrictions on Ghana, and then it was followed by a decision by Ghana to receive ECOWAS citizens being deported from the US. Then after, he is imputing that there is some *quid pro quo* between Ghana and the US, and therefore he is suggesting that Ghana traded the receipt of the ECOWAS citizens for the easing of visa restrictions on Ghanaian citizens. I think that that is not within our rules, so if he could just withdraw that and then continue with his debate, it will be in order.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do the needful.

Mr Owiredù: Mr Speaker, I withdraw the impugning of the motive. I am guided, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, in paragraph 990, and with your permission, I read:

“Ghana Airport Company Limited will introduce an airport development fee to rehabilitate Sunyani Airport, construct a new airport at Bolgatanga, and build a multi-purpose car park and a connecting concourse between Terminals 2 and 3 at the Kotoka International Airport.”

Mr Speaker, airline passengers, are very sensitive to price increase. This airport development levy is going to lead to an increase in the cost of tickets. Mr Speaker, when this happens, two things

will happen. Domestically, already, we have issues where a lot of Ghanaians are complaining that the charges of Africa World Airlines (AWA) and Passion Air are such that they cannot even afford it, to the extent that they all prefer travelling by road. We will end up killing domestic tourism if we continue in this trajectory.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to international tourism, again, West Africa is noted for having the highest cost of tickets globally. A lot of people complain that when they are travelling within West Africa, the cost is such that they cannot even bear. Ghana is noted to be one of the countries that charges the highest when it comes to ticketing.

So, this thing of “Year of Return” and “Dettý December”, where the former President, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo went out there, preached, to a lot of Ghanaians and people in the diaspora who started visiting Ghana.

This policy is going to be negated if we go according to the plan as put forward by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, again, I have issues with this US\$500 million oil palm policy. The reason is that, in most of these communities that grow oil palm, when we speak to the farmers, they tell us that people who practice *galamsey* come to them to buy their lands to go search for gold. To the extent that now we have situations where people are ready to sell their one-acre plot of land for GH¢15,000. This issue of *galamsey* would have to be dealt with. Other than

that, this US\$500 million would go down the drain.

Again, I know that Mr President, in trying to avoid a calling for a state of emergency, decided to form the NAIMOS. NAIMOS is doing its job, but Mr Speaker, we know that it is difficult to fight this issue of *galamsey*. Ghana's Attorney-General and Minister for Justice held a press conference and said that he has reports that the NDC national officers were involved in *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General of Ghana made this statement, so it tells us that the situation is such that if the President does not call for a state of emergency, this matter will not go away. So, I am calling on the President to kindly call for a state of emergency, so that we tackle this menace that is affecting our society.

Mr Speaker, I will be remiss if I fail to comment on the unconscionable US\$1.2 billion, or the over GH¢13 billion decision of the NDC government to purchase two presidential jets. We were told by the current Minister for Foreign Affairs that the current presidential jet is in pristine condition. Mr Speaker, if we now have a presidential jet that has just returned from France and is in pristine condition, why on earth—[*Interruption*]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, thank you very much. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he repeated a misrepresentation that was corrected earlier in the day, and you gave a ruling on. Earlier in the day, the question of the planned budgetary allocation for retooling the Air Force over a four-year period was exhaustively debated. Indeed, even though it was presented that the figure is US\$1.2 billion in fact, if we add the figures, which I took my time to do, and use the current exchange rate to do the conversion, it is not even up to US\$900 million. They can go and add the figures and do the conversion. This is something that has been planned for a period of four years.

This year's budgetary allocation is just about US\$250 million, and it is not for the purchase of a presidential jet. It is for the retooling of the Air Force, which includes the purchase of helicopters and other aircraft, and all the other ancillary equipment to retool the Air Force. That is why the Speaker ruled earlier that you should not make that misrepresentation.

But, Mr Speaker, I do not know if you were momentarily paying attention to something else. He repeated it so I want that struck off the record so that we can —

9:33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, accordingly, that is said to be expunged from the records.

Ms Appiagyei: I think we have gone over this issue over and over again. We respect your ruling, though. But I believe that it has been made very clear that the long span is always a commercial jet that

is purchased for the presidency. We explained it over and over again.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minority Leader, is it fair and just that a matter that I ruled on as a result of disrespect to the Chair, whatever I rule on should be repeated?

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I am telling you and informing you, yes, we respect your ruling, all right. But your ruling was that the figure that was mentioned should be expunged from the records. But what is of interest is whether the long span is a presidential jet or not. That is the issue. That is the whole issue at the end of the day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, I will say this for the last time. If you are sitting at the front and your Leader has the opportunity to speak, it is not fair and just after the Leader, I should give you the opportunity to also speak. This courtesy must be extended to our Leaders. That is why the Leaders speak last. This is not the first time I have made this assertion.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the edification. Save that my Leader or any Leader can be on their feet and may not advert his or her mind to a particular issue. The moment you call the Leader's attention; you may

trigger the Leader off from the tangent he or she was leaning to. That is why we are in Leadership respectfully, we may have just thought of something, and may want to bring it.

So, Mr Speaker, I think that because you are rude, I do not want to belabour the point, but to say that if the Majority Leader is asking that some parts of my Colleague's submission be expunged, I think that because you may have ruled earlier, it was to the effect that you were talking about the amount. It was not to the effect of the description or the narration, as in whether or not there were two presidential jets and four other jets.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, I think you are completely out of order. Resume your seat. Hon Members, there is nothing wrong when you quote what is in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. It would not be wrong.

Hon Members, by the power vested in the Speaker, by Standing Order 56 (2), we have done more than five hours of continuous Sitting. I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 9.38 p.m. till Thursday, 20th November 2025, at 12.00 noon.

